Adopting Adora

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/27051928.

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Not Rated

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Angella/Micah (She-Ra), Adora & Angella (She-Ra), Adora & Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Catra & Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Adora & Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

Character:
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Additional Tags:
Autistic Adora (She-Ra), Angella is best mom, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)'s A+ Parenting, Implied/Referenced Child Abuse, Child Neglect, Autism Spectrum, Therapy, Emotional/Psychological Abuse, Family, Adoption

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Adopting Adora

by GarbageFanfics

Summary

Angella and Micah pursue adoption after failing to get pregnant. After battling to adopt their new child. Angella realizes her new daughter needs a lot more than what she originally thought.

Re-write to Autistic and Adopted.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

The first step

Life is good for the brighten family. Years of hard work, two poor Yale students surviving off scholarships, waiting tables, and fixing cars paid off in the form of two high paying careers, a beautiful house in a great community, a beautiful daughter and now the hopes of adding another baby into their lives was hopefully soon on the horizon. Angella and Micah were trying—trying really hard for a new baby. Pills, vitamins, special workouts, tracking ovulation, and more extravagant methods in the bedroom have led them to become more and more defeated when every other week another test would come back as negative for pregnancy. It was heartbreaking….. especially for Angella. The birth of their firstborn came so quickly and easily in the beginning stages of their marriage they felt that having one or two more children after her would be just as easy, but now with Glimmer turning six, time felt like it was slipping. They weren't an old couple by any means, but they were older than other parents. Angella having Glimmer in her early twenties while still finishing her mentorship to being a plastic surgeon, she still had her worries. If they didn't have another baby soon, they would miss their window for having a perfectly healthy baby.

Now the two sat in a cold Obstetrician office to hear the final words from a doctor to tell them what the next step for them can be.

The female doctor arrived and asked them "Mr. and Mrs. Brighten, how are you two feeling today?" sitting down in the chair across from them. Both greeted her and assured they were feeling okay. She flips through her notes and informed them. "We received all the test results back and I want to inform you what may be the next steps in your plans"

Both nodded. Nervously Angella reached for Micah's hand for comfort. In her own research, she theorized the worst possible outcome. The fear that she is unable to conceive terrified her as a woman. To have her money, her status, and lifestyle, it would be the cruelest thing God could do to her to have her be unable to care for another child. She turned to Micah with a worried look in her eyes as he gripped her hand firmly and gave her an assuring look.

Now with their eyes focused on the doctor, she gave them the disheartening news.

"After reviewing both results, it shows that you, Angella, are unable to conceive……." She said sadly. Angella's face fell. Her heart sank at the news. After all the vitamins, yoga, blood tests, uncomfortable gynecologists visits, she was barren!? Unable to have children at the age of thirty?

Turning to Micah with tears in her eyes, her husband suggested "Do we have options for a surrogate?" he questioned. Though an innocent suggestion, it felt like salt in an opened wound for Angella. Her world was just shattered, and Micah flippantly offered for another woman to carry their child?

The Doctor across from them shook her head "Micah your test results that your sperm count is too low for surrogate options. If you two have blood-related siblings to share DNA with, then…. Possibly" she offered with a shrug.

Angella winced in discomfort on that idea. Micah had his adventurous lesbian sister sleeping around with every girl in the county, and Angella was an only child with only her parents as different living relatives.

Judging by the look of discomfort and sadness on the couple's faces, it was clear that was not a realistic option. The doctor softly replied with "I'm sorry, but further progress will not do you two any good. This has been a five-year-long struggle and I'd hate to see you two spend another five years on this pursuit"

Angella let her head fall on Micah's shoulder as she fought back tears. He asked the doctor. "What are our options now?"

She answered even softer than before "Have you two considered to adopt?"

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On the drive home the two sat in sadness and silence. Micah drove and in the corner of his eye kept glancing over to Angella. Wiping the tears from her eyes, she bravely tried to remain calm after hearing the bad news. It was a terrible feeling. Despite keeping it a secret from anyone else, it still had a tint of shame to it. Facing all their friends who had multiple children, having Glimmer be an only child. Glimmer was very vocal about her displeasure of being an only child. Asking her mother why she doesn't have a little brother or sister was hearting for Angella.

He asked his wife "You think if I keep taking those pills it will possibly help my sperm count?"

She shook her head "There's no point in that my love….." she sighed "I'm unable to conceive…."

He patted her shoulder "We can still try" he turned his attention back to the road and said "We made Glimmer, I'm sure we can make Micah Jr." he smiled. Glancing over to Angella he saw that his comment was ill-timed as she starting to softly sob into a tissue. Once they got into their driveway, he tried to pull her into an embrace, but she rejected it and got out of the car in a huff. Slamming the passenger side door, she went up to the front stairway. Micah gulped as he stuttered out "I—I'm going to get Glimmer from George and Lance, I—I'll see you in a little bit"

He left and she stormed off to her room to weep.

Micah never felt more guilty in his life. He knew Angella too well and knew she was going to beat herself up over this. Blame herself and become depressed. It broke his heart.

The second he got into George and Lance's driveway he saw them sitting on their porch waiting to greet him. His little Glimmer already had her backpack and she rushed to the car "Daddy!" she cried as she ran to hug him. He returned the embrace and lighter her up "Hey baby girl! How was your day?" he asked. She giggled and pointed "Look at Bow!" peering over he saw the little guy with a plastic bow and arrow playset.

Bow ran offer triumphantly and declared “I’m gonna be an archer!”

Micah raised a brow “Really buddy? That’s cool. But didn’t you want to be spiderman last week?”

George walked over and replied, “He lost interest, and he ripped his suit….” Looking down at his son her shyly smiled at him.

Micah chuckled and got Glimmer into the car. He thanked George and Lance and then left. He didn’t want to tell them the bad news yet. As his friends, they were rooting for him and Angella to have another child. Judging by his slightly saddened face, they could tell without asking that the news wasn’t what they wanted.

They made a quick stop before heading home. Micah bought Angella a large bouquet with a note saying, “To the best wife and mother in the world” and bought Glimmer a candy.

Upon coming home, Angella was still locked away in the bedroom crying. Micah lied to Glimmer and told her that mommy had a tummy ache and she’ll tuck her in for bedtime later.

Entering the bedroom, he presented to her the gift “Angie?” he called to her. He sat next to her on the bed as she laid under the

covers. Her makeup now smudged as she sniffled “You—you didn’t have to do all this Micah”

He gently caressed her face and tried to wipe the tears from her eyes “Angie I wanted to” he replied.

She tried to hold back her sob as she whimpered “I don’t deserve you” she sat up. Wiping her face. He embraced her. “Angie….”

She looked at him and asked “Adoption? Is that something you’re okay with?”

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5-months later

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It was time to see their potential daughter at the foster home. Only a ten-mile drive into the most unpleasant part of town. Horde Grove. The slum littered with garbage, graffiti, and abandoned old brick factory mills that were decaying in the cityscape. It was a strange turn from where they were from. Not too far away were gated communities and the States' best shopping outlet and tourist destinations. Regardless of the less

than ideal location, this was where the social worker said the best foster mother in the State lived and cared for multiple children in an old bed and breakfast she acquired. The woman took in teens, small children, handicapped children, and all troubled adolescence. Sue Weaver must be an absolute saint! Her portfolio is one hell of an indication of it. She was a former schoolteacher, a member of the peace corps. And even in her later years, she turned her family's 10-bedroom bed and breakfast into a safe place for children in need of the entire Etheria County.

Both assuming they were heading into a storybook-like atmosphere was slowly brought down into reality as one turns down the street showed the row of beat down houses and convenience stores with bars on the windows. It was a clear indication they shouldn't have driven the BMW in this area, as dirty looks from onlookers in the neighborhood showed they were not welcomed.

Pulling into the driveway was just as lackluster. The former B&B looked tired and worn down. The yard was littered with outdoor toys, a half-dismantled camping tent, and a bike tire. Walking upstairs to the door they noticed the cracks in the concrete stairs and the sounds of yelling. They were greeted by a teenage boy with acne and a green-dyed mohawk.

"Sup," he said.

Micah and Angella looked at each other with confusion as Micah returned with "Sup, we're here to meet Sue Weaver. Is she available?"

The teen questioned, “You guys here for Adora?”

Angella answered “Yes we are”

His eyes widened as he commented, “Wow, you sound like your from Harry Potter” he chuckled and opened the door fully. Angella tried to show humor in his comment and declared “I get that a lot” before entering they saw the living room looking disheveled. More toys, empty sippy cups of juice, and blankets around the room. Angella noted the smell of cigarette smoke and the bitter odor of dirty clothes. Frowning, Angella looked over to Micah to see his discomfort. Their expectations were shattered by this revelation that the foster home looked so unkept.

The teenager yelled up the stairs “Sue! The people for Adora are here!”

A raspy deep female voice yelled back “Bring them to the dining room! Adora is waiting for them!”

The boy escorted them down a narrow hallway to the dining room. The most well-kept room is to be seen. A large wooden table and buffet table to the corner adjacent to an antique breakfast hutch. Sitting at the table were two little girls. One child with mismatch colored eyes, tan skin, freckles, and thick wild brown hair. The other was hopefully their soon to be a daughter. A beautiful little blonde girl with bright blue eyes. The little girl met eyes with Angella’s. The two stared at each other for a moment as Adora rocked slightly back and forth in her chair and said “Your pretty” to Angella. Angella smiled back and sat next to

her "You pretty too, Adora" she said softly. The ice was broken and Angella felt more relaxed. She sat next to Adora and got a better look at the child. Six-years old, tall for her age, skinny, missing one of her baby teeth in the front of her mouth and was absolutely precious. Adora had her right hand clasped to her friend's hand as her friend spoke "I'm Carlotta! I'm Adora's best friend!" Adora turned to her and back to Angella and nodded in agreement. Micah sat next to Carlotta and noticed how poorly dressed the other girl was compared to Adora. While Adora had a clean white shirt on with red lining on the sleeves, the other child had a more faded red shirt on with a rip on the color and a whole in the right sleeve.

For Micah, his heart ached more for the Hispanic girl; as clearly Adora was dressed in better clothes for the meeting, while it was evident to him as a family attorney that these children were clearly neglected in some ways.

He looked over to Angella, who was in absolute awe with Adora, as the little blonde began to ramble on about herself. "I like to draw—I—I—like ponies, and I, And I, And I, l—like reading," she turned to Carlotta as her friend chimed in "She's the best reader" she turned back to Angella with a proud smile "Y-yeah! I'm the best reader!" she beamed, starting to rock more nervously. The precious little sweetheart was a little shy. Angella smiled at her and Carlotta. Finding it so sweet that her little friend was here to support Adora during this. It felt ask if Carlotta was helping to sell the idea that Adora was perfect for adoption. Judging by her voice, Angella could tell Adora had a slight speech impediment. A slight stutter and lisp. Something common with children who have delayed development. Something she noted was not disclosed in Adora's adoption profile. She was a sweet child, but it didn't take Angella or Micah too long to figure out something was a little off with Adora.

Before more could be said the presence of another adult entered the room. Sue Weaver. A tall olive-skinned woman with long dry black hair, an aged face with a visible scar over the right side of her lip. Her slender tall frame and unsettling gaze made it clear this woman who was deemed a saint by the adoption agency was a little less than to be desired. Micah felt a chill of uncomfortable familiarity as she entered the room. Without greeting anyone else she snapped in Spanish to the other child.

"Catra! ¡Te dice que no los molestaras!" she barked. The tan child fearfully jumped up and ran out of the room as she entered it. Another angry shout came from Sue as she turned to see the child standing at the end of the hall "Quédate fuera, pequeño monstruo"

Angella in Micah looked at her with disbelief. Unknowing to Sue Micah spoke Spanish fluently and referring to a child as a *little monster* was not the most inviting thing to say.

Sue gained her composure and welcomed them "Mr. and Mrs. Brighten! Thank you so much for waiting for me, I'm sure Adora kept you company" turning her gaze to Adora the child turned her body to face Sue and give her a response "Yes Sue I'm telling them that I'm a really good girl"

Sue smiled and sat across from them. Her smile was unsettling as she praised Adora "Excellent my child, you know what happens to good, and cute children, right?"

Adora turned to Angella, and in a disturbing and almost fear-inducing creed recited "Good and cute children get adopted"

A chill ran through Angella's spine at that remark. It felt so disturbingly familiar to her own childhood. Angella was a child who spent most of her adolescence at boarding schools ran by abusive nuns and would come home to abusive parents. Micah's childhood was no walk in the park either. He and his sister were raised by a single mother who boarded on homelessness their entire lives until they went into the group homes to suffer more abuse. Seeing Adora's condition made it clear, this child was not in the best environment. No matter what it takes, how much money, and however long this will be, they will adopt this little girl.

The meeting continued and was unsettling from beginning to end. As they left Adora ran over to embrace Angella. Happy to have met her.

Angella couldn't deny the embrace and hugged the child back. The sweet little girl looked up at her and asked "Did you like me? Do you want to keep me?"

Another strange declaration.

Before Angella could respond appropriately to that question. Sue declared "Adora! We talked about this. It will take time," she then

glared at Angella and commented "We can't be sure that they aren't like, *the rest*"

With that. The meeting was over. Micah talked a little with the teenage boys while Angella followed Adora outside to see Carlotta and the other children her age. It was heartbreaking, all the children looked dirty and thin.

Leaving them all made the Brighten's uneasy. On the drive home, Micah commented "One of the teenagers tried to sell me weed"

Angella turned to him and remark "Are you serious?"

He nodded "Yeah, then he offered me Vicodin"

Angella leaned back in her seat and groaned "Those poor children. Living in that dirty house"

He offered "I really got a bad vibe from that Sue lady, what about you?"

Angella agreed "She was not as pleasant as the social worker said"

Micha scoffed "Our social worker forgot our meeting and didn't call us until today to tell us to go meet Sue alone. I doubt any other foster home is any better in the State.

Angella became lost in thought over what Sue said: "We can't be sure that they aren't like, *the rest*" what on earth can that mean? Has Adora and those other children been up for adoption before and things not fall through? It was so disturbingly ominous that say something like that in front of a child. A sweet and precious child that deserves a good home. Her mind went back to Adora and a smile came over her face.

Micah questioned "Angie?"

Angella smiled as she answered "She hugged me. She was so happy to meet us, she really had a special glow to her"

Micah smiled too "She really is a special girl, isn't she?"

Angella agreed "Yes, she really is"

They looked at each other and at the same moment agreed "We need to adopt her"

Adopting

Chapter Summary

Angella gets to know Adora more while Sue grows bitter and jealous.

The routine of a foster child was not as glamourous as the routine of a child with parents. Adora shares a twin bed with her best friend Catra. Lonnie shares a bed with another girl, and the teenagers have their bedroom and their beds. So do the boys. In a house of four elementary school children and five high school-aged children, time was scarce in the home. They woke early every morning. It was the job of the teenagers to wake up the smaller kids so Sue can sleep in. The teens resent Sue deeply, so they take their frustration out on the younger kids.

The oldest teen girl opens the door to the younger girls' room violently and shouts "Get up turds!" before slamming the door closed. All four girls jump in fear as they leave their beds. They know not to upset the teens. If Sue wakes up they are in big trouble. The four assemble to the bathroom. All to take turns going potty. No modesty in this house. One girl pees, while another one jumps in the shower real quick to wash up. The cycle goes perfectly as Adora and Catra double up in the bath to wash their face, body, and hair before jumping out to grab their towels and run back to the bedroom to get changed. They can hear the thumping of other movements in the house. The house was once a bed and breakfast owned by Sue Weaver's family. The six-bedroom, four-bathroom home had lost much of its equity and luster over the years. A crashing economy killed the areas tourist attractions as many shops and attractions closed up. Leaving a row of vacant homes and business in its wake.

To the girls, this was the only thing they knew. The neighborhood wasn't pretty, but it was what they had. Just like this home and the routines they lived every day, it was all they had. After dressing and combing their hair they went downstairs for breakfast. Depending on which teenagers turn was breakfast duty, it was either eggs, granola bars, or cereal.

Today there were no groceries, so it was dry cereal. Cereals in a bowl with a spoon full of sugar and no milk. As Sue calls this time the end of the month special. For the kids, this meant school lunch is the best meal they will have today because dinner won't be anything special. If they are lucky it will be peanut butter sandwiches or pasta tonight.

They all leave for the bus stop and by luck, no one bothers Sue. Or so they thought. One of the bigger boys tells Catra to go upstairs to Sue's room before leaving. When she comes back from upstairs she is crying. She walks over to Adora for comfort and cries "I got hit! I got a Pow-Pow because I didn't go to bed on time last night!" she sobbed into Adora's shoulder. The little blonde comforted her as best as she could. It made her sad. If her friends cry, she feels like crying too. No one else feels sad when Catra gets pow-pows (the euphemism Sue coined for her ritualistic abuse for the smaller children). Catra receives the most abuse. Sometimes for no reason. It's almost as if Catra is hated by Sue. It's strange, no one knows how she got Catra in the first place. All that is known about Catra is that Sue had her since she was a baby and knew her mother. Other than that, everyone else came from broken homes or dead parents. Adora's family died in a car accident. Lonnie was taken from her mother by child services, Kyle's mom was ruled unfit to parent by a court, Rogelio's parents were dead, and the others were all taken from broken homes. In their broken world with beatings, little food, tattered clothes, and timed showers, they all had nothing without

Sue. She was a heaven and hell all in one and they all had to think of that on their way to the bus stop.

This is not the same for Glimmer. A child born into a fairy-tale American home. Two working parents had time to love and care for her. She was woken up every morning softly by her father. She could walk to the bathroom with no worry and take a hot shower as long as she pleased. She had so many clothes to choose from as her mother made sure to keep her in style and everything she owned was clean, new, and fresh. Her pantry of snacks was lined with all her favorites. Her mother placed a breakfast down in front of her. Glimmer's favorite. Blueberry pancakes, an apple slice, and a cup of milk.

Her mother and father enjoyed her. Loved her. They sat with her for breakfast and talked with her about their day. Glimmer adored her parents. Her daddy was a lawyer, and her mommy was a doctor. They were good people that helped others and they were good parents. She was driven to school every day by her father and her lunch was made for her every day by mom with love. Her life was good and according to her parents, she might get a little sister soon. Not a baby, but a sister a year younger than her. All things looked well.

Micah left for work after dropping off Glimmer and Angella was off to her work. The ER Doctor was leaving her happy home to go to

Etheria County Hospital. She respected her work, despite it being hard and stressful, as a young doctor, she has seen death, disease, the mentally ill, and some of the worst patients known to mankind. None could compare to the resentment her staff had for her. Playfully and also prejudicially proclaiming *The British are Coming* when entering the workplace. Though, they didn't know she knew that. Angella was a strict and intense doctor, with no regards for nonsense, cliques, or games at work. With sick and hurt people, there was no room for error, and the lack of daisy nurses and receptionists loathed her for her lack of friendliness—minus, Jillian Michaels, and Hanna Johnson. They were the only two nurses that weren't fearful of her nor did they disrespect her. But that could all just be because they were the mothers to Glimmer's best friends.

Despite getting ready for a long day she kept her head up high. Regardless of everyone else, she knew her job was important and if these nurses couldn't get that, well, then they were of no matter to her. It must be tough to patriated, and that why she couldn't help but admire Sue Weaver, despite the unsettling first meeting, she must have her stress and structures that lead her through her day as Angella does. Imagine being a selfless caring and giving woman to children day in and day out. To give up her old career for one of the humblest of the kind. Sue must feel blessed for what she is doing. Protecting and raising those innocent souls.

Sue did not share this sentiment. In her mind, she felt cursed and trapped. Her day starts around 10 am, as she slumps out of bed to her private bathroom. To start her morning she goes to her mini-fridge and takes her vodka and orange juice mix and pours it into a tumbler glass for coffee and goes downstairs. She feels like a servant to these ungrateful bastards. Always the villain to them,

she started her day by cleaning up the bathrooms of dirty clothes, started some laundry, did the dishes, and started to pick up the house. Most days she would leave for the kids, but today she needed to do some extra cleaning work. The teens have been slacking, the checks for the little bastards are late from the state and there is barely any food. The last thing she wants to deal with is a social work visit. Each child is worth $600 a month to care for. Each child check goes to utilities and bills for the home. Since Sue does not work, all her reliance on keeping her life afloat is bastard children and donations. Losing one means losing money and teenagers come and go so quickly that Sue needs smaller children to stay as long as possible to make ends meet. This will all come crashing down if Adora goes. Not only will she hear the endless crying from her "Friends" but she will also need to find other solutions to make ends meet. Angella's desire for adopting Adora will through her whole life off balance soon.

She resented Angella just from the first meeting. She knew Angella would not back down from adopting Adora, and Adora was too stupid to realize she was going to be uprooted. Adora was a strange and simple child. She was well behaved and played well with other children. Her routines would be completely thrown off in the Doctor's lifestyle. Adora is no child that would fit in at a Country Club daycare, she runs, jumps plays in the mud, and talks to her stuffed animals. A smile tugged at Sue's lips at the idea of it all. Adora being miserable with Angella and begging to come back *home*. It would certainly devastate the pompous Brit.

Only time will tell when that day comes. The day she waves goodbye to Adora forever. One day all these kids will be gone, all the ungrateful pains in the asses, every last one of them. Except for Catra, she will stay with her. Hopefully long enough to help run the foster home into her older age, so Sue won't need to fret much when she gets too old. Catra owes her. The little monster

has been a thorn in her side since the day she was born. The angry memory of her beloved having a baby infuriated her. At the high of Sue's life, she was a teacher at a private school and running an Inn on the side along with her beautiful life partner. Then the economy crashed, the school shut down after allegations, and her partner informed her of an affair that left her pregnant. Her love died in childbirth and left her with the burden of a child. An absent father and worthless other family members made her the only option for this child. It worked out well, the news story and the flood of donations and kind words made Sue believe fostering was easy, so instead of claiming bankruptcy on the Inn she converted into an Inn into a foster home, in agony she realized children and social services were a nightmare. In her darkest moment when the Vodka ran out and the cigarettes were out, she would take it out on Catra, the damn child that started all this. If it wasn't for her, she would still have her Cy'ra.

When the children start to come home from school that is when she is even drunker. Feeling sick, hair a mess, and smelling like smoke and the musk of Vodka leaving through the pores. Snack time and homework time begins right after school. To another anger filling action. The idiot rooky social worker Octavia decides to call ten-minutes before arriving that Angella was coming over and wanted to bring Adora out for dinner. Great, just what she needed. To look like crap in front of the prim little Gucci sunglass-wearing tart. Oh—no, *Dr. Brighton!* She must remember her title. *Dr. Good for nothing shill to the corrupt medical system Brighton.*

It wasn't long until Angella arrived. In Dior purse, high fashion clothes. As if she just wanted to scream to the world that she was better than everyone. It didn't help that the pretentious pain drove up in a Black BMW. Of course, why wouldn't a doctor have such an overly expensive car?

It made her livid to see how happy Adora was to leave with her.

In Adora's little head this was amazing. This tall and pretty lady wants to be her new mommy—and—wants to take her out to dinner. She dashed up to her room with Catra to find an outfit. Something cute, like her Kingdom Hall clothes. They're best clothes were only worn on Sundays to Kingdom Hall. All children were practicing Jehovah's Witnesses. Sue was, so they lead to a life with no Birthdays, Christmas, or other holidays. For Adora right now, this was the closest she ever felt to a holiday.

She rushed downstairs in jean overalls with a red shirt underneath. Sue smirked as she looked at Angella; who was judging Adora's poor wardrobe. It was doubtful that Angella would set foot in some fancy restaurant with Adora dressed like—*that*.

Instead, Angella was just more delighted to be around Adora. Driving her off in the BMW. Octavia followed them out. Spoke with her for a few more minutes and they were off. One less mouth to feed wasn't so bad for tonight Sue thought. It annoyed her that Octavia just granted Angella permission to take Adora like that, approval or not, it made her angry, this usually is the domino effect. One child leaves, then another, then another. Sue was not looking forward to the upcoming months if Adora's adoption goes through.

Adora was excited. She was safely bucked in the back seat of Angella's car. Adora's eyes shifted around as she sat in the back. This car was clean and smelled nice. No crumbs, stains, and weird

pee smell. Her seat was comfy, and the car door had buttons. She asked, “Angella, what do all these buttons do?”

Angella looked at the rearview mirror and smiled “That is the button for the seat warmer, love”

Adora looked surprised “Car seats can get warm?”

“Yes, they can”

Adora pressed the button and commented “My bottom is warm”

Angella chuckled at that. Such simple things brought this girl delight.

At the restaurant, she gave Adora a kids menu for her to color. It came to Angella’s realization of how odd Adora was. She didn’t know how to act in a restaurant. She nervously fidgeted. She didn’t know what any food was outside of her foster home and school lunches. To be simple she ordered Adora. Chicken tenders and French fries. Adora was mesmerized when the plate came. She asked Angella “I can eat this all by myself?”

Angella cautiously nodded “Yes, dear. Is that okay?”

Adora nodded happily "I like food—I'm really hungry" she started to eat. Angella noted her lack of utensil usage. Adora commented with her mouth full "T—this morning w-we only had cereal, and, and, we had no milk—so, so, we ate it with no milk and at school, we only had a little bit of food"

She ate as if she hadn't had a decent meal in days. Angella asked her if Adora was still hungry, to which she nodded her head. Angella ordered her another plate. To shocked her at how much Adora was able to eat. Then it occurred to her that living in a home with so many children must have meant her meals were limited. It crushed her. Despite eating two plates of chicken tenders, Adora still had dessert. She excitedly told Angella that she had only had ice cream once before. That also crushed her. With every word it made her want Adora more.

Adora tried to sell herself a little more to Angella. This time without anyone around it was clear Adora's stutter was more severe. Angella mentally noted how she would get her a speech therapist and tutor for that. She also realized Adora's eye contact wasn't so great, but that might be due to Sue's parental methods.

Adora said "I—I'm—I'm, I'm a good girl. I eat food. I eat food I don't like, I do what I'm told. I—I, know how to d-do dishes and, and, I can clean, I can c-clean, lots of stuff" This seemed like an odd thing for Adora to mention.

The night went fine. Adora looked relaxed in the back seat of the car. When they arrived back at the foster home. Angella let Adora out. Hugged her and walked her to the front door, only to receive a glare from Sue. Angella felt a sense of unease take over

and Adora willingly rushed to Sue's arms. "I had a good day and I was a good girl!" Adora proclaimed. A fake smile came over Sue as she motioned for Adora to go inside. Sue crossed her arms and looked over to Angella, who was walking up to her to speak.

"We need to discuss the final steps in the paperwork for Adora. This process will take the longest. So, it would be best to start it sooner than later" Angella offered.

Sue exhaled and shifted from one side of her body to place a hand on her hip "You're so determined, aren't you?"

Angella crossed her arms. Not fearing this woman "Why shouldn't I? I can give Adora a good and loving home. Doesn't she deserve that? Don't all these children do?"

Sue scoffed a little and let out a small and sinister laugh.

Angella looked nervous and clutched her purse.

Sue shook her head "Oh, I know your type. The American Dream mothers. You think adopting will be such a magical experience. But you should know it's not. To bring someone who isn't flesh and blood into your home will not be as easy as you imagine"

Angella asked, "What gives you the right to say that to me?"

Sue scoffed again "The fact that I know women like you, you like the attention, you want to look humble and good. I doubt you haven't realized Adora is a more special case than some of my other children. She's a little delayed, speech impediment, hearing is poor, she's going to be evaluated for additional ailments when she goes to the doctors next month, but I think you know what I'm getting at, right? If this little girl needs more help in her school life and social one, how badly would that ruin your image? I doubt having a child with a stutter running around the Country Club looks good for you"

Offended by Sue's accusation she defended herself "Adora, in my care, will have everything she needs, she'll the best of the best for all her needs, and I will love her no matter what. You don't know me, how could you have such little faith in parents who want to adopt?

Sue glared at her and opened the door to the front of the house-wide and said one last cruel comment "Before you uproot Adora, you should consider what is best for her…. And your family. She's not something you can return if she doesn't meet your expectations, dolling her up won't ever change the fact she is not your own"

With that, she left an offended Angella on the porch.

She couldn't believe what had just happened. Sue Weaver accused her of adopting out of vanity instead of love, and ruthlessly picked apart Angella's character without knowing her. It was downright evil and no one witnessed it. How can she say

such things? Do adopt fall through so often with her that she feels every parent wanting to adopt is bad?

Sue made it a point once she got into the house to single out Adora. She heard Adora tell Catra and Lonnie about how she ate chicken tenders and ice cream. Both girls remarked on her for being lucky. Sue took this moment to snarl "Bragging about your night, I see" She scolded her for being selfish and eating better food than everyone else that night. Guilting her by accusing her of retelling her night with Angella, was bragging and terrible. She watched as Adora tearfully pleaded she was a good girl and didn't mean to brag.

Catra held Adora's hand in an attempt to comfort her. In her overly stimulated start, Adora retracted her hand away from Catra and started to hit herself on the top of the head. "I wasn't bad! I wasn't trying to be bad" she cried to Sue. Leaving all the kids to awkwardly watch Adora pathetic meltdown. Something they were all familiar to. If Adora ever got upset, she would cry and hit herself. It was the weirdest way to handle being disciplined or scolded. She only did it at home since Sue seemed to be the only one to trigger this reaction out of her. As she cried and hit her head, Catra and Lonnie tried to stop her. Sue snapped at them "Leave her!"

Both jumped back and waited for Adora's meltdown to escalate as she threw herself to the floor and sobbed. One of the teens snicked in the back and commented "She's sperging out again" another one taunted "She's the only kid here that kicks her own ass" as they laughed and went upstairs Adora simmered down.

Looking up at Sue with tearful eyes and apologizing. Sue just nodded and told her to get ready for bed.

All the children had different triggers. Adora was the easiest, all she had to do was tell her she's a bad girl and that puts Adora into tears. Catra doesn't care about being called names. She's running out of insults and hurtful words for Catra, instead, she beats her. Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio were just as easy to discipline. They feared the basement, so she would just send them down there for a timeout. That used to work on Catra until her curiosity got the best of her and she decided to kick the furnace with her barefoot and burned herself. Sending her to the hospital and leaving Sue to have a miserable meeting with child services.

Upstairs Adora asked Catra "Are you made I ate dinner with someone else?"

Catra shook her head "No, it's okay. That lady is going to be your new mom. She looks nice"

Adora smiled "She is. She talks fancy, and she smells good"

Adora didn't know anything else about Angella. All she knows is what she has seen. All she's seen is a pretty, nice lady who wants to be her mom.

The Adoption process is not a quick one. Days turn into weeks and months. Social workers, therapy, and guidance counselors, and doctor's appointments were lined up for Adora. But, Sue dragged her feet on everything. Rescheduling appointments and refusing to sign off on certain documents put Angella in limbo. The social workers were also just as bad. They had such low energy when it came to getting kids adopted. Thankfully for Adora, Angella was not one to back down. She and Micah were stubborn. They visited, brought gifts, and got clearance to take her all the time to go out. It became a weekly routine. Every Wednesday she's gone with Micah and Angella. Sometimes a social worker was there at dinner and sometimes it was Glimmer. Either way, it was always someone. Adora would come home happy to tell Catra.

Both girls were still unaware that once Adora left, the chances of her coming over again were slim to none. Not because Angella would them seeing each other, but Sue will put a stop to it. She does with every foster child.

A year had almost passed. September was upon them and Adora was starting a new school year. Getting taller, she lost another baby tooth, and her stutter was not getting worse. It was taking forever for the adoption to finalize. Glimmer was growing impatient over getting *her sister*. It was so sweet to hear Glimmer refer to her like that. She played with Adora a few times and liked her. Adora seemed to be more of the follower and let Glimmer control the playdates. Angella was relieved to see that Glimmer could tell that Adora had a speech impediment and did not draw attention to it.

When the day finally came it was on a Sunday. Adora's last Sunday at Kingdom Hall. Angella attended. It was a different change of pace for an Episcopalian. As a Christian, she did have friends of different faiths. Sue was not too happy to see her here. Talking with other Kingdom Hall members, laughing, and catching their interests. She hated it. She caught a look at herself in the mirror in the coffee hour room and she wanted to die at what she saw. An old, aged Portuguese woman with dry long black hair, sunken in green eyes, and distinctive frown marks. To add insult to injuring she saw Angella in the distance. The gorgeous hazel-eyed, brunette, dressed in designer clothes, and looking ageless. It drove her insane to known Angella was five years younger than her and was a doctor, homeowner, and wife. It made her think her life was less important. For that she hated her. Everything about her.

Adora just stupidly looked at her with love. She hated the sight of it. Adora in her best clothes. A red cardigan, a white undershirt, and a black skirt with little black ballet slippers. She looked at Angella like she was some sort of *Angelic Being* come to her rescue. As Adora clung to Angella's arm. Catra clung to her. This was the only day in the week where Sue acted motherly. Being sweet and affectionate to the children. The kids were not stupid and knew this and the younger children used this time to get hug, kisses, and talk to Sue in public without fear of punishment. The teens didn't go to Kingdom Hall, she only made the kids go. The teens all had weekend jobs or house chores, and when she took out the children to Kingdom Hall it was an excuse for free breakfast.

After a few minutes before Kingdom Hall was over the little ones went outside to play for one final playtime. They didn't think this would be the last moment they would see each other, so they played house outside in the backyard of the Hall. The night before they watched a movie about two people getting married

and Kyle wanted to pretend to be the officiant. Even though he didn't know what they were called, he just said "I wanna be the person who marries people" to which Catra and Adora volunteered to get married. For Adora, this didn't seem like anything special. It was just like the time they played police officers or ninjas. Catra, it felt different. She liked the pretend idea of marrying Adora, she was her best friend and prettiest friend. The two held hands each other's hands and looked at each other. Kyle tried to remember all the words with some help from Lonnie.

Sue caught sight of this and smiled. In this small moment, it was precious, both little girls holding hands, both in little cardigans and skirts. Smiling and giggling. That happiness is so rare and precious. In this rare moment, she just observed her foster children in silence. Away from anyone else. She took her phone and began to record them. The sweet ender moment of a bunch of seven-year old's flubbing and fumbling their words as they played pretend.

Kyle stammered "You—and—you gotta, gotta….."

Lonnie dramatically facepalmed and instructed him "You have to say do you take Catra to be your wife"

Kyle then replied dumbfounded "Oh, okay" turning to Catra he asked, "Will you be my wife?" All three girls laughed at this.

Lonnie then cried "No! you gotta ask Catra for Adora!"

Kyle then asked corrected himself "Okay, Adora wants to be your wife, yes?" he looks to Adora who now starts to turn a little pink as she shyly giggles "Y-yeah" she replies bashfully.

He then turns to Catra and asks "Are you going to say yes? Catra also turned a little pink and giggled while fidgeting.

Sue realized when recording that she was witnessing puppy love.

She watches them hug instead of kiss and then run off holding hands to go play ninjas again. This sweet little moment was only an hour away from being ruined forever, and Sue was okay with that. As of next month, Sue will be down $600 due to Adora's absence, and the stress of that will be taken out on every child because of it.

The time was almost coming to pull Adora aside and gave her one last moment of fear. Cupping the child's cheeks she caressed her little face and cooed "My sweet little Adora, my precious Adora…… I hope you always stay a good girl for your new family" Adora nodded and smiled "I'm a good girl. I will visit you and Catra and __"

Sue stopped her and reminded her "That is only up to your new mommy now, remember, you have to do whatever they say, whenever they say it and always be good. You should never ask for anything that could upset them and follow them with everything they do. If you're a bad girl, they won't send you back to me, they'll send you away to a group home"

This was a lie Sue liked to tell the adopted children. She would want them that they could be abandoned if they stop liking them. The extra boost of anxiety always caused discord in the homes after, and Sue would be the one the newly adopted parents turned to in a crisis. For extra measure she knew it best to place fear in Adora's head, just to make her difficult for Angella, simply out of spite.

She warned Adora "Just be good, if you stop being cute and good, they won't keep you, okay?"

Adora nervously nodded. It never occurred to the child that she could be given away. In her heart, she hoped Angella liked her enough to keep her forever.

Now the time has come. Adora was off. All her belongings fit into one large black trash bag. Adora had given her Elmo doll to Catra before leaving the house, as Catra had given her, her favorite stuffed animal; a worn-down stuffed monkey with long arms and legs named Howie. Adora's belongings were depressingly placed in the trunk. Angella frowned that Adora was not granted the dignity of luggage. She looked over Sue. Giving her a dirty look as Adora hugged all her friends goodbye.

Sue desperately wished she could have faked tears for this moment. Just to look good in front of any remaining Kingdom Hall members that might watch a glance at her. To her dismay, it never happened. Adora and Catra gave one final goodbye and Catra asked "I will see again soon?"

Adora smiled “Yeah, really soon”

And with that, Adora was gone. Off in a Black BMW with her new doctor mom. The realization had not yet hit all the children, that their friend was gone. Adora wasn’t coming back. Angella wasn’t going to drive 10-miles every week to let the kids have a playdate. She’s a Christian, so no doubt she’ll force Adora to convert to Episcopalian for her new family. It wasn’t like a Christian can just waltz into a Kingdom Hall whenever they want, and it’s not like Sue was going to go out of her way to waste gas money to meet her anywhere. No. This was it. Adora was gone and she wasn’t coming back, she wasn’t welcomed to. She’ll make sure of it. She looked down at Catra, who sneakily held her hand. Since they were still at Kingdom Hall Sue had to play the part of a loving mother still, and she hated it. She felt almost bad for little Carlotta. This little monster had no idea that the person she loved and pretended to marry an hour ago was going to forget all about by the end of the week.

Glimmer's big sister blues

Chapter Summary

Glimmer is unsure how to handle her sister.

Adora was free from that terrible home. Angella thought. Now with her new daughter in the back seat of her car. Driving home to have a good life with her from now on. She was relieved that Adora was not distraught over leaving her old home. Adora must be excited to leave and have her place. Angella felt a sense of joy and relief that this whole adoption was finally over. Minus the next few social worker visits, Adora was no longer apart of the failing foster system. The doctor was no fool to the foster system, being an E.R. doctor she has seen many foster teens and children come into the emergency room with questionable injuries. With Adora living with her she will never have to worry or want anything ever again. Angella can give her the best food, clothes, toys, and education and she was confident in that. She smiled back at Adora. The little blonde seemed more focused on what was outside and Angella spoke up and asked her "Are you excited to be living with us now?"

Adora didn't answer. She kept her eyes on the window. Not looking at anything. Angella's eyes narrowed a bit, then she remembered, Adora had hearing aids for a short time as a toddler because they assumed, she suffered from hearing loss after being in a car accident. Tragically, she was in the car when it was struck by the other car. Her parents both died in the accident. She survived. Adora must still have some issues with hearing. Even though the ruled-out deafness when she was four, it seems she doesn't hear well still.

"Adora?" Angella called. Her voice raised slightly.

Adora snapped out of her trance and looked forward. "Yes, Angella?"

The older women were compelled to correct her. She wanted to tell her to call her mom, but it might be too soon into the move to ask for that. She asked her again "Are you excited to live with us?"

Adora nervously shifted in her seat and replied "Y-yes, I'm a good girl and I'll be a very good girl at your house"

Her voice seemed a little off with that reply. Like she was trying to repress her stutter as she spoke slower. She noticed Adora's speech was off. Nothing speech therapy and tutors cant fix. Adora started to speak again and told Angella "I can do chores and I follow rules" A positive selling point, but it felt forced. Adora had often spoken about what she can do and how well she can behave, it was something that must have been instilled in her from living with Sue.

Angella nodded "I know sweetie, you're a very good girl. But, you don't need to do chores at our home. We have a cleaning lady for that" she wanted to assure Adora that she would have an easier life. For this, Adora looked panicked. In her little head, she had planned it all out. If she does lots of chores in her new home she will always fall into Angella's good favor. If she cants do chores then what will she do to make sure Angella wants to keep her? Sue warned her if Angella didn't want her anymore, she would just send her away. But not back to Sue. Instead, group home and Sue loved to tell horror stories of what happens in group

homes. Bad little kids that cry and aren't well behaved get hit! Pow pows! Worse than anything Sue had ever given them. In a nervous sputter of words, Adora blurted out "I want to stay with you, I want you to keep me" Her stutter serve in that sentence.

Angella assured her "You are staying with me, sweetie"

With eyes on the road, she couldn't help feel Adora was a little awkward to be around. She was a sweet girl, but her upbringing with Sue must have stunted her social skills. She worried about what school would be like for her. She hoped Adora wouldn't be bullied at her new school. She hated that Adora didn't move in during the summer as she planned. Sue took forever on her side of the adoption plan that Adora started school at her old school and was now joining the school in late September.

Once they arrived home Adora was shocked by how large the house was. The neighborhood was nothing like her old one. This neighborhood was pretty and all the houses had windows and no graffiti on them. Plus there were no metal fences, every house had a big yard and some had pretty trees.

Angella opened up the trunk of her car and took out Adora's bag of stuff. She caught an unpleasant odor of musk and cigarette smoke. She knew she needed to re-wash all these clothes. She noticed Adora hadn't left the car yet and asked "Adora are you okay?"

Adora then opened the car door and apologized "Yes, Angella, s-sorry, I was waiting for per-permission to opened the c-car-d-d-

door”

Angella raised a brow at her. She liked how Adora was cautious, to this extent, she was unsure of how to react to it. She knew she would need to keep an eye on her. She was by far nothing like her Glimmer. Her precious girl was much for inquisitive, articulate, and independent. She looked at Adora who has her hands folded together in front of her torso. She looked up at Angella her pleading face. She could see the child’s worried expression. It must all start to be sinking in for her that her life is going to be different from now on. Examining her expression she noticed how dingy Adora’s best clothes were. In a faded black skirt and a faded and ripped cardigan, she smelled the faint odor of cigarettes and mildew. In an attempt to ease Adora’s anxious expression she offered “Let’s go inside sweetheart. I can show you all around your new home”

She grabbed the dirty bag of clothes and thought to herself she would wash them as soon as possible. When she opened the door to let Adora in and she was delighted to see the amount of wonder and awestruck the child was. Adora softly gasped “Wow, your house is so big and pretty”

Angella smiled “It’s your home now, Adora” she closes the front door and watches Adora look around. She frowns when she sees the scared look in her eyes as Adora looks like she is unable to articulate her thoughts. It seemed so odd, granted she was only seven, but she should be more articulate than this. Angella takes her hand out “Come, let me show you the house”

Angella grew a little more worried about Adora’s questions. Showing her the living room and hearing Adora ask “Am I allowed

to sit on the couch?" Of course, Angella said she could, but it seemed so strange. What kind of rules did she live with while being in Sue's care? It didn't matter. She showed her the kitchen, the bathrooms, and her bedroom. Adora was so surprised to have a room all to herself. She looked around in awe as Angella commented "In your closet, I have some clothes for you, tomorrow we can go to the store and buy you some new clothes and toys"

Adora looked in wonder.

Angella smelt the unpleasant odor of cigarettes must and asked Adora "Would you like to take a bath darling? And then we can get you into some pajamas before dinner okay?"

Adora nodded and fidgeted as she asked "C-can have a bubble bath?"

Angella smiled at the request. She hoped this meant Adora was getting comfortable with her. She decided to show her Angella and Micah's private bathroom. Inside was a jetted jacuzzi tub that Angella turned into a giant foamy bubble bath for her. Adora looked happy. Before Angella could tell Adora it was all clear, the child stripped off her smelly clothes. Angella assumed Adora trusted her, so she didn't comment on it. The little girl jumped in the tub happily. Angella took the clothes from the floor and brought all of them down to the laundry room. She opened up her bag to see a notebook, a binder, and a dirty little stuffed monkey. She frowned at it. Adora deserves better toys. She shouldn't throw it out yet. She made sure to place those on in her new room while Adora finished her bubble bath. For Adora, this was paradise, A bath all her herself. With warm water! No one

watching her, No one yelling, it felt so calm and relaxing, she wondered if Catra would have liked this bath. Catra only liked warm baths, so she liked to take showers first, that's when there is hot water. She swam around a little in the water. It felt so good. She realized had been alone for a while. The quiet hum of the jetted tub started to bother her. She can't here Angella. It started to worry her, she had no clothes, and this bathroom was bright, shiny, nice smelling, and there were, like, eight towels hanging up! Which one to use? This was nothing like the bathroom she was used to. Why was she left all alone? Should she call for Angella? Would it upset her new mom if she started yelling? What if it's a quiet time?

To her relief, Angella knocked on the door to the bathroom and asked Adora if she was okay? Adora sputtered "I w-wanna come out now!"

She opened the door and handed her a towel. Then closed the door again to give Adora privacy. She felt worried again, something about Adora seemed *different.*

When Glimmer and Micah finally got home it only became more awkward.

Adora grew a few inches since the last time Glimmer saw her. This beautiful hallmark moment was soon to be shattered without either adult anticipating it. Both girls seemed so happy to get to know each other in one of their meetings.

Glimmer put her shoes away walked into the living room to hug her mother and looked around “Where’s Adora?” she asked happily. Excited about her new sister. Micah took his phone out to record this soon to be a happy moment. Angella smiled and told her “She's getting dressed honey, she’ll be right down”

Angella went back upstairs to check on Adora. All her clothes were in the washer machine, so she had her wear a pair of Glimmer’s pajamas. Knocking on the bedroom door she was greeted by Adora telling her “I’m r-r-ready” her *stutter will need to be worked on*.

She opened the door to see Adora did not fit all that well in Glimmer’s pajamas. Her legs were tall, so it looked like she was wearing tight highwater bottoms with a tight shirt that barely made it past her elbows. It was humorous, to say the least. Adora didn’t seem to mind as she was happy to show off her cleanly brushed long blonde hair and blue pajamas with clouds on the “I’m dressed” she commented.

Angella smiled and told her “Your father and Glimmer are wanting to see you”

Adora beamed, she was going to meet her new big sister. She was so happy. She rushed down the stairs to see Glimmer in the living room. In a matter of seconds, Glimmer’s happy face fell when Adora rushed up to her.

“Glimmer!” Adora cried as she opened her arms for a hug “You're my new big sister!”

Micah and Angella had their cameras out to capture this whole moment. Glimmer tried her best to keep a smile on her face as she commented "Wow, you got taller….." she said as she hugged Adora. Angella and Micah shot each other a worried look as Adora cluelessly nodded and smiled "Yes, I—I can, I—I am taller now"

Her stuttering voice made Glimmer shoot a look at her mother. A look saying *does she always talk like this?* Without actually saying it. Glimmer and Adora had barely spoken and with Adora being so over-stimulated with so many emotions her speech impediment was worse than what it ever was. It wasn't that her speech had worsened in the last time they had seen each other, she just never had been around Adora when she was hyper. Usually, Sue would scold Adora to slow down or breathe or Catra would help her calm down. Her new family had no clue what was going on and just now all assumed her speech was just bad.

In an awkward way to save the moment, Micah informed the girls that he bought pizza and it was on its way. In the meanwhile, they can go play. Glimmer was reluctant to do so. She was still happy to have Adora as her sister, but now she was mad about her being three inches taller than her. She escorted Adora to her room to play.

Adora was wowed by Glimmer's room. Pink and purple, sparkly and pretty. She had a shelf of toys and her desk was filled with cool arts and crafts supplies.

Glimmer asked "So….. uh…. What member of One direction is your favorite?"

Adora confusedly asked “Huh?”

Glimmer sighed “Boy bands, what’s your favorite boy bands?”

Adora answered “I—I don’t know what those are”

She sighed.

Adora nervously tapped her fingers “W-what am I supposed to like?”

Glimmer just rolled her eyes and pointed to her poster “You have to like Harry, but Love Liam! the others are okay, wanna listen to some music?”

Adora hesitantly replied “Okay,”

While Glimmer tried to introduce Adora to all things she, Angella, and Micah talked in the kitchen.

“You think they got off to a good start?” Micah asked.

Angella replied “I think Glimmer wasn’t to keen on seeing Adora hit a growth spurt”

Micah chuckled “She’ll be fine. I hope she likes pizza”

Angella went to go check on them. She peeked on Glimmer and Adora and saw Glimmer giving Adora a lesson in boy bands. It was amusing, however, Adora seemed uninterested. Angella smiled as she saw how polite Adora was being, unknown to her, Adora was uneasy. The noise from the songs and trying to listen to Glimmer was overstimulating.

Lucky for her dinner was here and Adora got to enjoy pizza for the first time in a while. Something about being happy about getting to eat two slices of pizza all to herself was heart aching for Micah. As a lawyer, he has been involved in some nasty court battles. He knows a neglected and abused child when he sees one. He stopped practicing family law and switch to business due to the decline to take abusive parents' side when in the courtroom. Judging by Adora’s odd little mannerism and stutter he had made his diagnosis on her. Autism. No denying it. By her movements and uneasy look when she goes into a room, he can tell she most likely has been punished for stimming at one point or another. He noticed when they first met she had bruises on her arms and dreaded the idea of them either be self-inflicted or had been from her old home. He noticed she stimmed with her hands sometimes moving her wrist a lot or rocking a little. He worried Angella or Glimmer might say something; he could tell by the unamused look on Glimmer’s face that she was still pissed that Adora was taller than her.

After dinner was when it got more awkward. Her interest was limited and she asked if she could play outside. It was fall and it was getting darker faster, besides it was 5 pm. The girls would be going to bed in a few hours and Adora had just showered.

She asked Micah "Can I go outside to play?" tugging at his hand. He raised a brow "Outside? We don't have any toys for outside play, sweetie, what would you wanna do outside?"

Adora fidgeted and replied with her head down "Run around…. In a circle, um, jump—d-dig a h-hole"

Micah chuckled and teased her "Dig a hole? What are you? A mole? No holes in my yard" he grinned at her, but instantly frowned when he saw she backed up and flinched as if she was anticipating a strike. Adora regretted asking to play. Micah called her name Mole and told her to not make holes in his yard. Her previous yard was nothing but dead grass and dirty toys, Sue didn't care if they dug through to the ground or the bottom of the sandbox.

He gave Angella a nervous look and she suggested "Adora, love, we don't you go up and play in your new room"

Adora looked scared as she hugged herself and twisted her body a little and asked in a worried voice "W-was I bad?"

Micah and Angella gave each other a confused look and Angella assured Adora that she wasn't in any trouble. Angella then repeated herself "Go enjoy your new room, sweetie"

Adora nodded and walked out of the kitchen. She seemed hurt by Angella's insistence on going to her room. This was usually a punishment. Sue would often punish each child by either making them sit in the basement in complete darkness or forcing them into a room or closet alone. If sue got annoyed or felt too many Bastards were around her, she would just tell the kids to disperse alone in different places around the house. Adora and Catra took this the worst, as they often cried and begged not to be away from each other. Adora felt her feelings being hurt at the idea of being told she had to be alone. She peaked into Glimmer's room. Who was watching something off her tablet? She saw Adora in her doorway and just ignored her. She felt the blonde stare at her at rudely remark "What?" before shooting her a mean look. Adora clutched her pajama top and asked "C-can I be in here with you?"

Glimmer looked down at her tablet "I'm playing on my tablet it's only a person toy, so you cant play"

Adora looked down and softly asked, "Can I just sit in here with you?"

Glimmer sighed and agreed "Sure,"

Adora happily entered the room. She sat on Glimmer's bed with her and watched what she did. Glimmer found this annoying but didn't say anything. She got the feeling Adora was a weirdo. Like the kids in the green room. Those were the special kids, like the girl who needs a helmet, the boy with no teeth, and the other kid

that walks funny. Adora acted like one of them. She acted like the weird girl Entrapta. She was super smart but didn't talk to people a lot and didn't play with anyone at recess. With Adora's eyes fixated on her, she flatted stated "You're the little sister, you're supposed to be little. You bigger than me" she shot Adora a look and saw the worried expression on her face as Adora got up from the bad and asked, "Are you going to tell Angell and Micah to send me back?"

Glimmer looked confused. That was an option? She could just tell her parents to send Adora back and they could get her a smaller sister? That would be nice. But it might make mom sad. Angella spoke the most about adopting Adora and she wouldn't want to make her mommy sad. Just like how she tells her mommy that she likes avocados to make her happy, she didn't want to say get a shorter sister.

Glimmer just replied "I can't tell them that"

Adora fidgeted a little and asked, "Can I still stay in here?"

Glimmer nodded. Adora now sat on the floor instead.

Adora was weird.

It wasn't too long before bedtime. Adora stayed in Glimmer's bedroom until then. Both parents tucked Glimmer in and gave her kisses on the forehead and cheek and told them they loved her.

Adora's awards watched from the doorway. She wished she had Catra. Catra would do that for her. She walked into her room and Micah and Angella followed after. Both seemed a little worried. Neither knew Adora's bedtime routine. All they knew is she once shared a bedroom with multiple girls.

Adora stood next to her bed fidgeting with her fingers. She looked scared. Like she didn't know what to do. Angella instructed her "I'll tuck you in, love" Adora nodded. Angella tucked her in and paid close attention to her stiff and fearful emotions. Micah walked over to her with her toy monkey "Want to sleep with this?" he offered.

Adora nodded. And extended her hands out for it.

Angella then told her "We are all so happy to have you here with us"

She gently patted Adora's head. Adora didn't flinch this time. She hoped she would get tucked in and get kisses as Glimmer did. Instead, both parents wished her a good night and left the bedroom, turning off the lights.

In the comfort of their room, they looked at each other and gave a worried look to one another. Micah awkwardly rubbed the back of his head and began "So, uhh…. Did you notice her flinch at me? Right?"

Angella nodded “Yes, but she isn’t used to us. She needs time. It will be an adjustment”

Micah looked worried “I think we might need to look into that behavior more, she seems sort of mousey. Like, she’s afraid to be here”

Angella felt sickened at the idea of what could be making Adora uneasy. She reiterated what she said before “She needs to adjust, we’ll all be fine” ending the conversation. The couple got ready for bed and heard the knock of a tiny hand on their door. Opening it, they saw Glimmer looking annoyed. She informed her parents in a sigh of frustration “Adora’s been crying for ten minutes”

Angella felt a rush of worry as she darted past Glimmer to check on Adora. Leaving Micah with his unamused daughter. She walked into the master bedroom and sat on her parent's bed, looking up to her dad she asked him “Did you know she was a foot taller than me?”

Micah paused for a moment. *Feet?*

Micah asked, “Do you mean foot?”

Glimmer nodded “Yeah, she’s a foot and a foot taller than me,” she replied in a huff “She’s supposed to be the little sister”

Micah chuckled “She’s still your little sister, she’s only a few inches taller”

Assuring his little girl, she was still the oldest sister, he told her “You have to help and guide Adora, she’s going to be looking to you to be a good big sister” his expression turned a little more serious as he sat next to her and put an arm around her. His method for hamming up a dramatic moment. Wanting to make Glimmer feel important, he told her “You’re the best girl to be a big sister” with that he started to send her off to bed. Walking her back to her room he heard the muffled talking of Angella and Adora.

Whatever was transpiring was not going well. Judging by the shaking voice of a seven-year-old. Angella had closed the door behind her and wished Adora to have a goodnight again while adding in “Stay in your new bedroom, love.”

Angella felt a feeling of a supportive breakthrough. When entering Adora’s room the little girl was crying due to being afraid of being alone in the dark. Peering around Angella felt her room was not nearly as dark as it could have been. Some light shining through her blinds from the streetlights.

She softly asked “Adora? What’s the matter?”

Adora rubbed her eyes and cried “I—I, I don’t want sl-sleep alone. I don’t wike it”

Angella corrected her “You don’t like it?”

Adora nodded and pleaded “C-can I stay in your room or Glimmer’s r-r-room?”

Angella shook her head “No sweetie, you need to enjoy your room by yourself. I promise you, your room is nice and safe, okay, now get some rest” she assured her as she tried to tuck in the little girl. Angella saw in the dim light Adora’s lip tremble as she tried to hold back tears. Worrying if she was making the right decision she tried to conform to Adora's “Your safe here” and kissed her forehead. She took her to leave. Adora did everything she could to not start crying again. In her desperate attempt to muffle her distress she bit down on her right forearm as hard as she could. This was a coping mechanism she used when she got stressed. Biting herself, smacking herself in the head, sometimes pulling her hair. She didn’t do that much anymore since Sue always made her wear her hair up for that reason. Adora bit so hard she left a mark, she repeated the action until she had several bite marks on her arms. Now with two sore arms, she was left alone with her thoughts. Thinking to herself about how mean Angella was. *Why couldn’t I sleep with you? I could have slept on the floor? Even Sue let me sleep on the floor of her bedroom when I was sick.* Her eyes darted around the darkroom. Fearful of the sounds and darkness. The house was quiet. With the few clicks and cracks from in-home appliances. She could hear the air purifier from outside her bedroom in the hallway. She couldn’t hear Glimmer, though. She to her window and noticed the silhouette of the tree near the garage looked like a big scary hand through her curtains. It bothered her. Catra usually blocked her view of the window in her old room. Usually, she had stuffed animals and other things to keep her feeling safe. In a room full of girls she felt safe. It was her and Catra and Lonnie with another bigger girl

that slept in that room. And she knew the teenagers were only down the hall. The humming and buzzing and muffled talking she had grown accustomed to her whole life was gone and she hated it. The realization of knowing she would be sleeping like this from now on sank in. she didn't want to sleep alone, she waiting in her bedroom. The time going by. Unable to get comfortable in her squishy bed she felt like she was being eaten up by the darkness. In her panic, she got up from her bed and walked to her closet. Opening it she saw some of her new clothes and her old clothes in the black trash bag. Taking out one of her old red sweatshirts and her stuffed monkey she made a cozy spot on the hardwood floor of the closet. Looking around she noticed her closet had a light. She turned it on and felt relieved. It might be bright, but she could see and in this tiny space, she felt safer. Now with her sweater cover only a small part of her body, she felt more relaxed. This felt familiar to her. Catra and she used to share a blanket and sometimes Catra would steal all the covers. Her sweatshirt still had the stale smell of cigarettes and the musk of an old house. It was another safe and familiar scent she had grown accustomed to thinking of when she thought of security. The new smell of this hour was fresh and crisp, like flowers and perfume. Something she associated with when it came to doctors' offices or the child service office. It was a fearful scent. It reminded her of fakeness. In this house, she had to be more careful. She thought to herself about what she needed to do from here on out.

Regretting crying she knew she had to say sorry to Angella in the morning. She would have to do a better job of hiding her tears. Angella was less caring than Sue. Sue would have given Adora an option, but Angella told her to toughen up. She talked to her the way the social workers did. Adora didn't like the social workers, they would tell them to stop being bad girls when they had to sit with them in private. Even when Catra would tell them about getting bad punishments or being hungry because there was no food. The social workers would always remind Catra to be a good

girl and she might not get bad punishments and that she should be grateful enough to eat a meal a day.

Adora feared what to do. If she was a bad girl who would discipline her? Would Angella? She had the same nails as Sue does, or would Micah. He had bigger hands, and boys are stronger than girls. Adora curled into a ball some more at the idea. Her new family might not like her for crying at night. They might even hate her for keeping them awake. She sobbed softly into her arms as she fell asleep.

Angella two rooms away tossed and turned in worry. Was Adora okay on her first night? Should she have let her stay in her bedroom? She didn't find it all the appropriate of a request. Glimmer doesn't even sleep in their bed. She turned to Micah who was creepily staring at her with wide eyes "Worried?" he asked.

She jumped a bit at his silent staring and asked, "How long have you been awake?"

He sat up a little "The whole time. Worried about a new little princess?"

Angella sat up and confirmed "Yes. She was sobbing over not wanting to be alone. Sue never told me what her comfortable sleeping arrangements were. I figured a room to herself would be blissful."

Micah rubbed his beard and offered "Well, one little sleepover shouldn't hurt. Have her come in and share the bed with you and I'll take the couch."

Angella kissed his cheek and thanked him.

Getting up to check on her was not as easy as she has hoped. When opening the door she panicked at the sight of no child in the bed. Holding back a shriek she searched the room. Opening the closet door she saw the light on and saw little Adora curled in a ball sleeping on the floor of her closet.

Angella clutched her chest feeling an ache of failure. Her new daughter was upset and she let her down. She has no idea what kind of life Adora had before adopting her. Was this a coping or self-soothing method? Did she do this before adopting her? She had no idea. Feeling regretful and unaware of what to do she decided not to wake her up. Seeing how she was fast asleep she didn't want to bother her now. Micah didn't fully agree with her decision. He commented that kids who did stuff like this were typically fearful children.

The next morning

Filled with guilt Angella wanted to make things right. Preparing for her morning routine was nothing special for Angella. Downstairs in the basements was the washer and dryer were was a secondary furnished room. One with a treadmill and some

weights. It also had an extra fridge and a pool table. Being dubbed Micah's mancave and household accessories, it was where Angella could get a brief workout in on cold mornings. Starting her run she put on her headphones to listen to an audiobook on adopting children. She needed some additional resources to help her through what was going on with her daughter.

Listen and love. A child needs to know their needs can be met in their new home. Without communication, a child will withdraw and a bond can never form properly…..

This though made a new fear come to Angella's mind. What if Adora didn't bond with her? Adora needed a mother. Angella felt she was the perfect provider. She can give Adora anything her little heart desired. Clothes, toys, vacations. Anything! Angella could give her all those things.

After finishing her workout and being wrapped in the thought of not being able to bond with her adopted child she went upstairs and smelt the scent of breakfast. Micah must fo went all out for making breakfast for the girls. Her smile turned to frown instantly upon entering the kitchen. Seesaw as Micah and Glimmer sat at the kitchen table while little Adora was standing on a chair doing the dishes.

Rage filled Angella's mind. Adora shouldn't be doing this! She just came from a home where she probably had to do this all the time! She wasn't going to have Adora be treated like some sort of Cinderella! Looking at Micah as he flippantly allowed Adora to do

dishes while standing on a chair made her angry. He should know better than this!

She snapped "What is going on here?!"

Micah not feeling he had done anything wrong calmly replied "Oh, we just finished up having some breakfast"

Glimmer nodded.

Adora looking back from the chair beamed at Angella. Hoping this would impress her. *Look, Angella! I'm doing dishes! I'm a good and helpful girl! Aren't you so happy you adopted me?*

Angella's face soured at this. She commented, "I don't think Adora should be doing dishes," turning her head sharply to her husband as she finished "the first full day home shouldn't have chores mixed into this" looking back over to Adora. She saw the little girl tremble again. Like she did last night at the sight of her. In a haste effort to retreat from the situation Adora dropped the sponge back into the sink and jumped off the chair. Sliding a little and almost falling as she did and darted out of the room. Leaving the rest of the family in confusion as to why she made such an exit.

Adora's mind went into flight mode. She knew the routine of a beating. She had upset Sue like this before. Done something, got yelled at, and then got a *pow-pow* because of it. She didn't

know what she did that was so wrong. She thought doing dishes would impress Angella. It impressed Micah. He didn't say no. All he said was not to touch the pans because they were still hot and he would do those. He let her do the plates and the silverware. Why did that upset Angella? In her room, she hid back in her closet. To where she stayed the night in, only to be awkwardly woken up by Glimmer questioning why she was in the closet. In fear, she slammed the closet door shut. Placing her jacket on her head. She feared what the rest of her day would bring. Sue wouldn't go looking for them if she didn't want to see them. Maybe if she hid in her closet all day she wouldn't have to worry. She then feared if she needed to go the bathroom or if Angella wanted to come into her room to hit her. Angella didn't cough and gasp for air like Sue did when she walked. Angella wasn't a smoker, so she could easily catch Adora if she wanted to. She retreated into her thoughts. Fearing the worst. She closed her eyes and whimpered "I only wanted to impress you"

Micah looking over to Glimmer and in a cheerful voice recommend "Hey kiddo, why don't you see what Adora is up to while me and mommy talk, okay?"

Glimmer nodded and left the room. She never heard or saw her parents argue or disagree before and this wasn't going to be the day where it starts. Micah and Angella were very mindful of how they interacted in their own home. Knowing to keep their squabbles private.

As soon as they knew she was out of earshot Micah threw his hands up in the air and angrily whispered "I let her clean the

plates because she wanted to, she was set on trying to show off on things she knows how to do. It made her happy, then you came and crapped on her”

Angella snapped back “I don’t think she is doing dishes! She should be getting pampered by us, not doing chores for us”

Micah retorted “It’s all she knows how to do, Angie. I was trying to make her feel comfortable by letting her do things she knows get praise for”

Angella frowned. Not thinking about it like that. She looked at Micah who smugly crossed his armed and commented “I’m two chapters ahead of you on that Building a loving home for adopted children book”

She questioned him “How?”

He shrugged “I listen to it, while I’m taking dumps.”

Angella scowled at his low brow humor.

He then playfully commented “Since you never poop, you wouldn’t know what it’s like to have valued toilet time for audiobooks. Last year I was able to listen to all the Harry Potter books on the toilet due to them opening a Firehouse Subs and Chipotle right by the Kia dealership.”

She shook her head and walked out of the kitchen, but not before playfully swatting his shoulder.

She didn't have time to ruin more of Adora's day. Her phone went off and she was off to the hospital for an emergency regarding a patient. Her job pulls her away from her family more than she would like to admit. Micah had a busy schedule too, aside from being an associate at a large law firm he also was the owner of a small car rental company. Most of their consistent income was made through Angella, the mortgage and many of the other bills were under Angella's name while many of the luxury items were under Micah, from their Country club membership, vacation rentals, cars, and jet skis, those were all under his name. Both hard-working adults have pulled away. Micah was more fortunate. His law firm had a daycare for workers and his dealership was his own so Glimmer has had the privilege of being pampered by everyone for being the boss's daughter. In the hospital, Angella was focused on saving lives, so she had no time to watch over Glimmer in her private office. So Glimmer spent most of her time with her father, aunt, and their closest friends.

Soon, Adora will have that life too. As for today. Micah was going to bring the girls to his law firm. To catch up on some paperwork. Then he would show Adora his dealership and maybe go for ice cream. Something fun for the girls before Adora starts school Monday.

Both girls were instructed to clean up and get ready for the day. This was no big task for Glimmer. She picked out her clothes and got herself ready all the time. She was a very independent child. Adora on the other hand was wracked with worry. She had to

pick out her clothes, with all these new outfits she had no idea what to wear. Glimmer knocked on her door in annoyance and asked "Daddy said we're leaving"

Adora still in underwear and an undershirt looked at Glimmer with confusion. She asked "Can you help me, pick out clothes" His meek tone was voided of any stuttering, but Glimmer was not having it. She chastised her "Can't you pick out your clothes?"

Adora looked down at her bare feet in shame. Glimmer was nothing like Catra. Catra would have helped her. Micah came into the door and being unaware of the tension teased Adora "Hey, underwear girl, hurry up. We got a lot planned for today"

Adora felt embarrassed. *Underwear girl?* That wasn't very nice. She couldn't figure out what to wear. She had so much to choose from and so many colors, why was she being picked on by her new dad and sister.

Micah picked out her clothes for her. Without any of Adora's input. She wore blue jeans, a yellow shirt, and white sneakers. Adora wasn't very good with putting her hair up by herself so she had no choice but to wear it down, which she hated on account of it bothering her. This made Glimmer even madder. Looking at Adora next to her she became jealous of the girls' looks. Taller than her with longer hair. She ran her hands through her thick wavy short brown hair and became angry that her mom convinced her to go short. Now Adora looked cuter than her and she wasn't going to like this.

Her jealously only went into high gear when all the people at daddy's office frowned over Adora. Saying how cute she was and talking to her. Adora was flustered. Cheeks red and her stutter was stronger. She was a little overwhelmed with all the attention, but Glimmer was far from excited for her. They went into the playroom and the office and much to Glimmer's dismay, they were the only ones there. She was hoping she could pawn Adora off and play with someone else. Adora's eyes lit up the moment she saw a Thomas the tank engine railroad playset. She excitedly asked Glimmer "Wanna play with me?"

Quick to shut her down she snarkily replied "That's for boys. Baby boys. I'm going to color and watch TV" seeing Adora frown she felt triumphant until she felt guilty again. Maybe she shouldn't be so mean to her. But then again, she is kind of weird.

Adora was saddened by but continued to play with by herself. Glimmer went over to a nearby table to color and turned the TV on to Disney and watched Shake It Up.

Micah was gabbing around the office. Talking to some of the paralegals and the shared his enthusiasm as he gushed about his new daughter. He showed the ladies his phone and the only picture he had of Adora thus far; her sitting next to Glimmer on their couch in pajamas that we took short for her.

"Aww, she looks so cute."

Micah smiled “Yeah, she’s cute that’s for sure. Very sweet, a little shy and timid”

George walked in and settled into his office, as he was a business lawyer full-time and a part-time museum operator with his husband. He brought Bow with him, who was now going through a power Rangers phase as of yesterday, and went into the playroom. Doing karate kicks down the hall the whole way there. He was happy he got to play with Glimmer while his daddy finished up his work. When we entered the playroom, he saw Glimmer, and on the other side of the room by the train set was a new girl. A pretty girl. A pretty girl who looked to him like a tony version of the pretty blonde power ranger from one of his brother’s older VHS tapes. Kimberly.

He smiled and walked over to introduced himself to Adora before saying hi to Glimmer. This went very well noticed as Glimmer felt her jaw drop as he saw how he darted over to Adora. She glared at this. How could *her Bow* just run to Adora like that?

She sat up and walked over to see Bow introduce himself to Adora. The blonde was completely unaware of what was going on. More focused on the Thomas the Tank engine toys then the new friend coming up to her and practically shouting “HI! I’m Bow! Your pretty! You remind of the Pink Ranger from Power Rangers!” he panted a little as he saw she had no foresight to look up. He cleared his throat “Uh, hi, Ummm… I’m Bow, and I think your—” he was cut off by the sharp reply from Glimmer “She has hearing problems” walking behind Adora. “She sometimes can't hear people” unknown to her that Adora was hype-focused on the trainset and was unaware of her surroundings.

Bow frowned “Oh,” a little defeated in the fact that this new pretty girl didn’t even budge at his compliment. Glimmer walked over to him and grabbed his arm “C’mon, draw with me”

He didn’t want to leave this new potential friend just yet. He then cupped his hands around his mouth and shouted “Hi!!!! I’m Bow!!!!” causing Adora to jump a little at the loud burst of noise that flooded her senses. She looked up started to see a boy wearing a Power Rangers costume with his rangers mask in hand. The first thing to pop into her head as someone who knew what the old school Power Rangers were was to say “The Green Power Rangers name used to be Tommy”

Bow beamed at this “Yes! He’s my brother’s favorite he said as he showed her his mask; This one is the Red Ranger, the first one's name was Jason”

Glimmer rolled her eyes and tugged at Bow’s sleeve “Okay, but can we go draw now?”

Now that Bow had Adora’s attention he said “Your pretty like the Pink Ranger”

Adora just blinked in surprise at the compliment. She never got a compliment from a boy her age before. She smiled and looked down at her trains again. Feeling shy. Most boys she talked to before weren’t very nice to her. The boys at her old school picked on her for being in foster care.

Glimmer saw this and didn't like it one bit. Declaring "She's not the Pink Ranger! She's Adora"

Adora frowned at this and went back to trying to play with her trains. Bow was interested in what she was doing asked her if he could play with her instead. Now Glimmer was pissed. First Adora gets all the attention and now she steals her future husband away from her! The Nerve!

Glimmer stomped off to the other side of the room, upset her day with daddy and Adora was not turning out to be all that fun.

Sulking in the corner she watched as they played together. Kicking herself for not being able to talk about boyish stuff like Power Rangers and trains. She listened in on the conversation and apparently, Adora used to watch a lot of boy-centric cartoons in her foster home. Pokemon, YuGiOh, Dragon Ball Z, and Power Rangers, since there were older boys in the house and when the boys would watch the little kids they always chose to watch whatever Kyle and Rogelio liked. Adora didn't mind, nor did Catra, Lonnie sometimes got mad because she wasn't to watch Finding Nemo or Dora and the boys wouldn't let her.

One of the paralegal ladies came in to bring them juice and cookies. She saw how Adora ate. Like a little piglet, she practically inhaled the cookies and drank the juice box like it was a race was she rushed to a corner in the room away from her and Bow. Unknown to her, Adora was conditioned to eat like this. In the foster home of greedy kids, some teenagers being on strict diets, she and the other small children would have to inhale their snacks or disk them being eaten on them. It had happened to Catra and Kyle too many times where they would put down a chip

or cookie, only to have someone else take it from them. Adora knew the tears and the pain of going hungry, so eating her snacks in a corner was a safety precaution she was familiar with. When she was finished she walked back to Bow, who found her a little less like Kimberly after watching her eat like that.

In the corner of her eye, she spotted an orange bouncing ball. Seeing Adora walk back over to the train set table she kicked it with her foot, hoping it would knock her in the back of the legs or something. She had no real reason to do it, but she wanted some sort of reaction.

It didn't hit her in the back of the legs, instead hit Adora in the ankle as her foot was off the ground and caused her trip. Fumbling forward she fell face-first on the corner of the table. Bow looked in horror as he saw Adora's face hit the corner.

Glimmer gasped in fear. Scared she hurt her. She didn't want to hurt Adora, just startle her. To her dismay, she heard Bow exclaim in horror. "She's bleeding!" he cried jumping up to see if Adora was okay. The blonde girl clutched her face with one hand. Her lip and mouth were bleeding. On the other free hand, she used her yellow sleeve to wipe off her chin. Looking down at the ground she saw she didn't bleed on the carpet or the table. Sore, she felt the loose tooth her mouth become from her gums. The taste of blood ruined the after taste of sweet juice from just a moment ago. It hurt. Her lip and mouth hurt. The fall made her loose baby tooth come out much faster than it should have. Looking over to Glimmer, the older brunette girl saw the hurt and pain in Adora's teary eyes. Bow asking Glimmer "Why would you do that?"

Glimmer stammered "I—I didn't mean to make her trip, I," she stopped and saw Adora get up and walk into the corner of the room again. The same spot she had her snack at and sat in the corner in a style akin to being placed in time out. Trying to self-soothe her wound she put her bloody baby tooth in freehand while her other hand used her sleeve to soak up the blood gushing from her lip. She didn't open her mouth, so the blood coming from her gums wouldn't go all over the place.

She didn't know how to process this. Glimmer hurt her. Glimmer was mean. She can't do anything about it. Sue wanted her if Glimmer didn't like her that she would be sent away to a group home, and group homes beat kids. If she cried out in pain she might upset Micah at his work. She didn't want to be punished. She held back her sobs until Micah came into check on them. Happily unaware of what just took place her asked "Okay, girls, daddy's done with work, we can go get ice cream now" he looked around the room to see Bow and Glimmer looking mortified, their eyes focused on Adora on the opposite side of the room. When he looked over he saw her in the corner.

Joking he asked as he walked over "What did you do? Put yourself in timeout?"

Adora looked up to him fearfully. Exposing her swollen lip and bloody face. He gasped as he saw she got blood all over her sleeves and shirt.

"Adora!? Baby? What happened?" he said. Worried. She wasn't crying or screaming, but she definitely must be in pain.

Adora croaked out, trying to hold back her tears "I—I fell, I tripped and fell. I'm s-sorry. I, I didn't m-mean to r-ruin the day" she whimpered.

Micah sighed "Oh, sweetie," in a soft gesture he tried to stroke her cheek only to receive a flinch from Adora. Fearing she was going to be hit for getting blood on her new clothes. Micah looked over to the other kids and asked "I heard a thud just a minute ago, was this what just happened?" pointing to Adora.

Bow cried "Yes! She fell and started bleeding" he looked to Glimmer hoping she confessed to tripping Adora by kicking the toy ball at her. Instead in shame Glimmer looked down at the ball and just nodded. Bow was shocked she didn't say anything else. He saw Micah attempt to comfort Adora while the little blonde whimpered "I'm sorry. I didn't mean it"

Guilt flooded Glimmer's chest as she realized what she had done. She hurt Adora, and Adora wasn't even going to tattle on her. Instead, Adora thought she was in trouble. Micah got the girls. To get ready to leave. Telling them they would go get ice cream another day. This now made Adora cry. Fearing she ruined the day and also upset that she wasn't going to have ice cream. She only had ice cream four times in her life and was sad to miss out on a chance to have some.

Glimmer knew she didn't deserve ice cream after what she did, but she couldn't bring herself to admit to her father that she was mean to Adora. She felt a million times worse when her mother got home and Adora started to bawl in her eyes out for what happened. Adora apologizing profusely overrunning her shirt and ruining the day by being bad and getting hurt.

This disturbing revelation had Angella and Micah talking down in the laundry room while they assumed both girls were upstairs. Glimmer snuck down and was listening in on their conversation.

She heard her mother explain "I don't care about the shirt. I can buy her fifty new shirts, I don't see why she got upset over that"

Her father replied "She was more upset about ice cream and need to come back home than anything. She has a high pain tolerance because I thought she would have been screaming. I mean, she lost a tooth and busted open her lip. Now she has two gaps in her mouth from missing baby teeth and her lip is swollen"

Her mother sighed "She has bruises on her arm too, she must not be aware of her surroundings. It seems to be a major sensory issue she has. I think she should be re-evaluated for her hearing aids. If she isn't listening well, it might be the fact that *State Medical* didn't diagnose her properly"

Her dad then softly suggested "I think we need to evaluate her for something else too,"

"What?" she asked.

His voice became a little more serious as he explained "I think Adora is on the *spectrum*."

A pause came over the room as she heard her mother's voice elevate to a tone that she knew was anger.

"She is not on the spectrum! She's just adjusting to her new life!"

"Angie…."

She defended "She just needs time to adjust, Micah. Even if we get her evaluated, what do you think that will do? The social workers and pediatric doctors will just try to pump her up with medication. Have you seen with a misdiagnosis has done!? Because I have! And believe me, the ramifications of a bad diagnosis are worst than anything to a child" she said in a huff. Leaving the room she saw Glimmer in the hallway. Giving her daughter a disappointed look she scolded her "Young lady, we do not eavesdrop" before leaving to her bedroom.

Glimmer frowned and went upstairs to check on Adora. Seeing her door was closed she opened it. Seeing Adora was nowhere in sight. She called to her. "Adora?"

Adora meekly replied "I'm in here"

Glimmer followed the voice to the closet and opened it. She saw Adora huddled in the closet with her old clothes scattered around

her and her old toys in her hands. Glimmer asked, "How come your in here?"

Adora replied "It makes me feel safe"

Glimmer frowned and sat on the floor outside the closet "Why didn't you tell Daddy I tripped you?"

Adora nervously answered "If, if, if Micah and Angella find out you don't like me, I'll get sent away to a group home. I—I don't want to get sent to a group home"

Glimmer's mouth gaped open a little. She had never heard this before. If she didn't like Adora she would have to set sent away.

Adora then asked in almost a pleading tone "If I don't bother you, will you let me stay?"

Glimmer felt her mouth go dry. This new emotion of knowing she can make Adora's life miserable was a disgusting feeling she did not know how to process at age eight. The idea her parents would send her away made her fearful. What if they stopped liking Adora? Would that mean they would send Adora away? She didn't want that.

Glimmer asked, "Do you want me to tell Daddy it was my fault?"

Adora shook her head violently “No! if they find out you don’t like me they’ll send me away! Please don’t!” she said with tears forming in her eyes again.

Glimmer felt her body go cold as she saw Adora plead for this.

Trying to hold back tears herself she nodded and told Adora she wouldn’t.

Adora promised her “I won't try and make you made again”

Glimmer stood up. Unsure of what to say she just closed the door to the closet to leave Adora alone.

She walked back to her bedroom and closed the door regretting all her actions. She heard a knock on her door and it was her father asking her “Are you, okay Princess?”

Glimmer wanted to cry. She loved her daddy so much. Would he make Adora leave? She couldn’t just tell him what happened. That would be lying and bullying. Like Lindsay Lohan in that one movie. She didn’t want to be Lindsay Lohan. *No one does.*

She softly replied “I’m sad for Adora,”

He agreed “Yeah she got a bad boo-boo.”

Glimmer then admitted “I kicked a ball at her and she tripped. I didn’t mean to get her hurt” her confession turned teary “S-she starting bleeding and s-she said if, if I don’t like her you and mommy will send her away” she softly started to cry into her father’s arms. He softly comforted her “Oh, sweetie, we would never do that. Why didn’t you tell me earlier?”

Glimmer sniffled “I was scared to get in trouble for being mean. I don’t want to be a bully, like Lindsay Lohan or Ellen Degenerate.”

Micah wanted to laugh at Glimmer calling in Degenerate instead of DeGeneres. He assured her “You did the right thing by telling me, but you should have said something earlier. Adora is…. A little different, she might not tell us right away if she needs something or if something is wrong, I need you to be the nicest and best big sister for her, okay?”

He kissed her forehead.

She promised, “I will daddy, I’m the best big sister, I promise.”

While they had their sweetheart to heart. Adora stimmed fearfully, while Angella had to come to face the reality that Adora may have autism. She thought to herself about what she needed

to do for her. Whatever it was she would do it. It bothered her so much they Adora went this long in her development and didn't receive better from Sue or the State. It made her think about all the other children in foster. What are they all going without and what about Adora's little friend Catra? Heaven knows what cruelty takes place behind that House in Horde grove.

A day with Mommy

Chapter Summary

Angella tries to access Adora's needs after coming to the realization that she might be autistic.

It’s normal for Adora to feel fear. At Sue’s, it was common for the older kids to bully the smaller ones. It was only a few certain kids that would get punished for being bad. Adora was one of the lucky small girls and didn’t get in trouble as much. Catra was punished often, usually the one to get hit or yelled at the most. She was used to it. She just wasn’t used to not being the favored one. Glimmer was mean today and nothing happened to her. Even if she told Micah she tripped her, it might have been worse for her. When Catra told Sue about the older kids being mean, Sue would yell at Catra still. At dinner, Glimmer sat close to Adora. Making the blonde uneasy. If Glimmer wanted to, she could knock over her drink, or punch her in the leg if she wanted, she flinched when Glimmer moved. This caught Angella’s attention. Micah had left out the detail that he knew Glimmer was the cause of Adora’s busted lip. Still sore, her lip and mouth were sensitive to the touch, and to her dismay, Angella made pasta with chunky tomato sauce. The acid from the tomatoes burned Adora’s lip. She tried not to show a pained reaction to it. She didn’t like that Angella put vegetables in her pasta. But she couldn’t tell her she didn’t like vegetables. Sue would send them to bed without dinner if they didn’t like the food they were given, usually, Sue didn’t make them eat vegetables, it was usually spaghetti, mac, and cheese, hot dogs, or chicken nuggets. There was routine. In this home. There was no routine. Adora hated not knowing what the next day will bring. Despite being hungry, she didn’t ask for seconds. When Glimmer got out of her chair she walked past Adora, who quickly hugged herself in preparation for an attack. Again, Angella saw this and glared at her husband. She knew what was going on and she wasn’t happy about it.

A short time later both little girls were off to bed. Adora getting into her bed reluctantly as Angella closed the door on her. In her heart, she felt something was wrong.

Adora sat in her bed for a while. Still scared of being in a room by herself. She didn't like it and now her tummy was growling. She whimpered. She wanted more food. Getting out of bed and opening her bedroom door she peered around the dark hallway. Quietly going downstairs to the pantry. She opened the door to the pantry and saw all the organized assorted foods and cleaning products. On the bottom, a row was paper towels, toilet paper, and cleaning sprays. The row above was napkins, plastic cutlery, and some empty lunch boxes and bags, the row above that, was dried foods, like pasta, rice, and canned foods, this row had familiar foods to Adora, ketchup, mustard, vinegar, peanut butter, and Nutella. Those she was familiar with. The other shelf she couldn't reach, but she saw what she wanted to see. Cereal! Open boxes of cereal! If she took and ate a handful of cereal no one would be able to tell, she wouldn't get in trouble. She desperately reached for it on her tiptoes. Lucky to grasp the box of puffins. A cereal she never had before but looked forward to eating. For a moment she paused and looked around. Doing this was bad, if she got caught, she would be in so much trouble. Glimmer would tattle on her, Micah was the biggest person in the house, he could easily hit her, and she would be in pain, Angella was the one she wasn't sure about. Would Angella hit her? She already made mistakes yesterday, trying to wash dishes, and getting hurt and bleeding on her shirt, if Angella saw her stealing cereal she might give up on Adora and send her away. With another growl in her tummy, Adora stepped back from the pantry and closed the door. She moved a chair from the table and crawled under the kitchen dining table. She and Catra used to do this when they tried to sneak food after bed. They knew Sue wouldn't bend down and get them. If she did catch them, she would just try and hit them with a broom handle. In her fearful silence, she tried to eat tiny handfuls of dry cereal until she felt full.

Angella tossed and turned a little in bed. In her heart, she felt something wasn't right. Something was wrong in her home. Seeing Micah sleep beside her, she watched him rest for a bit. Nothing out of the ordinary. His soft snoring was as normal as ever. Getting up she put her robe over her nightgown and walked down the hall. Opening Glimmer's bedroom, she saw the little brunette sleeping soundly. Nothing was wrong here. She peeked into Adora's room and saw she wasn't in her bed. Frowning she figured she still wasn't accustomed to sleeping in her new bed. She frowned she looked in the closet. The same spot she found her the previous night sleeping. To her horror, she saw she wasn't there. She looked around her room and realized Adora wasn't hiding in her room. She started to panic. She left the room and checked the bathroom. She wasn't there. Rushing downstairs, she tried to keep calm. Her daughter was missing. Looking around the living room she turned the lights on and saw Adora was not there. She walked into the kitchen fearing all the worst things possible. Her new baby girl could have left the house, could have been kidnapped? Anything!

The second she was ready to scream in horror was when she saw the tiny bare feet under the kitchen table. Relieved she quickly moved the chair hiding Adora away from her and squatted down to see her. To her surprise, Adora was in the fettle position with a box of cereal in her hand. The small child looked terrified at the sight of Angella. The fast movement of the chair being pulled away made her think of Sue when they got caught out of their beds after dark. Hungry, Adora tossed and turned unable to sleep due to her aching tummy. Desperate for food she tried to eat some cereal without getting caught. Angella came downstairs in a panic, Adora hid under the kitchen table. Typically, Sue wouldn't bend down to get them. Usually, she would try and swat them with a broom, but Angella was much healthier than Sue is, and she was able to get Adora from under the table. Adora knew she was in trouble. Being a bad girl, out of bed, and stealing food.

This might be the last straw. After bleeding at Micah's job and Glimmer not liking her, Angella might beat her for all the mess she has caused.

Angella was just so relieved to see she was just downstairs. She placed her hand on her chest and sighed. "Adora, honey I was so worried," Adora slides the cereal box over to Angella and darted the other side of the table knocking a chair down and making a loud thud she yelped in a panic and ran upstairs terrified of the outcome of what she had just done. In terror, she dashed to her closet. Heart racing and her body trembling in fear.

She heard the footsteps of her adoptive mother enter her room she curled into a ball and tensed her body. Her throat was dry, and she braced herself for a beating.

Instead, Angella softly opened her closet door and got down on her knees to be at eye level with Adora. In a worried tone. "Adora sweetie why did you run? Did you hurt yourself?" Adora couldn't tell what Angella's motive was. If she moved closer and let herself be open to Angella, she could get a beating. She would get *pow-pows.* Sue would speak softly to her when she was in trouble, and when Adora's guard was down she would pull her by her ponytail and smack her. She feared that. Angella has never hit her yet. But she deserved it. She was stealing. That cereal wasn't for her and she knows that.

Adora needed to grovel. If she apologized, she might only get a little hurt. She stuttered "I—I sorry, I was-wasn't b—being b—bad."

Angella couldn't understand why she was reacting like this. She extended out her arms for Adora to embrace her. Adora crawled to Angella, dreading the punishment. She wanted to hug her and feel that everything was okay, but she knew it wasn't. Adora's head was down. Angella hugged and patted her head in a way to comfort her. She felt Adora's little body shake under her touch.

In a moment of silence, Angella offered to her "Baby, if you were hungry you could have had a snack. Do you want me to make you a snack?"

Adora nodded. This could be a trap. She still didn't know Angella very well. She had such an intimidating demeanor about her that Adora was desperate to please, she wanted her new mom to love her. Maybe this was a sign she liked her and wanted her to stay.

Angella helped her up. The small child still fearful went downstairs. Adora was still untrusting. She looked around the kitchen and saw in detail how clean and polished this home was compared to her former one. A much sturdier table that was prettier with bigger chairs, it was nothing like the old wooden wobbly dining table she remembered from Sue's house. The marble top tables and granite flooring was pretty, and it also sent a shiver down her tiny spine at what would happen if she was slammed into the floor or the table. It would hurt. Looking around the cabinets she saw wine glasses hanging and pots and pans hanging from some ceiling thing. At any time Angella could easily take a glass, a pot, or a chair to throw at her. Without thinking, she was slowly backing away from Angella in the kitchen. Unknown to the mother as she opened the freezer door. She turned to Adora and asked, "Would you like something sweet?"

She saw Adora backed into the corner of the entrance. Adora nodded.

Angella questioned, “Why are you backing away?”

Adora moved forward and apologized again.

Angella asked her “Would you like ice cream?”

Adora’s face lit up. Ice cream? Really? She was going to get a yummy treat? Daddy didn’t take them to ice cream since she had messed up and got hurt at his job yesterday. She was so upset over it.

Adora nodded and made an audible squeak.

Finally showing positive emotions.

Angella was relieved that Adora was finally showing some form of happiness. She placed a bowl down on the table and Adora watched Angella placed two scoops of chocolate ice cream. Angella watched as the little child watch the bowl. Angella decided to make it a sundae. She put some chocolate sprinkles and whipped cream on top of it and took the bowl to the table gesturing for Adora to follow her. Getting a spoon for the little

child she saw Adora's eye light up at eating ice cream. The small child smiled at Angella.

Angella sat next to her, placing one hand under her chin she smiled at the child. Finally seeing the little girl look happy. She hoped this would make her Adora's favorite. Micah was already Glimmer's favorite parent. There was no question there. Glimmer's Father's Day card to Micah this year said "Favorite parent" on it. She wanted some sort of favor with Adora. She didn't have that connection with Glimmer. She knew her daughter loved her, but when it came to parents, she favored it was always Micah. She wanted Adora to favor her, she wanted Adora to be her *baby girl*.

While Adora got to slowly taste the sweet treat that was ice cream she let a spoon full rest on her lip. Still hurting from what happened earlier in the day.

Angella asked, "Does it hurt still baby?"

Adora nodded as she put the rest of the ice cream in her mouth.

Angella had her suspicion of what happened earlier. The flinching and fearful way she acted towards Glimmer during dinner time indicated to Angella that something wasn't right. Adora just falling and losing a baby tooth didn't make sense. Micah was covering something up.

Angella asked, “How did your boo-boo happen?”

Adora looking down at her empty bowl and replying, “I fell on accident.”

Knowing it was a lie she offered “I know what happened sweetie, you can tell me the truth, be honest with me”?

As inviting as this was supposed to be, these were the same words Sue used to trick her into saying things that would get Catra or someone else in trouble. Then make Adora watch the beatings. She didn’t want to sell out Glimmer for what happened in case Angella was secretly a mean mom. She didn’t want to be lied to. She wanted to show she was a smart little girl.

What came out of her mouth was deeply unsettling for Angella to hear.

Adora wanted to sound smart. She wanted Angella to know she knew her place “I not your real daughter…. I know if, I’m bad I—I, I w-will be sent a-away. I—I don’t w-want to b-be bad and g-go away”

Angella’s face fell at what Adora’s realization was to her circumstance. Did Adora truly feel like she would be sent away at any slight incident?

Angella asked Adora “Sweetie, who told you that?”

Adora without hesitation “S-Sue, she told m-me, that I—I need to be g-good or—or I will get sent away”

Angella shook her head “Adora, sweetheart, I will never send you away”

Adora looked down cautiously at the bowl. Could she trust Angella?

Angella asked, “Did Glimmer see you fall?”

Adora nodded hesitantly.

She then asked, “Did Glimmer make you fall on accident or purpose?”

Adora tried to not shift all the blame on Glimmer “S-she k-kicked the ball a-at my f-feet, and then I fell. I -fell on a-accident and hurt myself.”

Angella’s suspicions were validated. In her mind she was livid. Not only did Micah and Glimmer not tell her about the real reason Adora got hurt. Conveniently Micah never mentioned it. Glimmer

should not get a free pass for being mean, eight-years-old, or not. She needed to address this poor behavior now or Glimmer could become a bully to her new sister.

She watched Adora scratch the back of her head hard and this triggered Angella to ask, "Is your head always itchy?"

Adora nodded. Looking down at her empty bowl she asked "C—can I sleep with m-my light on? The dark scares me, a-and I'm all by m-myself."

Angella offered "Would you like for me to stay with you in your room until you fall asleep?"

Adora nodded and Angella got her settled into bed. She noted Adora's movements and lack of eye contact. She started to feel that Micah might be right about Adora being on the autistic spectrum. She was saddened by this. She loves Adora no matter what. She just felt like Adora was more neglected by the State. There was no way her former teachers and doctors didn't suspect anything. She wanted Adora to have the best life possible.

Adora cuddled up to her. She watched as the little girl began to drift off to sleep. She stayed for a little while longer after she fell asleep. Just to make sure she was in a deep slumber before getting up from the bed.

It wasn't until the morning when getting the girls ready for the day was when Angella made her aggression towards Micah clear. Letting him sleep in longer. The way was planned for Glimmer to be with her aunt while Angella took Adora to all her new doctors' appointments. She would see her new pediatrician, dentist, and eye doctor. She also wanted to get her a tiny haircut as she noticed the little girl had some dead ends, and it looked like her hair was a little uneven in the back with her hair down.

While the girls ate breakfast together. She made them eat yogurt and berries. Something Adora never had before.

Micah came down extra chipper. He walked over to his wife and tried to kiss her "Morning, love"

Only to have Angella coldly reply. "Good morning, *Micah*"

Micah's eyes widened*. Oh no. I messed up something.*

She never calls him by her first name unless he has messed up. He didn't know what could have gotten him in trouble. He didn't leave the toilet seat up or park in her spot or anything. He hasn't missed any anniversaries or bills due, so what could have Angie mad?

He sat next to Glimmer and glanced over to Adora, seeing some discomfort in her face as he sat at the table. He saw that her

chair was slightly shuffled closer to Angella as if she didn't want to be close to Glimmer or him.

As Angella sat down at aggressively placed his plate down, he figured out what must have happened. Adora must have told Angella about how she hurt her lip before Micah could tell Angella he knew Glimmer did it on accident.

He shot Adora a look as she ate. This little girl might be timid, but her timing to form drama is spot on to a child that is a manipulator. If she was honest yesterday with all of them, there would be now impending discord. The last thing he needs today is Angella to get into a *mood.*

As the two girls got up at the same time. Adora still was jumping at Glimmer.

Micah turned to his wife asked "Sweetie, is everything okay?"

She paused for a moment to take a sip of tea and replied, "I got to have a little late-night snack with Adora last night, in talking to her I received a bit of information that verified something I was worried about yesterday."

He ponderous replied "Oh?"

She sharply answered, “You must have known that Glimmer hurt Adora, right?”

Micah replied, “Glimmer didn’t tell me until I tucked her into bed, and Adora didn’t tell me the truth when I asked her.”

Angella glared and placed her teacup down “You seem more disappointed in Adora than *Glimmah*,”

Micah defined “I’m not. I told Glimmer she shouldn’t have done that. She isn’t off the hook. But Adora does need to vocalize her problems with us, we can't read her mind.”

Angella’s eyes continue to narrow at him. Not wanting him to be right. Adora does need to tell them what is wrong with her, but she can't hold her accountable for not doing so, her upbringing has most likely left her socially delayed.

Micah then comments on what he said previously “I think when she goes to the doctor today…. You need to ask for an autism evaluation.”

Angella scoffed “You know a diagnosis takes months; they won't confirm anything until she has been tested.”

He got up from his chair and kissed her forehead “Well, we need to start the process now” with that he left her alone to her

thoughts.

He asked, "Anything you need from me while I'm about with Glimmer?"

She shook her head. She was worried for Adora. It started to stew with Angella that Adora may be on the spectrum. She had noticed some of Adora's traits were akin to someone on the spectrum. It made her worry about what to do and what if Adora does have autism. What if Adora becomes overstimulated and has a breakdown in a place with people. What if people cruelly judge her? What if she is bullied? Children can be so cruel. Parents and adults too….. didn't want Adora to go through any additional trauma. Even as a doctor, she was not an expert in the autism field. A major misconception people had with her title was that they assumed she was a master of all ailments, but all doctors specialize in specific fields. As a plastic surgeon working in the ER, she typically dealt with major and minor cosmetic procedures. From a guy cutting his finger off with a hacksaw by mistake or cosmetic implants, she did not a long resume in the field of mental health she felt the medical industry has failed many people as some of her most damaged patients are addicted to medication. As a woman who swears by multiple vitamins and has a zero-pain killer policy for her family. She dreaded the potential medication cocktail they might brew up for Adora.

In their bedrooms, Adora looked panicked at all the bright colors and different patterns of her new clothes. Sue made them dress so plain, white, red, black, grey, sometimes brown, but Adora was looking at yellow shirts, blue shirts, shirts with stripes and designs on them. Picking out clothes yesterday was bad enough, she had to ask Glimmer for help and Micah teased her for taking too long. She didn't want to ask Glimmer for help or ask her new dad.

They were mean to her. She needed to avoid them. She picked out her shirt and pants based on comfort. A familiar color she liked, a new pair of red sweatpants and a grey shirt with buttons on it. To her it was comfy. The shirt looked nice and the pants felt good. In reality, she was a mismatched mess. A dressy shirt with comfy casual pants. With her dirty old sneakers because they felt comfortable. Her hope was Angella would like her the most in this house. She gave her ice cream last night. That might be a sign she is loved by Angella. If Micah and Glimmer don't like her, she can at least be loved by Angella. In foster care she knew Sue didn't love them, *she wasn't getting paid enough by the State to love them*, but she knew Catra loved her, and her other foster friends did.

Stepping out of her room she looked up to see Angella. Unable to read her face she mistook Angella's puzzled look for one of excitement. Adora thought Angella was happy to see her. Adora raised her arms a little and declared "Ready,"

Angella couldn't tell if Adora was being serious or not. Nothing she wore matched.

Angella questioned "Are you being funny?" assuming Adora's silly mismatching was a joke.

Adora was unsure by her tone that Angella was either questioning or furious with her. The blonde jumped a little and stuttered "T-these, these feel soft, I—I like them," she looked around and saw that Micah and Glimmer had poked their heads out from their rooms to see Angella speaking to Adora. The blonde looked down in humiliation. Her face turning red as she realized she is making herself look bad in front of her entire new family.

"She needs extra help with picking out clothes Angie, I picked out her outfit yesterday,"

Adora looked at him with a hurt expression as her mouth opened a little. He just tattled on her in front of Angella. This didn't feel like such a big deal to anyone else, Angella didn't mind picking out Adora's outfit for the day. For Adora, it felt like she was doing something wrong.

Angella ushered Adora back into her room to get her a better outfit for today. Angella was happier about this, she had picked out so many cute clothes for Adora, she was happy to get her in something she picked out. Adora sat on her bed, taking her shoes off, and looking sadly at the ground. Angella joyfully picked out a brown jumper and a white shirt. Picking out brown dress shoes to go with it. She was happy to show Adora this bright and cheery outfit. Unable to hide her sadness Adora just nodded. Angella left the room to give her privacy to get dressed. When she emerged, she noticed Adora was distracting her head again. Still unable to put her hair up herself, she was wearing it down again.

Heading downstairs Angella saw Glimmer and Micah head off. Micah informed her "We're going to go to the park first, and then I'm going to drop her off at Lance's so she can play with Bow today."

Adora heard the words "Park" and rushed downstairs. Squeezing her feet in the tight dress shoes Angella picked out for her. They hurt her feet, but she knew she had to deal with it unless she wanted to anger her new mother any further. Adora rushed to

Angella's side looking up at her with a pleading hope that she was going to the park too. She stuttered "A-are, we going to-to the park?"

Angella frowned and shot a look at Micah for saying it out loud that he was taking Glimmer somewhere fun without her. Angella dreaded saying it, but she had to let Adora down.

"No, sweetie," she said to Adora. "Today we are taking you to the doctors and then to the dentist and the salon, okay?"

Adora frowned and asked, "C-can I go to the park later?"

Angella looked at her sadly "It will be too late, love, I will take you another time,"

Adora looked down again. She nodded in sadness.

All three of them could feel the uncomfortable tension. Glimmer felt bad that she was going now. It dawned on Adora that she was not getting the same treatment as Glimmer was. She realized she was far from favored in her new home. She gave a glance up to Micah. *He doesn't like me.* Adora thought. *Boys are so mean and bad! Big adult boys are the meanest! Sue was right! Men are mean!*

Micah and Glimmer said their goodbyes. Micah giving Angella a hug and a Kiss on the lips before leaving. He leaned down to try and kiss Adora's forehead. Only to have the little one put her hands up in defense and back away. She hid behind Angella, causing the three of them to feel even more awkward than before. Inadvertently offending Glimmer and Angella in the process and hurting Micah's feelings by rejecting the affection. Angella let out a light gasp. Micah felt his heartbreak a little at Adora's rejection. Adora looked up into his eyes with a mixed look of fear and hatred. If yesterday's incident was bad, then today was proof Adora was not in the least bit fond of Micah, or Glimmer, as the blonde shot her brunette sister a look.

Angella frowned at this gesture as the two left and got her purse and got Adora in the car.

Pulling out Angella wanted to scold Adora for being cold but was unsure how to handle the situation. If Adora was autistic, then affection might upset her. She cant be cross with her over her being unable to generously enjoy affection. She frowned at the thought of not being able to hug her new daughter.

The doctor's office was something Adora was not happy about. *Glimmer gets to play and I have to get shots.*

Adora sat on the bench, shoes off. Looking down at her feet. She nervously glanced at Angella on her phone. She wanted to say something to catch Angella's interest. She knew she had nothing exciting to say to her new mother. She knew the park was out of the question, she also knew she had to go to the dentist and eye doctor today too. She didn't want to go to any of those places.

The doctor came, examined Adora, asked her some questions, checked her tongue, eyes, ears, and heart rate. He asked Adora how she was feeling. Adora with thinking told him the truth "Sad," catching Angella off guard he asked, "Aw, why are you sad?"

Adora didn't look at him and replied "I—I gotta get shots, and I can't go to the park today, b-because I need to go to the doctor."

The doctor gave an uncomfortable look to Angella. He was in the odd place of watching Angella look as if she saw someone kick her puppy.

The situation became more depressing as Adora received two shots. The little girl wince and whimper under the sting of the needles. In a small attempt to cheer the near sobbing child, the doctor offered her a lollipop and offered for her to go back into the kids waiting while he talked to Angella in private.

He leaned against the bench and asked Angella about how she felt. "I take it Adora, has been in foster care for her whole life?"

Angella agreed and confirmed she had a lot of friends in her foster home and at her old school.

He asked her "Is she on the spectrum? Nothing on her files indicates she was examined for autism."

"We were hoping to get her a diagnosis. All her records indicate she was presumed to be partially deaf but come to find out that might not be the case at all."

"Does she use hearing aids?"

Angella shook her head "Not since we adopted her… she doesn't focus on people's faces or makes eye contact. She flinches and backs away from us at any inclination of physical affection,"

He asked Angella in a softer and concerned tone "Is it confirmed or speculated she has been abused? Physical? Mentally? sexually?"

Angella felt a chill. Worried about what things happened to Adora in Sue's care. She shook her head and answered, "We think there was neglect and disciplinarian abuse, we are unsure of anything else."

He recommended, "I believe she needs to see an autism specialist and therapist for the mentally challenged and retarded children."

Angella let out a fake cough "Uh, retarded isn't a word most medical professionals use anymore, Doctor Sterns."

Angella felt mild offense at him referring to Adora as *mentally challenged*. Why are all words to describe a child or person with different needs too offensive? Seriously, why it takes the medical field so long to stop using the word retard?

He didn't take her offensive seriously and shrugged it off "Medical terms change so frequently, I've been practicing medicine longer than you, my dear, I'm over sixty."

Angella wanted too badly to snap at him but didn't due to not wanting to affect Adora and her needs. She accepted the referral.

Of all times she wished she could slam a door, the pediatrician's office only had anti-slam doors.

She couldn't hide her frustration as she walked over to Adora and told her to get ready to leave. Fearful of her mother's voice she did what she asked. Not bothering to tell her that her feet hurt from the shoes. Angella was able to cool off a little in the car ride over to the dentist. While Adora was getting her teeth cleaned she made a call to the referral. Only for a familiar voice, she didn't want to hear at a time of distress.

"Etheria County Medical associates of mental health, Dr. Castaspella Angeles speaking."

Angella wanted to hang out right away. How could she have forgotten that her sister-in-law works for the same medical group she is a part of?

Angella keeps her composure as she speaks "Hello, Casta, it is your sister-in-law, I was referred to you by Adora's pediatrician,"

A short pause came over Casta as she replied bitterly "Oh, Adora is home with you now? Lovely, I remember asking you about telling me when she came home so we can throw her a party, but I guess that was too much to ask for, right?"

Angella replied sharply "This is a professional call, Casta, so let's put in a pin in that topic for another day, shall we?"

She heard Casta exhale deeply through her nose before asking "How may I help you, *Doctor Brighton*."

Angella grinned at being called by her professional name.

"Adora may need a diagnosis, she is speculated to be on the spectrum. Due to her being on State medical her whole life, it went undetected, so we need to set up a therapy session with you to discern her actual needs".

She dreaded whatever smart remark was going to come.

Casta surprised her with a supportive reply "Of course, we can have her in a session this week, and I can make some home calls for her, I can even stop by today,"

Angella blinked and thought for a second. Casta being over would not be the most fun for her, but Adora's needs are the most important thing right now.

Angella agreed for Castaspella to visit today. She hoped Casta would be a subtle introduction. A partnered aunt that lives close, hopefully not too over the top. If Adora is autistic, an overly affectionate, loud, and in-your-face aunt might be traumatizing. If she rejected Micah's affection, she would defiantly reject Casta's. she hopes she rejects Casta… then she can try to get a different therapist referral. Angella immediately stopped herself from thinking that. She wanted Adora to love the entire family; even Castaspella. Even though Casta had wronged Angella in the past, and only Angella is still hurt by it, it doesn't mean she would want Micah, Glimmer, or Adora to look at her differently.

Adora's appointment was over. She got a sticker for having clean teeth. Getting her tooth knocked out yesterday had no dangerous side effects as it was already loose. She also got a paddle ball from the density for losing a tooth.

In the car, Angella started talking on her phone with an associate on the Bluetooth speaker. Adora nervously darted her eyes around the backseat. Looking out the windows she had no idea where she was going. Where she was and when they would get to the next stop. After two appointments and being a good

patient girl, the juice she had for breakfast had now filled her bladder and she needed to go the bathroom. Badly. Usually, Sue wouldn't keep them out all day for appointments. Adora still had another appointment to go to. Would Angella not let her go to the bathroom if she asked. She looked at Angella from the back seat*. She is on the phone with work. She might yell at me for interrupting. Or, she might say I can't go*. Adora crossed her legs tightly and squirmed. *If I make an accident, I'll get pee on me and the car! Angella will be even madder at me!*

Her eyes watered a little. She wanted to cry she had to pee so bad. Angella has been on the phone for minutes now, and she had no way of telling her anything!

she noticed Adora was uncomfortably squirming in the back.

She asked her "Adora, do you need the restroom?"

The child nodded and held herself.

Angella ended her call.

Pulling into a McDonald's parking lot so Adora could go in and use the restroom. Sitting in the fast-food establishment she internally cringed at the disgusting food smell. She was one of the biggest supporters of banning unhealthy foods. She hated everything about McDonald's, Burger King, Wendy's, and Subway! She finally

noticed Adora limping a little as she walked out of the bathroom, she asked her "Are your feet okay?"

Adora nervously replied "T-the back of my feet h-hurt,"

She gestured for Adora to sit down at the table with her so she could examine her feet. "Show mommy,"

Adora paused and thought for a second what Angella meant by that. Remember Angella is technically mommy to her now she lifted her foot and Angella took her little brown dress shoe off. To her shock, she saw that the heel was red from blood! Adora's sock was bloody too!

Angella gasped and asked Adora "Sweetie, why didn't you say anything?" her voice getting a little shrill. Catching the glare of two other moms sitting a few tables away. Adora mistook her shrill question for disappointment and instantly started crying. Now people were starring at Angella and Adora.

Adora sputtered out "S-sorry I—I didn't mean to ruin m-my shoes."

Covering her eyes as she cried Angella awkwardly tried to shush the weeping child but to no avail. Some mothers gave her a dirty look, as to them they thought Angella was scolding Adora for ruining her shoes instead of worrying about her daughter's well-being. Glimmer was never a crier. Adora was a much more

sensitive child. Adora calmed down a little. Rubbing her eyes, she bit at her forearm. Angella jumped a little at this. *Is this where her bruises came from?*

Angella took Adora's arm and examined it. Seeing the fresh bite mark and two older bruises in the middle of healing. She looked back up at Adora. The smaller child tensing up. Preparing for slap. Angella noticed Adora's fearfulness and gently rubbed her forearm. "Sweetie? Why did you bite yourself?"

Adora couldn't keep her eyes focused on her new mother. Looking away she softly replied "I don't know… I—I j-just do it. I always did it"

For a parent; especially a doctor this was a painful explanation. Unable to control stims that can hurt her must be awful for Adora. This sweet little girl must have gone through so much. How can Angella communicate with Adora? She didn't respond to her the way Glimmer did. She cocked her head a little to the right and asked her "Honey, where all these appointments too much for you today?"

Adora hesitantly nodded and meekly replied "My arms and mouth hurt a little"

Her mother asked, "Would you like to go to the salon another day?"

Adora nodded and fidgeted with her hands.

Angella looked around. She had to turn today around. She had made all this up to Adora. Of course, a little kid wouldn't understand and just settle for a day of nothing but doctor's appointments. Her knowing that Glimmer is off playing must have made today ten times worse for her.

This McDonalds' has a play place.

She asked Adora "Sweetie, if you let mommy bandage up your feet, you can play in the play place, and after I will get you a happy meal. How does that sound?"

Adora's eye went wide as she beamed. "R-really?"

Angella nodded. She finally got Adora to smile at her genuinely; it was the first time since the first time Adora met her back last spring.

She placed bandages on the back of Adora's little feet and she watched as Adora went off to play. She was happy to see only two other children were in the play place and the two made friends with Adora fast. Angella did her best to ignore the fact that the play place looked a little dirty and she could only imagine how black the bottoms of Adora's feet will be after, but it didn't matter. She was making her new baby girl happy.

She sent a text to Micah and Casta to let them know their plans had changed.

After the time of play and getting something to eat, Adora was happy.

They were on their way home.

Carrying Adora in, Angella had Adora in her arms. One hand had her purse and another wear the ruined shoes and socks from Adora's outfit. Adora asked her "Am I too heavy?"

Angella shook her head "No, baby you are okay"

Adora tightened her grip around Angella and commented "I eat a lot of food. I like food,"

Angella chuckled "That's good, sweetheart."

Adora rested her head on Angella's shoulder as Angella made her way to the door. She commented in a soft voice, free of stuttering "I like when you say that."

Angella questioned “Say what?”

Adora lifted her head. “When you say sweetheart, and baby, and sweetie. It’s like how the moms at school and the park talk to their kids,”

Angella frowned at this. The young girl must have heard how kind other parents were to their children and longed for it.

Adora then meekly asked “I-I’m allowed to c-call, you mom? Can I?”

Angella felt her throat go a little dry. This moment she has been waiting for. She looked at Adora lovingly “Of course you can.”

Adora offered “I can c-call you, mommy?”

Angella pressed a kissed her forehead “Yes, my sweet girl,” *Don’t cry Angella! This is a big emotional milestone! Don’t ruin it.*

Opening the door she got Adora settled in. Getting her into some comfy clothes and getting her to sit down and watch some TV. She felt such a sense of relief that she was able to make Adora happier after a long day of running errands. She changed her clothes and began to make dinner when the front door opened. She smiled seeing her husband and daughter walk in. Both having smiles on their faces. Two other figures walked in after

them. Angella's smile quickly turned to a frown when she saw Castaspella walk in with gift bags in her arms, a pizza in hand, and Juliet with a 2-litter bottle of soda and another gift bag. The two former friends shared an awkward glance at each other as Casta made her presence known.

"Where is my new niece!" she beamed at Angella.

Quickly the British mother shot her a look of annoyance.

Adora sat up from the couch and looked over to all the people in the house.

Casta placed the pizza down on the kitchen table, right in front of the vegetables Angella was in the middle of cutting up. Flashing a triumphant smile at the British woman and walked back into the living room. Seeing Adora shyly sit on the couch, Casta walked over to her while extending her arms out "Oh, you must be my new niece Adora!"

Angella walked into the living room and angrily looked at Casta. Forcefully moving in on Adora's space. In a guilty and jealous thought, she wished Adora would not be fond of Casta's boisterous attitude. To her dismay Adora looked at her, giving Casta the same shy and nervous smile that she gave Angella when they first met. Casta sat next to her and commented "You are so pretty, Adora"

Adora looked down, her cheeks turning pink as she quietly replied "Y-your pretty too,"

With arms open again, Casta asked "Can your auntie have a hug?"

Angella crossed her arms, hoping for rejection. Glancing over to Micah, she knew he was wanting the same thing. Instead, Adora hugged her tightly.

Both parents looked at each other. Giving half-hearted smiles to one another. Glad for Adora to feel comfortable around Castaspella, but not proud of themselves for needing an outside source to make their daughter.

In-Laws, school and money

In the household of a Jehovah's witnesses, gifts, treat, and loving your family is all acceptable. A common misconception for those who do not take the time to understand the different values other groups have. As a doctor, Angella has been incredibly thoughtful and considerate to the Religious protocols of her patients. The emergency room is where she has seen many people take their last breath and has had been in very emotional situations with family members of the sick and dying. As a doctor, she was thanked endlessly for those who she had come across. A haunting memory of attending a funeral service at Jehovah Witness patient, who died of old age, and Angella had grown close to, she remembered the family, being referred to as a "non-witness" and watching the children of the deceased have a complete meltdown over a non-witness family member arriving and witnessing a shunning at a funeral. The pure discomfort Angella had to endure that day made her more cautious with Jehovah's witnesses. She had seen the respect they give and how fast Respect can take it away. Dealing with Sue Weaver made Angella uneasy. The short visits to see Adora was always tension-heavy as Sue kept mentioning Adora's strong faith and even going as far as to summon Adora into one of their private meetings to have the then six-year-old recite excerpts from the book of Jehovah. As a power move from Sue to make it known that Angella's Episcopalian beliefs would infringe on the beliefs Adora has been born. It could have easily been Sue's attempt to have Angella lose interest in adopting, but that never came to be. As parents, Angella and Micah will be prepared to keep Adora's beliefs her choice and agreed. If Adora wanted to, they would take turns going to Kingdom Hall with her to make her happy. This reasoning is why Angella did not make Adora's adoption such a massive deal. She didn't set up a party due to it not being in Adora's best interest. She didn't want the child to be guilty of having a party for her. Sue had made endless comments about how guilty Adora felt when they would take her for the day or

dinner, and Adora would come back and be upset due to *Jehovah* being mad at her for celebrating her soon-to-be adoption.

With no knowledge of this reason, it made anyone think the adoption wasn't nearly as big of a deal to Angella. When it a reality, it was the most important thing going on for her right now. Castaspella thought that Angella's work had cut into her time with Adora and found her sister-in-law: *The Doctor*, to be insufferable. Adora had come home days ago, and Micah was the one to tell her and to wait for when Angella says it's okay to come over and meet her. Casta did not hate Angella at all, but she did find her to be pretentious and knew her work as an E.R. doctor took time away from her family, and she had insight from Glimmer as the young child often remarked about how busy her parents were. Growing up with Micah, she remembered how much it hurt them never to see their dad or mom and how they had to fend for themselves most of the time. A person like Angella, who had two accomplished parents, would never know the feeling of wanting parents around. A boarding schoolgirl would never understand family connections the way Casta and Micah did, and it showed how Angella prioritized work over family. Nothing was further from the truth, and if the two communicated better, they would know that. A myriad of reasons is their inability to speak to each other; the biggest one was accompanying Casta for this family get-together.

Juliet Michaels. A gorgeous woman who was once a best friend to Angella. The two were attended Yale together, along with Micah. The former friends were once inseparable in all old photos and going to most events together; Juliet was Angella's maid of honor at her wedding and continued to stay in her friend's life after Glimmer was born. This was when Casta was living with Angella and Micah full-time to re-discover herself and lounge about in her brother's house while she debated on graduating or not. At that time, Juliet was around a lot and got to know Casta, and they got

to know each other so well they ended up together. This wouldn't upset Angella as much, but how the incident did it and the situation that led to their falling out made the sight of her uncomfortable. It's been years since the incident, and neither women have reached out to one another to make things right. Now, with a second child in the house, it makes for double the awkwardness as Glimmer adores both Casta and Juliet, and from the looks of it, Adora was now absolutely fascinated with them too. The two small girls sat in between the two women. Casta handing Glimmer presents to give to Adora.

"Adora, open this big one!" Glimmer said. She was excited for her little sister to get new things. Casta went all out in a matter of a two-hours and wrapped up multiple gifts for Adora. The petite blonde happily looked at the box, and Casta instructed, "Open it, sweetie, it's for you."

Adora peeled away the wrapping paper and saw a fish bubble lamp. Her delighted gasped showed how much she loved this present. She showed Glimmer, "Look, it has toy fishes!"

Glimmer smiled at her and then handed her another smaller gift. "Open this one!"

Adora happily opened and got an assorted bag of toy army soldiers and other various playsets. Several gifts in, and all Angella saw was the pure joy that came across Adora's face. An hour of unwrapping gifts made Adora smile more than she ever did around Angella. The British mother sulked in the kitchen as the rest of the family enjoyed Adora's company without her. She packed away the vegetables she had cut up for dinner and sat at the kitchen table to played on her phone to pretend to be busy

with work to hide her discomfort. When the family entered the kitchen to eat the pizza Juliet had brought, she stepped into her office—avoiding them as much as possible. She heard how happy Adora sounded with Casta.

Her adorable slight stutter told her new aunt about how good she was at school and that she can draw. Casta talked to her like a baby and cooed over her. "Aww, what else do you like, sweetheart?"

Adora, without minimal stuttering, explained, "I—I like ponies, cartoons, coloring, playing, running, and—and animals!"

Angella jealously peeked out from her office and saw that Adora was sitting close to Castaspella. Her little hand on Casta's forearm as they ate together. It filled her with jealousy. She thought she had made progress with Adora today at McDonald's, but Casta made much more progress with Adora than she has done in two days. She glanced over to see her husband giving her a disappointed look. He was not happy with her lack of interaction with the whole family. In a cowardly act of her selfishness, she chose to come out and pull a seat close to Adora and asked the child, "Sweetie, did you have a good day with mommy?" trying to derail any more of Casta's connection with Adora. The blonde child just nodded and almost froze a little with Angella being so close to her. Whenever Sue did this, it was a warning sign that Adora was not acting right. Adora worriedly asked, "I—I am good?" her little blue eyes, fearing Angella's response. The sudden change in Adora's attitude went notice by everyone sitting at the table.

Adora made the situation worse for Angella by showing Castaspella the band-aides on the back of her feet. "I—I didn't tell

An-Angella my feet were too big for the shoes, and—and I ruined them with blood," she looked up to Casta and assured her, "I—I didn't get punished, Angella let me play at McDonald's." She said, turning back to her adoptive mother. As true as it was, it didn't make Angella look that good. Adora unintentionally made Angella look like a massive *Tosser* in front of her in-law and ex-best friend. Because only a *Tosser:* British slang for asshole would not check her daughter's new shoes to make sure they aren't too tight. That was an amateur mistake. She once scolded Casta for when Glimmer was a toddler, and she tried to force shoes on Glimmer that didn't fit. Now she did it to Adora and hurt her new child because of her lack of attentiveness.

Casta could have been petty and made Angella feel bad about it. Instead, she just replied, "Oh, how nice of Angella to let you play at McDonald's" with that, Adora scooted closer to Casta—leaving Angella to feel replaced. Of course, Adora would like her aunt more right now; Casta made the perfect first welcome home impression, and all Angella did was make her take a bath. It wouldn't surprise her now if Adora kept flopping between calling her mommy and Angella now.

Glimmer rubbed more salt in the wound by telling her aunt, "Daddy took me to the park today because mommy made Adora go to the doctor and dentist."

In the corner of Angella's eye, she saw Casta roll her eyes at that and comment in her obnoxiously fake loving aunt voice, "That sounded fun, Adora, that was two doctor visits in one day, how do you feel?"

Angella wanted to leave the room, but Micah stood behind her and had his hands on the back of the chair and asked Adora, "Do you like all your new presents, baby princess?"

Adora perked up with that "I like that nickname."

Micah smiled at her "Good because you're my baby girl now" he sat, patting her head.

Glimmer beamed. "We're both princesses now. Daddy calls me princess a lot, I can be a princess, and you can be a baby princess because you're the little sister."

Adora shrugged. "Okay."

The adults chuckled, and Juliet and Angella made eye contact for a brief moment before Angella looked away, causing the other woman to frown. Adora excitedly moved her arms a little as she spoke more. Her body shifting as she told Casta about how much she liked her new lamp and wants to set it up right away. Casta stood up and helped bring up all her new toys upstairs. It angered Angella to see that Casta picked up much better things for her. A night light, stuffed animals, a blanket, sensory-friendly toys, all things Angella didn't think of. Angella bought Adora educational games and puzzles, along with books. It wasn't nearly as exciting. She hoped she would get to make a toy store trip with her soon to get her toys she was more in to and Casta beat her to the punch.

Juliet and Glimmer followed them upstairs, leaving Micah with his overly jealous wife. Not in any way pleased by how standoffish she was with Casta and Juliet; two women who wanted to share in love with the new member of the family and also help and diagnosing Adora for autism, and Angella practically washed her hands off with the situation the second Casta brought in toys and pizza.

He crossed his arms and reminded her, "You know, we set up her room, and we were going to make plans to bring her to the toy store, and we still are. Casta has been dying to meet her and wanted to make a good first impression. You did tell her to come by; you didn't think she would show up empty-handed, right?"

Of course, Micah would always side with his sister over Angella. It wasn't fair to make her feel like she was doing something wrong.

She huffed, refusing to look at him. She answered, "She could of at least told us she was coming over with gifts and dinner."

Micah didn't comment. He just looked at her. Visibly unhappy as he walked past her. "I'm going to see how they are all doing. I would love for you to come with me,"

The tall woman just looked down, ashamed. She couldn't bring herself to be around them. Micah didn't like this response and walked upstairs to see how it was all going. Adora is sitting on her bed; her new blanket was on her. Micah heard her ask Casta, "Why is this blanket heavy?"

Casta replied, "It's a weighted blanket, doesn't it feel nice?"

Adora nodded.

Micah noticed something about Adora the first time he ever met her. She rocked a lot, typically when talking to people. Even downstairs, she did it. When she got scared, she would get tense and only move her head. The day he had to bring her home with a bloody lip, she was banging her head into the car's back seat while she sobbed. With the blanket, she wasn't rocking. Juliet unboxed the lamp and commented, "It needs water for the tube. I'll fill it up downstairs," Passing Micah. Walking downstairs, she saw Angella sitting at the table. Without looking up, Angella, "If you came to tell me I'm a *tosser,* Micah then—" she looked up and stopped herself from speaking another further as her face reddened with embarrassment as she saw Juliet walk into the kitchen. Looking just as uncomfortable as Angella did. "Oh, um, M-Micah still upstairs," the dark-skinned women commented flustered.

Angella wanted to bury her face in shame.

Juliet asked, "So, how have you been?"

Angella sputtered, "I—I am fine! Focusing on the girls right now."

Juliet replied with "Adora is such a sweetie."

Angella smiled at her. "She is; we love her so much. I want what's best for her"

Juliet "I know you'll give her the best. What was her upbringing like?" she turned to Angella.

The British woman frowned and answered, "Not the best for her"

Both women shared a saddened expression. Before someone could say anything else, Micah came back downstairs to grab the tube for the lamp. "Adora and Glimmer are waiting for this," he said, grabbing the tube from Juliet; smiling happily, he turned to Angella. "Angie, tell Juliet about how we got Adora home; it's a good story."

He then left before either woman could protest. Both gave an awkward smile as Juliet sat across from Angella. Juliet asked again, "When did you decide you wanted to adopt?"

A question Angella has heard from so many people before. The two-year-long ordeal was shared minimally with Casta, so anything said now would be news to her. Angella explained, "We always wanted more children. We bought this house specifically with the ideal would have three or four children,"

Juliet smiled and placed her chin on her palm of her hand as her elbow propped her up on the table. She missed hearing her best friend's voice. Angella was not much of a storyteller but more of an informative sort. Hearing Angella goes into all the analytics of adopting and who qualifies, and what classes and interviews she needed to take would be the most boring ways to lead into a story. It was a soft lead-up for the heartbreaking parts. The untold stories Angella didn't share with people. The story of how her parents said they would not refer to the child as their grandchild and reminded her of how difficult her adoptive cousin was for her family. The story of how they were going to adopt from a teen was dated to give birth in the fall of last year but then changed her mind a month before the delivery date. All things that would have discouraged a family from proceeding with adoption. To their luck, a list of adoptable foster children that lived in the state was in urgent need of homes. Angella's serious tone changed to happiness when she reminisced about finding out about Adora.

"They showed us the most adorable picture of her—just the sweetest and happiest little girl on a swing set. We were fortunate to set up the meeting for her, and she was just the cutest; she was so happy to meet us. She was practically bouncing," Angella said with a laugh.

Juliet commented, "She's such a happy girl, and now she has a beautiful home,"

Angella looked behind her to make sure no children were coming downstairs as she looked back to Juliet to explain, "If I can share this, the poor thing was afraid to sit on the couch the first night here, she kept asking where she could and couldn't go and where she wasn't allowed to sit."

Juliet gasped softly. "Do you think she was told she had to ask those things from living in foster care?"

Angella confirmed, "I think she went through more than just being told where she could and couldn't go, but I think she might have been physically abused in that foster house," Angella pointed down to the kitchen table. "Her second night here, she was eating cereal from the box; when she saw that I was looking for her, she practically threw the box and rushed upstairs."

Juliet frowned. "Do you think she would get beaten?"

Angella nodded and looked down, folding her hands together. "It's the only explanation for her behavior. She acted the way I would if I ever saw my father with his boots in his hand to run from him." A small tidbit of information Juliet knew about Angella. The Brit came from two extremely abusive parents, and thankfully she excelled in school so well her parents had the opportunity to enroll her in boarding school on a scholarship. She used her time in school to keep away from them as far as going to stay at school for holidays or staying with other friends she made at school to even spend a Christmas and Boxing day with a questionable headmistress to avoid the abuse. Juliet knew this, as she was also someone who did everything; she could avoid her family. She came from poverty and alcoholic grandparents and did everything she could in her youth to keep away from them, going to the same lengths Angella went through. Except for being a boarding school, she went to a charter school with dorms and joined every club and group to stay away from them. The two women knew abuse, and just in that example alone showed signs of major abuse.

Juliet asked, "How do you feel about all this? If she has autism, therapy will be a challenge for her,"

Angella perked up, "Well, I have that covered, I think I can enroll her with tutors and specialists during the week after school, and that should help her with all her needs." Pleased with her ideas for Adora.

Juliet commented, "I figured you would be on all those sorts of things. She's fortunate to have you; Adora's going to have such a good life with you as her mother."

The compliment took Angella back. It was so sweet of Juliet to recognize her being a loving and good parent. Angella looked down at her hands in a slightly flustered response and sputtered, "O—Oh! T-thank, Juliet," a light blush creeping up her cheeks from the flattery. She hoped this was genuine. The two were once each other's most motivating and encouraging friends.

They heard small feet rushing towards them. Glimmer rushed over to them and explained, "Adora wants to show you her lamp."

Both women stood up to see what was going on. To Angella's slight disapproval, it appeared that Casta and Micah had done some rearranging in her room. Silently moving Adora's bedroom furniture around. Angella's original setup was more appealing in her mind. The bedframe was against the left side wall, and to the left of the bed was Adora's nightstand; to the right was her desk, the wall connecting was her window, and the right-side wall was where her closet was, and the bookshelf was. Now the bedframe

touched the back wall by the window and was pushed to the left side wall followed by her nightstand next to it, and only a few inches away was her desk, and on the right-hand side of the wall by her door now had her bookshelf. All the balance in the room design off from what Angella had originally set up; without Casta giving Angella time to drink it in, she answered the question before it was asked and said, "This set-up makes Adora more comfortable, she likes to sleep close to the wall, and she wants to be able to see her entire room layout from her bed" Casta informed.

Angella didn't protest this as much as she didn't like the room change. She wanted Adora to be happy, and it seemed Adora was happiest around Casta. She saw the happy little blonde sitting on her bed next to her new night light wrapped in the weighted blanket Casta, and Juliet bought for her. Glimmer sitting next to her on the bed as Adora rambled on without stuttering caused her mother to notice that Adora wasn't rocking back and forth like she normally did while talking. Indicating that Adora's rocking was a *stim*. Stimming was common for autistic children and sometimes for children with A.D.D and A.D.H.D. In this setting, Adora was calm and relaxed. Her little movements are cute. Glimmer's attentiveness was sweet, as Glimmer has completely warmed up to the idea of being a big sister, and Micah is getting some positive attention from Adora too, all that left was Angella. The female head of the house was out of her league with fun-loving Micah and Casta.

Juliet placed a hand on her shoulder and walked with her into Adora's room, giving her former friend the loving nudge to be a part of her family.

Adora didn't pay any mind to Angella's presence as she sat with Glimmer, looking at her lamp. Angella spoke up, "Adora, do you like your room like this?"

Adora didn't reply, still staring at her lamp. Glimmer nudged her sister and whispered, "Mommy is talking to you."

Adora looked to Glimmer and then to Angella and answered, "I like my room more, mommy."

At least she called me mommy in front of everyone.

Angella smiled awkwardly. "Good sweetheart, I'm happy" she looked at the little lamp. A water-filled tube that changed colors and had plastic fish floating in it. She worried this might keep Adora up at night, as it was a distracting night light. She looked down at her daughter giving her full attention it. Placing a kiss on her forehead. Adora blinked and looked up and beamed at her. Angella was relieved to see Adora was happy to be near her.

After a little more time with aunt Casta and Juliet, the girls got ready for bed. Adora has struggled to sleep when bedtime has come up and toss and turn or hide in the closet. Tonight, she was fast asleep by 10 am when Angella peeked in to check on her. The lamp must have soothed her made her focus on that instead of the large open space that was her room. Under a weighted blanket slept a little blonde angel in cow print pajamas.

First day of school

Angella was more nervous than Adora was. Dressing her up in something cute was Glimmer's elected job. Adora was still not good with clothes matching and dressing herself all that well. If they let her be, she would dress in sweatpants and long t-shirts every day. Instead, Glimmer got her to wear a red top with jeans and a white hoodie. She also helped Adora put her hair up in a ponytail. As much as Angella worried, Glimmer had taken it upon herself to be a better big sister to Adora. Getting over the fact that she was shorter than her, Glimmer took a protective role to her as a sister moving forward in a short amount of time. Knowing Adora was sensitive and prone to crying made Glimmer more determined to help her instead of ignoring her. The shorter sister once worried that Adora would come in and be the new favorite and steal all her parent's love from her. Instead, Adora was different. She didn't want to take anything from Glimmer and only wanted Glimmer to like her. She boldly told her that before. *If you don't like me, I'll get sent away.* This didn't make Glimmer think to take advantage of these insecurities; she wanted to help Adora feel more welcome. Something about her new sister felt *different*. She couldn't tell what it was yet, and her eight-year-old mind couldn't figure it out just yet, but she knew Adora was different.

Micah was not worried. His mind was too focused on balancing being a law associate and a car rental shop owner to keep too much worry on his family. He felt Angella was going overboard in her fears as he knew his wife had sent Adora's teacher several

emails. It was unfair to her how Micah got to drop them off at school today as she had to go in early.

Adora was now learning all about her new routine for her house. There was no rush to the bathroom, no shared showers, no need to pee while someone is in the shower, getting to eat food every morning, and not worry about someone stealing your food. All the nice smells from mommy and daddy as they got ready. Her parent's bedroom door was open, and she peeked in to see her mother sitting at her vanity applying makeup. This was something she had only rarely seen Sue Weaver do. Sue's vanity mirror was smudged, and around it was cigarette ashes. Nothing was special or fancy. Mommy's one was pretty, a pearly white vanity, and lined around was all of mommy's makeups and perfumes. Adora just stared at her from the doorway. Angella was so beautiful. The way she spoke and carried herself was something to be admired. She was the type of woman to envy, beauty, intelligence, and wealth. All features Sue did not have and loathed. Sue never really said anything nice about Angella when Adora was getting adopted. Instead, she tried to warn Adora about how she would not be accepted or how easily they could send her away. All Adora could think about how Angella looked like the moms from movies or like the moms who used to dress nicely to pick their kids up from her old school. The look of beauty and confidence was something Adora admired in her new mother. Micah was sitting on the king-size bed, putting on his tie while looking at the mirror. As he stood up, he saw Adora fixated on Angella, watching her from the door. He smiled at her; it reminded him of watching his own mother apply makeup. Or the several times he used to mess with Casta as she tried to do her makeup. Leaving the bedroom, he patted Adora's head, telling her that she looked adorable for her new school's first day. This caught Angella's attention, and she looked over to smile at her daughter, only to have Adora shyly step to the side to be out of her mother's sight. Both parents chuckled at Adora acting shy, and it was the first time she ever really did that in front of them.

Adora went downstairs, and Angella saw Glimmer walk past her room and called her in, "Darling, come here for a moment?"

Glimmer walked in. "Yes, mom?"

Angella's tone turned serious as she placed her hands on Glimmer's shoulders and explained, "I know you and Adora are not in the same grade. You're her big sister, and see you at recess; I want to make sure that you look out for her. She's going to be a new student, and she'll need help making friends."

Glimmer blinked and replied, "Adora will play with my friends and me at recess."

Angella smiled and kissed her forehead. "That's my girl,"

They two went downstairs; Angella headed out the door for work, stopping into the kitchen to say goodbye to her family. Micah had made the girls pancakes. Adora looked up at Angella. Her mother kissed her forehead, "Have a good day at school, sweetie," and then kissed Micah afterward. She left, and during her entire drive to work, she worried about Adora. *What if the kids aren't nice to her? What if her teacher is mean? She isn't good at speaking up; what if they think she's dumb or teases her for her stutter?*

Angella didn't help her thoughts as she drove to work. Twenty-five minutes of thinking of every horrible scenario that could happen to Adora on her first day. Were all building up for her bad day at work. Not enough nurses were in the E.R. today, and all the C.N.A's were useless. Running around trying to help sick and injured people were bad enough without her staff being incompetent. One guy came in because he cut off his finger with a power tool, and the nurses had him wait in the hospital bed without cleaning up and bandaging his wound. After Angella did it herself, she called in a floor meeting to basically tell everyone how bad they were at her job. After unloading on half the emergency room staff, she felt a little better about her day. It didn't stay that way. After several more outbursts at the nurses' expense, she was caught off guard by the appearance of human resources at her office door. This was typically never a good sign. According to the H.R. department, Angella has received many complaints from other co-workers, and as a requirement by the hospital, she now needed a teamwork evaluation. She dreaded this conversation and hoped to God that Adora had a better day than her right now.

That was true. Adora, right now, was having a much better day. She was walked into school by her father. Clutching his hand tightly, she worried all the same thoughts Angella had. Although Angella never said them out loud to Adora, the little girl was concerned about kids being mean, not making friends, or having a teacher that didn't like her. She worried that if she stuttered, she would get laughed at. The other school she went to was unkind to foster children. No child there was very welcomed; group home children, foster children, and all other state wards were treated poorly.

To Adora's surprise, this school was nothing but kind to her. Her new classroom was bright and pretty, and her teacher was a nice lady. So lovely she made cupcakes to celebrate the new student

Adora. The blonde was a little shy to the attention but quickly caught the attention of some of the boys in the class. Two boys, Carlos and Douglas, wanted her to sit next to them, and two popular girls wanted Adora to sit with her. The teacher had her sit at a desk that was more in the middle of the class.

For lunch, she had her lunch made for her by mommy. It had a tiny fruit salad, cookies, juice, and a bento-style box with white rice and something brown. In it had a note saying, *"Mommy loves you! Have a good day at school"!*

Adora wasn't too happy with her lunch. Angella never bothered to ask Adora about foods she liked. Lucky for her, one of the boys who was starting to have a crush on her offered her his pizza in exchange for whatever she was having.

After that, she was off to recess. She didn't know that first graders and second graders had cavities together. She walked over to the jungle gym with other kids from her class when she was stopped by Glimmer. Her older sister tugged at her arm. "Adora, play with my friends and me, so you don't have to be alone." She instructed.

Before Adora could speak, Carlos and another girl from her class named Cassidy came over and said, "Adora is going to play with us," Cassidy said, grabbing Adora's other arm. Glimmer firmly addressed her position "I am Adora's big sister. My family adopted her."

Carlos asked, "Can she play with us?"

Glimmer looked at Adora and asked, "Are they nice? You can play with them if they're nice."

Adora nodded. "They're nice,"

Glimmer nodded and let Adora go. "Okay, I'll be by the swings if you need me," she turned to Cassidy and Carlos. "I'll be watching," giving them a severe look before walking away. Back with her friends, Perfuma commented, "That's her? She's pretty" Glimmer nodded and crossed her arms. "Yeah, she is."

Perfuma turned to her and asked, "What's wrong?"

Glimmer sighed. "I'm trying to be protective; I don't think I'm doing it right. Do you think I should be playing with her, or should I let her play with her new friends?"

Perfuma looked over to the first graders and saw how happy she looked. "I think she's okay. She looked happy."

The shorter friend looked down worriedly, and Perfuma nudged her. "You're a good big sister, don't worry."

She kept looking at Adora and watched the blonde girl running around and laughing with other kids. A sense of relief came over her as it looked like Adora was good at making friends and maybe that her mom was too dramatic when it came to Adora. It looked

like the times where Adora is the most nervous is around them, not anyone else. It made her think about what kind of sister she wanted to be and how she can be a better one. If Adora gets nervous around mom and dad, then Glimmer needed to help her.

When school ended, Micah was the one to pick them up. He went in to get his girls and asked Adora's teacher how she was on her first day. The teacher assured him that Adora was fine and had a great first day and that she read and replied to all six of Angella's emails throughout the day. He sheepishly smiled at her, embarrassed of how overprotective Angella was. The teacher assured him, "Adora was great, and she is a good student. I understand Angella's concerns and will always answer all of her questions; it does not bother me at all when a parent has concerns about their children," he was relieved and thanked her before they left. Adora was happy. She sputtered a little as she excitedly talked about her day, her new friends, nice boys, and her teacher is nice and pretty and likes the playground and her classroom.

All the good vibes were brought to a halt when they got home. As the girls went into Glimmer's room to do homework, Micah went into their shared office next to the kitchen to see what the matter with Angella was.

He walked in. "Uh, honey, I see your home early, and you didn't say hi to the girls when we got home,"

She turned to him with tears in her eyes. He was taken back by the sight of his wife, who was greatly upset by something; he looked to his right and saw a cardboard box for office file on her

desk filled things from her doctor's office desk at the hospital. His eyes widened as he asked, "Did you get fired?"

Angella scoffed and crossed her arms. "I wish," she turned from him. "Apparently, I am considered a difficult person to work with, and for that, I will be transferred over to Sealines Hospital for the remainder of my contract."

Most medical doctors working for health centers and hospitals have a contract that depicts their time expected to work and their location. As Eternia medical group has multiple hospitals around the state, she is not being made to go off-contract. Sealines hospital is a longer drive and basically in the heart of Horde County. Micah frowned and tried to embrace his wife. She turned away from him. "I was looking forward to my contract expiring soon, but I never thought I would have to deal with this before the end of it."

Micah asked, "When does it expire?"

"Four months and for the next four months, I will be in Horde County,"

Micah rubbed the back of his head nervously and asked the poorly timed question, "Will you renew your contract with them if It's offered?"

Angella snapped, "After this? Never! It's bad enough I need to do this! But clearly, I have no choice but to continue work with them! I can't just be a private practice with all your debt!?"

Micah defensively asked, "What do you mean, my debt?"

"Your auto rental—shop—place—thing! Is a money pit! We are constantly covering expenses out of our savings for that place!"

"It's going to make money!" insulted that her bad day was now making her go after him on what he has going on.

Angella yelled back at him, "You said that six years ago! It has never made a profit, Micah!"

Before he could yell back at her, she started crying. He grabbed her close as she sobbed, "I hate this job! I hate it so much!"

He patted her back and comforted her "Angie, Angie, honey? It's alright, and I'm here for you."

As much as he wanted to know why she was upset, he wasn't as ready as he thought he'd be for Angella to unload all her stress on him. Her resentment to his spending and how he can always enjoy the fruits of their labor more than she gets to, her job being a million times more stressful than his, and the kids like him better than her. All of this was a little too much for him. Even though he let his wife vent, he felt awful for not knowing any of these things before this breakdown.

To make matters more awkward, he cleared his throat to tell her, "Uh, honey, I'm so sorry you stressed. I'll make it up to you, I promise, once I get home tonight from being out with the guys, I will—"

She snapped at him, "You're going out tonight!?" all the tears vanished from her eyes, and she turned to rage.

He waved his hands and retorted, "It's for the darts league with Lance and George; after that, I will come home, and we can go over some budget plans."

Angella angrily pushed away from him and put her hand on the doorknob, and angrily turned to him, "I can't believe I wasted all that time telling you how upset and overworked I am, only for you to let me know you have planned?!"

Micah put his hands up in the air with defeat. "Angie! If you don't want me to go, just say so, and I won't!"

She turned to leave the room. "No, no, you go ahead and have a good time; one of us needs to!" and slammed the door behind her. Leaving her husband alone in the office.

Her night continued to get worse. The girls finished homework and came down for dinner. She made spaghetti with vegetables in the sauce, and the noodles were whole grain and chewier than what Adora was used to. Innocently trying to make conversation

with her new mother, the blonde child innocently mentioned, "Yesterday, auntie brought pizza, and it was yummy," she looked at Angella. She saw the instant glare come over Angella's face. Insulted, Angella took that comment as an insult*. Is she a brat to me? There is no bloody way in hell she is a brat to me.*

Angella coldly replied, "We don't get pizza ever night, Adora."

Glimmer could tell by the tone that her mother was angry about something and shot a look over to Adora to stop. Unable to pick up the social signs, Adora continued, "Auntie was really nice to me,"

Angella looked down at her food remarked, "Well, Auntie is good at that; she can make everyone like her; it doesn't take her much effort."

Glimmer knew something was going on. She didn't know what it was, but her mom was angry.

Adora was starting to stutter something "I—I—I—I, t-today at school w-was really nice and f-fun, and—"

Angella stopped her and scolded, "Adora, finish your dinner, then we'll talk,"

The blonde jumped a little at her aggression. She was afraid she had upset her mother. She shrunk in her seat and kept her eyes

down at her food. Glimmer gave her a glare for making Adora feel bad. Her mom could sometimes mean, especially if it has anything to do with aunt Casta.

After dinner, the two made went back upstairs to avoid Angella for the rest of the night. As much as Angella regretted her actions, she felt she was unwanted by the girls to talk to Adora.

Micah was feeling just as bad downtown. Even after a good dart game, he vented about Angella's anger with the guys. George, Lance, and his friend Jeff, the retired attorney general for the state, all sat around talking about their exes. For Micah, this made him drink more, these were all divorced men, and he was the only one married still out of his friends. A few shots too many, and he wasn't able to drive home. He slumped over the barstool and groaned, "Angie hates me……. I can't drive; I'm almost fifty!"

Jeff came from behind George and Lance and asked, "So, uh….. we're taking him home, right?"

Lance shrugged. "I guess I'll drive his car and you guys and try to load him in."

George narrowed his eyes and looked down at his drunken emotional friend. "Okay," he said, rolling his sleeves u.p "You get the hands, I get the feet" Jeff nodded and help drag Micah out of the bar, all while the bearded drunk friend whined about Angie leaving him.

Getting into the car, Lance tried to assure Micah that Angella wasn't planning on leaving him.

Once they got him home, they were greeted by the sight of an angry wife in a nightgown. She stormed in from the kitchen as she heard the front door open.

"See here! You have some nerve coming home this late and not —" Angella instantly shut up and covered her chest with her arms, flushing as she saw George and Jeff carrying Micah in and Lance coming in from behind waving, "Hi, Angella, he's a little drunk, but we got him home safe. Do you want me to pull his car into the garage?"

To Angella's embarrassment, she wasn't planning on being seen in her short and revealing sleepwear. The guys tried to be as polite as possible, despite all still being men and finding it hard not to look at how much skin Angella was revealing at this moment. She sputtered, "Y-yes, thank you,"

The guys walked over to the couch to set him down as Angella tried to put a blanket over him, and Micah threw his arms around her and drunkenly sobbed, "Angie! Angie! I love you so much!"

The two men backed away, trying to be polite. As Micah grabbed on to Angella, he dragged her down to fall on top of him. Giving Micah's heterosexual friend a peek of a little more than he should have seen from his friend's wife. George was indifferent and

comedically placed his hand over Jeff's eyes, only to have him snort and push his hand away.

His wife flustered, trying to push him off and having her topple over him on the couch. She was on top of him, and it almost looks like straddling as she tried to get off him, but he kept clinging to her and repeatedly saying how much he loved her. Lance came back from the garage and saw the sight of Angella trying to get away from Micah off of her. She finally got away from him, only to adjust her gown with an audience. Clearing her throat to suppress any more embarrassment. "Gentlemen, thank you for bringing him home,"

Lance came from the garage and saw Angella and asked, "Is he okay?"

She sighed and crossed her arms. "Besides the nonsensical rambling and sobbing, I'd say he is fine."

The guys laughed and asked, "Do you want us to deal with him while you get some sleep?"

She shook her head and chuckled. Assuring them, he would be fine. As soon as they left, she finally got the blanket over him and left to go back upstairs to sleep. It wasn't long before Micah came to bed, only in boxer shorts; he walked into the bedroom and started to whine again. "You're going to divorce me?" his words slurred as she tripped and fell onto the floor.

Angella jumped up to make sure he was alright, and he got on his back and extended his arms out to her. “Please don’t leave me, Angie! I promise I’ll do better! I didn’t know you were upset,” he looked at her with sad eyes. Angella sighed, helping him up, and asked, “Where did you leave your clothes?”

He retorted, “I didn’t leave me clothes; my clothes left me.”

She giggled and helped him to bed, apologizing for what she said before he left for the night. He apologized for his actions and promised to be better with spending. As drunk as he was, he asked the serious question, “D-do you want me to sell the auto center?”

Angella shrugged as she cuddles close to him. “I know it means a lot to you so that I won't take it away from you, but it is a financial loss for us and would be better to sell.”

He nodded and cuddled close to her. He might be drunk, and half his clothes were all over the living room floor, but he knew his Angella loves him and would never leave.

Love and Care, with shame and Distance

Chapter Summary

> Adora is confirmed autistic, and Angella goes overboard, giving her every single resource tool a parent is told to do without considering Adora's feelings and wants in the process, only to realize she has created a rift between her and Adora.

All the happy thoughts have gone away now.

Adora's small body felt heavy as she slept, her energy was gone, and all her joy of being adopted died along with her love for playing. Angella and Micah didn't like her, Glimmer liked her a little, but everything changed once the diagnosis was confirmed. Adora tossed around in her bed when she remembered being in that cold white room while the doctor and Angella talked about Adora being high functioning *autistic* and having *anxiety*. She heard them talk about *speech therapy* and *social skills treatment*, along with Adora having sensory issues and unable to process pain well. For as long as Adora could remember, she had had bruises and cuts. Sometimes by accident, from playing too hard or getting Sue angry. Then, finally, Angella said something about seeing Adora walk into corners or biting herself to be *troubling* and unable to stay asleep.

The doctor advised several home accommodations, setting up a camera to see if Adora wanders around the house when she is supposed to be asleep; he recommended bite guards for Adora to wear on her arms to prevent her from hurting herself when she *stimmed*. He advised against sweets and too much television as they could trigger negative emotions or distress her too quickly. Adora hugged herself as she tried to get comfortable in her room.

All the awful memories came back to her when she looked at her nightstand and saw her missing fish bubble light. The water tube of colors and plastic fish was taken out of her room when her doctor told Angella it could be *overstimulating*. A word Adora didn't understand at all. Ever since then, everyone started to treat her differently. Not at school, she looked forward to school and having recess. She hated being at this *house* now. All the fun was gone, and she couldn't make anyone happy. Her time with Angella and Micah was so limited, to begin with, and it only becomes more limited as of this week. Angella had a late-night hospital job and wasn't home in the morning. Dad woke them up for school and made—something—close to breakfast for them, or they got lucky, and he was running late, and they would eat Dunkin Donuts or McDonald's on the way to school.

Adora finally drifted off to sleep and dreamed about Catra.

All the fun they had when they played and their dream to move far away from Sue and all the mean people in their lives. They had a childish vagabond dream; they thought they could survive in New York City independently in their tiny minds. They could live in a cardboard box like homeless people do and make it an excellent package. Catra had a toy guitar with Cinderella on it, and they could play guitar and draw people as they do in the movies to make money and live independently. It was a nice dream. It was something that gave her comfort when she felt sad, and ever since the diagnosis. She had felt low for weeks.

She dreaded sleeping now, and it didn't matter how good of a dream she would have or how much longer she slept now; her new medication made her thirsty all the time, and it made waking up for the bathroom at night impossible. She wet herself four days ago—the first time—since she was four. She lucked out, and

Glimmer woke her up that morning instead of dad because he was running late. Glimmer saw it and was grossed out. Ready to taunt her but stopped when Adora begged Glimmer not to tell anyone, or she would get *beat* and Glimmer reconsider tattling on her, but it cast her thoughts about her parents into doubt. The idea of Adora getting beat by her loving parents. A new sense of protection came over Glimmer. She helped Adora hide her soiled sheets in the bottom of her clothes hamper and assured Adora that the cleaning lady who worked on Mondays for the family would wash them for her without mommy ever finding out. Taking another sheet to throw on the mattress masked the evidence but kept a lingering odor in the bedroom. A few sprays of Febreze from the upstairs bathroom hid it as best as possible, and Adora would start her morning off as best as she could. Glimmer told her parents she wanted to oversee waking up Adora in the morning because she is the *big sister*.

As delighted as her parents were to this new responsible role Glimmer demanded, it kept Adora feeling a little bit safer. She hated herself for bedwetting, she wished she didn't need to drink anything, but she hurt her throat too much not to drink water or juice during the day.

This morning she got lucky.

When Glimmer shook her to wake her up, she didn't have an accident. Getting up and ready for school was normal, except for Micah. He was running late and couldn't get off the phone with work, leaving the girls to themselves to get ready, which wasn't an issue. Glimmer liked to be in charge and did an outstanding job and getting the two of them ready. Adora wanted Glimmer to help her more than anyone else in the house. Glimmer picked out

her outfits for her and brushed her hair for her the way Catra used to.

For breakfast, it was McDonald's for them again, same as last week, and Adora loved to drink chocolate milk and eat hash browns. So she got to have two—since Glimmer didn't like hash browns.

The beginning of school was something to look forward to. Adora had some early morning time to play with her friends on the playground before the bell rang, and Glimmer watched her from a distance with Bow. Glimmer told Bow in confidence, "She's only weird at home. I don't think she likes my parents."

The Bow was wiser beyond his years at age eight and offered, "Aren't they, her parents now too?"

Glimmer nodded but also sighed and answered, "Yeah, but she doesn't spend time with mommy or daddy. My parents aren't home a lot now; we spend most of the time with auntie Casta when daddy is late for work and mommy works at nighttime. So all Adora does is stay in her room or hides in her closet."

"Is that because she has autism?" the little boy asked.

Glimmer shrugged. As she did, the bell rang, and she watched as Adora lined up with three other kids from her class. She frowned at her sister as she watched her. You'*re so weird, Adora.*

Adora was just relieved to be in class. Starting her day with a daily chart—the classroom Monday questionnaire on how their weekend went and how they felt. Adora has put "sad" three weeks in a row. Her first week was due to missing Catra, the second week was due to being diagnosed with autism, and this weekend is because mommy and daddy made her stay in her room all weekend. She asked to play outside and go to the park, and they said "no" because they were busy. Adora remembered watching them from the stairway Saturday night while they watched TV with Glimmer. She felt so left out and wanted to join them but thought she wasn't invited. At one point, she grew fearful as she remembered when Sue used to get mad at the kids for sitting on the couch with her. She used to tell them she had a *bastard limit* for her couch. She didn't know if she was allowed to sit with them all. She never tried before; she knew that Angella told Glimmer not to hug Adora anymore because of *sensory overload.* Adora continued to draw her picture next to her feelings chart. She drew a picture of a house. Inside the house were stick figures to symbolize Micah, Angella, and Glimmer standing together with hearts floating around them. Another stick figure represented Adora; it was crying and had broken hearts floating around above her.

When the teacher went around to collect the drawings, she paused at Adora's picture to examine it for a moment before going back to her desk. Midday: she was asked by her teacher after reading time if Adora wanted to meet another excellent teacher.

Adora didn't hesitate by her teacher's kind tone and was walked to the main office to meet this new friendly teacher. Her teacher escorted her into an office filled with stuffed animals and had a

trampoline in it. At the desk was an older woman with long grey hair and thick ruby-colored glasses.

Her teacher spoke, "Mrs. Razz, this is Adora Brighton."

She smiled at the two of them and offered to Adora, "Oh, Adora dearie, would you like to play while I talk to Ms. Ellen?"

It was a pleasant visit.

Adora got to unwind and talk to Mrs. Razz about herself. Then, she got to jump on the trampoline and tell her about Catra and her old friends.

The papers Ms. Ellen had told a different part of the story as Razz waited for Adora to stop jumping to ask her about her feelings.

That question sent Adora's mind into a tiny spiral as Adora, feeling safe, info-dumped everything about her and her feelings about her new family. Razz put Adora's thoughts into a better perspective as she played a game with Adora using a feelings chart.

Razz had an emoji poster in her hand, and she pointed to emotion and asked Adora to tell her about a time she felt that emotion.

The feelings were powerful coming from a seven-year-old and heartbreaking for an adult to hear. As Adora explained, she felt jealous of other kids and babies. She sees how *"Nice their mommies are"* and how she feels ugly because she doesn't look like Angella or Micah. She feels like Angella stopped liking when she became autistic and felt like she has a disease she didn't know about and wished she were *"better"* for Angella. She was indifferent to Micah and liked Glimmer as her sister, but her feelings were mixed with Angella.

Adora explained to Razz how she was Sue's favorite before and liked being the favorite child.

Finally breaking down into tears, Adora cried over being made to take speech therapy after school and not going to the park, and not being allowed to play outside anymore. Her sobs got stronger as she told Razz she wanted to go back to Sue to be with Catra again. All of Adora's pleads painted a clear picture.

Adora had severe abandonment issues.

She told Razz she knew from a very early age that Sue was only a foster parent and raised her to be adopted. She warned Adora that any lousy behavior would lead her not to be placed with a family. By age five, she has explained her parents were dead, and that's why she didn't have a family. She was told by Sue directly that they left her. The cruel words have now made up Adora's worth; as long as she was a good girl, she wouldn't be alone and unloved. Now that she was autistic, she felt like she needed to *"Get fixed"* to win back Angella's love.

After the session, Adora was back to class to enjoy the rest of her day.

Razz immediately got on the phone with Angella to leave her a voicemail.

While the school consular anticipated a call back from Angella. The overtired mother of the Brighton household was dealing with her issues at the moment. The accountant for the family was at the house going over with Micah and Angella about all their debts. Micah, in poor timing, dropped several debt bombs on Angella during this meeting.

The car shop had been losing money for over a year, covering the lost revenue with his income and helping Castaspella with her mortgage.

Angella was furious and did her best not to show her rage towards him. However, he knew he was in hot water and chose to get the girls from school.

Exhausted, she sat on her couch and groaned.

Years of working hard, having a demanding career, and now, while Micah chose to be part-time as a lawyer, he had put them in a debt that will take them years to pay off with no end in sight. As a result, Angella's dream of being her private practice might never come true now.

She heard footsteps coming from the basement stairs and saw the cheering polite smile of the housekeeper that came on Monday's tell Angella, "All clean, Doctor."

Angella smiled and reached for her purse to write her a check.

Without much care, she asked about the girl's room. "Have the girls been keeping their rooms clean?"

Due to Angella's lack of time with them, she didn't go in and snoop around her daughter's things.

The housekeeper innocently responded, "Oh, good. Clean. Glimmer's room, exceptionally clean, Adora had some pee-pee sheets, and they are still drying. I needed to wash them twice to get the stains out."

Angella's eyes widened at the realization of what she was telling her. Then, handing her the check, she asked her, "How many sheets as she soiled since you've taken over with her laundry?"

The housekeeper replied. "Three sheets last week, only two this week."

"Thank you for letting me know," Angella replied while she handed her the check. Then, watching her leave, Angella rested on the couch and worried. Sue never mentioned Adora was a bed wetter. Was it a side effect to the medication, or was this blatant defiance?

Her thoughts did not linger as they all came home. Glimmer rushing to embrace her mother. "Hi, mommy!" Glimmer greeted her while she dropped her purple backpack to the floor and ran to hug her mother.

Angella smiled and kissed the top of her daughter's head. "How was school, princess?"

"School was good, mommy." Glimmer replied, pulling away and looking at Adora. The blonde looked down nervously. She wanted to hug Angella too but was afraid Angella might not like her *autism* on her. Adora didn't say a word to Angella and went to her bedroom. She already knew what the rest of the day would bring. Her speech therapist will come over, Micah will take Glimmer to soccer practice, and Angella will listen in from the living room. The second Adora will feel confident enough to talk to her mother will be when she starts to stutter, stammer, and phrase her sentences incorrectly. She hated speech therapy; it wasn't fun. The regular school was more fun than speech.

Glimmer followed after Adora so she could get ready for soccer.

Micah sat next to Angella on the couch; he knew something was wrong and asked, "Did something happen?"

She looked to the stairway to make sure no little ones were listening. Then, in a calm tone, she told Micah, "Adora has been bedwetting."

Micah's eyes went wide with the information. "This whole time?"

Angella narrowed her eyes at him. "I don't know. I haven't been home in the mornings to see her wake up. Why haven't you noticed anything?"

"I've been letting Glimmer wake her up." Micah's brow furrowed at her scowl. He didn't like the idea of her implying he was not alert of his children. Glimmer knew to tell him things like that. Adora should also know by how this family operates; she can tell him anything.

Angella explained to him, "Irene said she has been washing sheets for the past two weeks. She said Adora puts them at the bottom of her dirty laundry basket in her closet.

Micah's nose scrunched up at the thought of it.

"What do you we do about it?" he asked.

Angella rolled her eyes. "We need to address it. She's been sneaking this situation for some time now, and we cannot have it happen anymore."

Micah stroked his beard. "Do you think it has anything to do with autism?"

Angella "It could, or the meds. But, you know, I didn't want her medicated so early in life. She's seven; she'll grow up dependent on medication for things she should be able to control."

"Isn't that why we are doing all this expensive therapy for her?"

Angella sucked in a breath at him, calling Adora's therapy expensive. He wasn't wrong about the price being high; she just didn't like him being the one to call out expenses when it was clear he was the reason for all of their debts.

Angella didn't take a moment to jab at his rhetoric and just agreed with him. But, unfortunately, the speech was expensive, especially when going outside the medical insurance limits.

She felt compelled to talk to Adora right now; she didn't want to get her upset before her speech therapy session; she left the living room to go upstairs to see how the girls were doing. Quietly going upstairs, she saw Adora's bedroom door open with her not in it. The girl's rooms were right next to each other; before she opened Glimmer's closed bedroom door to see where

they were, she heard the muffled talk of the two children. Glimmer went on about how cute her soccer unfirm was, and all the cute boys from the second grade and third grade were on her team.

Adora's soft voice can be heard saying, "You look like mommy and daddy."

Glimmer didn't respond right away, and Angella heard her softly agree. "Yeah… I guess. I want to look like auntie when I get bigger. Daddy says I look like him the most."

Angella frowned, knowing Glimmer's ideal version of her adult self wasn't Angella.

Adora then weakly stated, "I wish I were pretty like mommy; she would like me more if I looked like her."

Angella felt her heart sink at her words.

Glimmer assured her, "Your still pretty, Adora."

Angella was proud to know. Glimmer was so positive for Adora. She was assuring her that her little sister was pretty.

Adora whined, "I don't feel pretty here; I feel ugly. I want dark hair like you and mommy and daddy."

"Your hair is pretty, Adora." Glimmer tried to reinforce.

Adora didn't say anything.

Glimmer then softly said, "Don't cry, Adora," to comfort her.

Angella stopped her eavesdropping and her motherly instincts kicked in when she opened the door without knocking to see Glimmer by her mirror and Adora wiping her eyes by Glimmer's bed. Both girls were startled by Angella's sudden entrance. Adora is more fearful than surprised. Glimmer only speaking to tell her mommy. "You're supposed to knock." Her remark was a little fresh, and Angella just gave her a look. Turning to face her attention to Adora—she watched the blonde flinch with her watery eyes. Adora kept her gaze down as she rushed past Angella to her room. Angella followed after her, more worried as she realized how fearful Adora was of her. Adora ran to her closet—a haven for her when she felt overwhelmed. Seeing Angella burst into Glimmer's room made her anxious, and she didn't know what would happen next. When Sue did that, it meant a pow-pow. Adora didn't know what she could have done to get a beating. Still, she knew she had made several mistakes throughout her time living here. She knew it was only a matter of time before Angella has enough of Adora's autistic stuttering and mishaps.

Angella saw Adora close her closet door to hide from her.

Worried and saddened by her sudden actions, Angella asked from the door, "Adora, is everything alright?"

Adora didn't respond. The lump in her throat made her want to cry. She worried about crying in front of Angella. Sue hated the sound of crying. Angella could become angry at Adora's sobbing. She was desperate to silence her at Mcdonald's when his feet were heels were bleeding and even more when Adora cried over Angella taking her fish light away. Angella opened the closet door and saw Adora on the floor with her toy monkey in her hand. The tears were streaming down Adora's face, and she hugged Howey close to her face when Angella crouched down and asked her, "Sweetheart, tell me what's wrong?" she noticed Adora put on one of her old jackets from when she lived with Sue. One missed the dumpster. She remembered Adora crying when she discovered the black trash bag of dingy clothes was thrown out while she was at school. Adora only had two pieces of her old life with Sue Weaver. The dingy stuffed monkey from Catra and the faded red children's varsity jacket that had grey sleeves.

Angella stood back up and gestured for Adora to get up and leave the closet. Obediently, Adora did not hesitate to follow instructions. As much as she didn't want to anger Angella the way Catra would anger Sue.

Angella asked again when Adora sat up and got out of the closet. "Is everything alright?"

The truth was NO!

I miss playing! I don't like speech therapy! I want to go with Glimmer to soccer and play!

Adora kept her eyes down.

In a trembling voice, the small child assured her mother, "I was good. I was g-good t-today." Adora shut her eyes tightly. She hated how she couldn't go a single sentence without stuttering in front of Angella. It made things harder on her than they already were. Every word that came out of Adora's mouth was a stammer or stutter. Because of how poor her speech was when she got nervous, she heard talk of Angella wanting to put her in extra speech classes.

Seeing the small child fidget in fear made her feel that she was doing something wrong in her parenting method. All the checks and balances made sense for what she was doing. Putting Adora in therapy, avoiding overstimulating places, like parks and arcades, and giving her sensory preferred toys were supposed to make her happy. Instead, Adora looked like all the joy had been zapped from her. The blonde's personality had entirely changed after the moment she left Sue's house with her.

If Adora were homesick from her old foster home, it would make sense to. Angella hoped she could fill the voids the child must be feeling; as of yet, nothing Angella has done has been enough to make Adora happy.

Angella assured Adora, "Darling, you can tell me anything. Are you sure everything is alright?"

Adora didn't know how to answer this question. Her feelings worksheet at school was easier to follow and explain. She could circle an emoji, and it explains it that way. However, her emotions, in general, are hard to explain. So when Sue asked this question, it was either because Adora was in trouble or did something she shouldn't have done. Instinctively Adora looked to her closet. Knowing that is where she hides her wet sheets and snack wrappers from school.

Angella called to bring Adora back to attention. "Adora?"

The blonde looked up, feeling her throat go dry.

At this moment, she wanted to tell Adora she knew about her bedwetting but also didn't, after hearing how Adora thought she wasn't cute for not looking like anyone in the family. The timing felt wrong. For Adora's sake, she lucked out as Juliet came over to watch Adora while her speech therapy went on, so she and Micah could see Glimmer's soccer game.

Adora was mildly relieved not to have to speak to Angella.

Angella, on the other hand, was awkwardly happy to see Juliet. Just like Adora, she failed at having a normal conversation with her former best friend and more or less just rambling on about

Adora's speech therapy. Juliet knew her former best friend was uneasy around her. Things were never the same after the incident. Angella was stubborn, and so was Juliet, and neither of them apologized for something that happened eight years ago. Juliet was no better at being less awkward and failing to keep a normal conversation about work. Between a doctor in physical therapy and a Surgeon, it would be implied they would have too many things to talk about. Instead, it was a painful five minutes of dead air between random blurts of information.

Micah was in ear short to the whole thing and felt bad for his wife and her limited friend circle, she didn't typically make female friends quickly, and when she did, they didn't stick around for long.

He spoke to Adora's speech therapist and told her that Adora had a hard time responding to questions at home about her feelings.

Juliet was on the couch, and Adora and her teacher in the kitchen are going over the lesson. The unofficial aunt watched as Glimmer and the parents left. She was lost in the mindless loop of court TV while the study proceeded.

Adora bit on her arm as her teacher pulled out the lesson cards for today. The routine was annunciation of the words in the alphabet that was hard and then to form sentences. Practice reading and repeating words the teacher says was not a difficult task. Adora was told by her teacher she was reading a third-grade reaching level, which made Adora happy to know she was brilliant. Unfortunately, this information was only Adora's knowledge, as the parent-teacher conference was not happening until Friday.

Adora fidgeted and rocked in her chair to her teacher's annoyance as the lesson began.

Juliet processed to text Casta about the day.

Castaspella instructed Juliet to peek in on the speech therapy and participate. Since *clearly Mother of the Year couldn't be bothered*. Juliet disagreed with Casta's views on Angella. She knew Angella on a more personal level than Casta could understand. Casta had this negative view of Angella since their twenties—all the way back when Angella was dating Micah. She assumed Angella to be some snob from the beginning when Angella had a terrible impression of Casta for various reasons. Two being minor grievances and the other two being very reasonable. Her falling out with Angella years ago was reasonable. The last time Juliet was asked to babysit was when Glimmer was an infant. Overtired and stressed, Angella needed to go out for errands and left Juliet and Casta home alone. Casta—at this time, was living in what was now Adora's bedroom. A bit of small talk here and there led to the two becoming close to a romantic level without Angella and Micah knowing. It led to some action in the bedroom while Glimmer was in her crib alone downstairs. Angella came home early to see her baby unsupervised and her best friend and sister-in-law in HER bed by poor timing.

A furious argument happened, and that ended the friendship.

Angella felt betrayed beyond words for this action, and Juliet has avoided Angella for almost eight years. Her reason for reemerging into Angella's life was due to Casta and her living

closer to them now, and Casta was stubbornly refusing to stop speaking with her brother to make the *Queen* feel better.

Juliet got out of her thoughts to watch Adora from the kitchen entrance to see Adora doing well in her speech classes. The class ended twenty minutes earlier than expected, and Adora was able to relax for a bit. However, the blonde child had a frown on her face, which seemed to be permanent at this point. Juliet asking "Sweetie, do you want to watch cartoons?"

Adora frowned and looked away from Juliet and the television and replied in a hurt tone, "Mommy says television is overstimulating for an autistic" wow. *Her words were so clear. Also—what the heck Angella!? Can't she watch TV?*

Juliet turned the television off and asked her, "what would you like to do?"

Adora bit down on her left arm, twisted her body a little, and replied, "I want to park. I want to the park and play."

Juliet nodded and told Adora, "Okay, sweetie, let me tell mommy where we're going, okay?"

Adora frowned and laid on the couch, hugging her knees close to her body, and whined, "She's going to say no; she doesn't like me."

Juliet was rendered speechless by that last remark. Juliet had the phone to her ear when Adora said that, and not much to Juliet's surprise—Angella didn't answer. Knowing she couldn't take Adora without Angella's permission, she called Micah.

He thankfully picked up. "Hello?" he answered.

Juliet took a breath and responded, "Hello, Micah, it's Juliet. Adora's class is over early. I wanted to see if it was okay for me to take her to the park?"

A short pause came over as he answered, "Sure, if she wants to. As long as your okay with taking her. This game is going to run on a bit longer than we thought. So we all might go out for pizza after. I'll give you the details as soon as they come, okay?"

"Great. Thank you. Micah." She said before hanging up.

She looked at Adora and brushed the hair out of her face, and told her, "We can go to the park."

Adora jumped and beamed. She hugged Juliet and thanked her relative.

The park Juliet drove them to was close to their house. It was in the housing community. Adora felt that Angella had lied to her—which she did. But had already made up her mind that she didn't like Angella anymore and wouldn't care. When she was four, she made up her mind that she didn't want Sue anymore after several beatings and being forced to watch Catra get beat. So even though Adora missed some things about Sue, she was relieved to not be around Angella right now.

Juliet watched from the benches as Adora ran around playing. Being the only kid at the playground, Adora had full access to all the fun things. Micah sent her a text to inform her that they were all going out to get pizza after the game. He asked if she could make Adora dinner. Juliet offered to take her out, and he said she could.

With Castaspella out of work, they decided to treat Adora to someplace fun. Someplace Casta knew Angella would never take Adora.

After Adora was done playing in the park. She was sweaty and happy; Casta told her she was taking her to Chucky Cheeses!

Adora could not believe it. A place she had seen only in commercials was here!? Close to home? Sue said they weren't any in this State. So now auntie was driving her to one near the mall. Another place Adora has heard of but had never been.

When she got into the pizza play place, she got a stamp on her arm and went with Juliet to a coin dispenser to get her game

tokens. Adora was amazed by all the games and light she saw. Everything was bright and loud, and she loved it! It was like when Sue wasn't home and the teenagers—*the nice ones*—let them play all around the house.

Adora was mesmerized by it all.

As she wondered and carefully examined all the games, Juliet asked Casta, "Honey? Is this going to be okay for her…? You know?"

Casta's eyes narrowed. "Autism? She's not a vegetable. Angella is just overbearing, as usual. She can have fun and play like every other child. Adora needs social interactions and exposure to exciting places; she can't be locked away from having fun.

Juliet was compelled to tell Casta about what Adora said earlier on the couch after her speech therapy. She didn't want to get into any family drama, but the words Adora spoke were alarming. Any adult should rightfully say something. "She thinks Angella doesn't like her."

Casta's eyes went wide, and an—almost—smile tugged at her face, and she kept her composure and asked, "Seriously?" this news was alarming for them. For Casta, it just confirmed her thought about Angella. Her sister-in-law was a know-it-all that was too busy for her own family. For Adora to come up with that idea, there must have been reasons. She knew Angella was critical and demanding; her intense natural personality must not mesh well with the sweet and timid nature of Adora. A child who

wants to be a normal kid. She tried to pry and learn more about Adora's feelings without taking her away from any fun. She asked Juliet to order pizza while Casta decided to join Adora for some games.

Walking over to the blonde child, Adora was delighted to see her. It was fun to have her nice new auntie around. Auntie asked to play with her, and they went to play whack-a-mole and a racing game together. Adora was so happy to have someone to play with again. Glimmer played with her less now due to the autism diagnosis, and Angella and Micah were far too busy to want to spend time with Adora neither. Finally, Auntie asked in a soft voice, "Do you play with your sister a lot?" the start to her interrogation began without Adora realizing it. To be honest, Adora replied, "No, not anymore. She watches me from. S-she doesn't play with me. She—she has her toys and friends."

Casta frowned as she followed Adora to another game. Placing a token in, Adora began another whacking game. This once was a fly swatter-styled game.

Casta crossed her arms and offered, "But, mommy and daddy, make time to play with you, right?"

Adora shook her head before moving to another game.

She asked, "Adora, the baby? What do mommy and daddy do when they are home?"

Adora frowned and sat on a ride. Finally, they lifted her off the ground. "They are busy. Mommy is always working in her office, and d-daddy who-works in the garage. They don't like to be around me."

Adora said as the machinal ride lifted her up and down in the air safely from her little chair.

Casta frowned at that. It turns out it wasn't just Angella who was too busy to spend time with the kids. Adora got off and went to another game. This was an underhanded move on Castaspella, and she knew she was using a tactic she advises against her patients. Distracting a child to get them to answer questions they wouldn't usually answer was a move many divorced parents played. She was crossing a line knowing the consequences would upset her older brother, but she didn't care. From her experience as a child care specialist in autism, she wanted to get preventative answers before Adora had a breakdown.

Angella finally heard the urgent message from Adora's school consular sitting on the cold bleachers at the soccer field. She was calling in regards to Adora's feelings at school. Doctor Razz said that Adora is feeling emotionally distant, and her pictures and drawing in class time show signs of emotional detachment. Her effects were more than what Angella could proudly say.

Angella let Micah hear the voicemail, and he concluded, "She's depressed. She must be homesick from the foster home with Sue and her little best friend."

Angella sighed and crossed her arms in worry. "What if this is a sign of low functioning autism. She went so long without a proper diagnosis, and she might have never developed a proper emotional attachment to people? I mean, will she ever be able to live on her own, get married? What about school? We don't even know if she has made any friends yet?"

Micah rubbed the back of his head in shame. "I think we should know that by now."

Both of them were saddened by this revelation. But do they even know any of Glimmer's friends?

The two moved closer to the other parents on the bleachers and saw some new faces due to the enrollment for soccer still being open. Glimmer had Micah's talent for making new friends quickly. They watched as the kids had their break on the field. All the kids were sitting on the grass, and Glimmer talked to two new girls on the grass with her. After the coach finished speaking to them, each child went back to their respective parents. Glimmer rushed over with her new friends. "Mommy! Mommy! These are my new best friends!" a little tan blonde girl with freckles and a dark-skinned girl with jet black hair rushed beside her to greet them.

Glimmer spoke for them, "This is Mermista and Perfuma."

Glimmer pointed to her mother, "My mommy is a doctor, and she's from Britain."

A few parents looked at Angella as Glimmer proudly informed them all of her mother being a doctor. She was causing Angella to turn a little red at the attention. However, she was more humble than what would be assumed of her. She didn't run around and tell people she was a doctor but did correct some when they asked her about her preferred pseudonym.

Mermista spoke up first, "My mommy works in a hospital now. Do you work in a hospital?"

Angella nodded. "Yes, I do."

Perfuma then pointed over to her mother to get Angella's attention. "My mommy is a nurse, and she works in a hospital too."

Two women, presumably the mothers of these girls, turned to see her talking to Angella. The two women; examined Angella from a distance and whispered to one another. Angella could tell they were talking about her but didn't want to shoot them a dirty look in front of three eight-year-olds. She had no female friends. Juliet was the only best friend she indeed had. Other friends from England were more acquaintances than friends, and most women at the Country Club treated Angella like a free medical consultant than a fiend either. She lacked Micah's charm to brighten up a room or Glimmer's ability to take charge.

Both women seemed to be making their way over, and Angella, a cowardly move, excused herself from talking on the phone and lying to Micah and telling him that she needed to make a phone call.

Micah knew what she was doing. She used this as an escape when social situations made her uncomfortable. Angella didn't have the social confidence that she would be expected to have outside of the hospital. She came off as arrogant and a know-it with some people in Etheria Medical Group when she's just doing her job in reality. As gorgeous and sophisticated as she was, she never connected with any women her age. She often kept to her husband's side at social events. A sign to any other would show their devotion to each other when in actuality, Angella was too anxious to be far from him.

Walking to the parking lot, she scrolled through emails to see if she had any news. Only one new message from work regarding her getting two new nurses to her department was experienced in emergency room producers. It was a relief to get that news on having two capable nurses in her department. Unfortunately, the ones she has met at Horde County thus far have been less than ideal.

To buy more time, she gave Juliet a call to check on Adora. To her annoyance, Castaspella answered for her. Then, hearing buzzing and sound effects in the background, she asked, "where are you?"

Casta replied, "We've taken Adora to the Chucky cheeses. She's having such a good time right now."

Angella's eyes narrowed. "Who said for you to do that?"

"Micah gave us permission." She replied with a sound of triumph in her voice.

Angella angrily replied, "Adora overstimulates easily; I wish you didn't take her to *there* of all places."

Casta retorted back, "If anything, Adora is under-stimulated, this may come as a shock to you, but this little girl has been smiling ear to ear all night with us. She needed a reward from all the extra work your forcing on her with speech therapy and all those other therapists."

Casta might as well of just called Angella a terrible mother.

Without much thought to the following words to come out of her mouth, she demanded, "Bring her back home."

Casta antagonized her. "Micah said she could have pizza and play games. So you want me to stop her from finally having fun?"

"Why do you always undermine me?" Angella questioned.

“Why are you making it a mission to isolate Adora? I finally had you completely disregard a decent conversation with my niece and her feelings.” Casta replied.

Angella felt her throat go dry at that statement.

Adora barely talked to anyone at the house, and to find out, she felt more comfortable talking to Casta—CASTA!?—more than her? How could that be fair?

The phone conversation ended with Angella declaring, “Fine then, We’ll come to you, then.”

She stormed off to the car and waited for Micah and Glimmer to come to her.

Oblivious to what had just transpired, Micah tried to tell her that Glimmer’s new friend's mothers were going to work with her in Horde County Hospital, and they were looking forward to working with her. Naturally, Angella didn’t care about this news, nor did she pay attention to him when he said most of the kids from the game were going to Chucky cheeses. Her mind was far past this car ride, and all she wanted to do was have her daughter back at her side for the night. Juliet couldn’t be blamed for this; as much as she enables Castaspella’s behavior, she had the nuance to know Casta did all of this without any of Juliet’s control. In her mind, all she could think of was horrible scenarios of Adora getting picked on, teased, having a sensory overload in front of other kids, and them being cruel to her. Poor Adora wasn’t used

to all these new places. As much fun as it is for her to be at an arcade, it could also be too much for a child like her.

When they arrived at the arcade to see Adora happily playing a game with Juliet, worry eased up on Angella. She admired her former friend for being so kind to Adora. This was one of those rare times Adora was smiling. Ever since the diagnosis, Adora had been smiling less and crying more. With Juliet, the blonde was just as cheery as before the adoption was finalized.

All those warm feelings dropped out of Angella's mind once she saw Casta coming towards them. Her obnoxious panicked look made only direct eye contact with Micah and only a nervous glance at Angella. The younger sister to Micah constantly stirred up drama; the same look she was giving Micah right now was the same look she gave him when she crashed their car and threw a house party at her mother's home and got thrown out. Casta was never one to leave out dramatics, faking a smile to Glimmer while glaring at Angella as she tugged on Micah's arm to take her to Adora.

Unable to give Casta a piece of her mind, her tactical method of running to Micah first made this anger her to no end. It didn't help that the soccer team was trickling in from the front door. They were making it impossible for her to approach Casta without looking like the bad guy. Finally, the two women from earlier came in with Glimmer's new friends and smiled at her.

Angella felt a strong sense of wanting to retreat from talking to other parents. She never spoke much to the other soccer moms, and before they could approach her to introduce themselves, she walked over to where her family was.

She was crowding around Adora while she played on some helicopter contraption. She peddled her little legs as fast as possible as she smiled down at her sister. “Look how high!” her voice louder than necessary in this setting. The second Adora saw Angella; the smile faded as she nervously stared at Angella. Finally, she stopped peddling her feet and slowly came down from the ride.

Everyone starred at Angella, as it was clear the mood changed the second she came over. Her face burned with shame because she was not enjoyed by her family when Casta gets involved. Adora took a moment to rush over to another game to keep her distance from her adoptive mother. Finding comfort in a giant touch screen game, Glimmer followed after. All adults had their eyes on Angella when Casta spoke up, “Adora’s been so happy today with us; her speech class went well, right Juliet?” turning to her girlfriend to get validation. Juliet nodded and gave Angella an apologetic look; she knew that Casta had crossed a line. Finally, Micah spoke up, “Sis wants to tell us about something Adora said earlier.” He said, looking at Juliet for confirmation, putting her on the spot to give Angella terrible news.

Juliet offered, “Let’s sit down and talk real quick.”

Looking over to see the girls were together playing, and now several other friends were joining them, put them at ease that they wouldn’t overhear an adult conversation.

Adora was around all girls her age. Almost, they were all Glimmer’s age. Her older sister proudly showed off her adoptive

sister. "This is Adora; she's my little sister. We don't look alike because she's adopted."

Adora's face flushed as four girls from Glimmer's soccer team starred at her. One girl, in particular, caught Adora's eyes and heart instantly. Mermista was dark-skinned and had black hair. She didn't look precisely like Catra, but she was pretty like Catra. The only words that could come out of Adora's mouth were "You pretty." Directing to Mermista. Taken back but also flattered, Mermista shrugged it off and tossed her ponytail over her shoulder, and replied, "I know." And smiled at Adora, causing the blonde to turn even more red in the face. Glimmer found her reaction odd but didn't make her feel uncomfortable about it. All the girls started to talk about soccer, and one girl pointed out a game by the windows that was a kicking game for soccer. All five little girls went over while all the parents stayed at their tables.

Angella had the worst bomb dropped on her as Casta told Angella about how awful she was as a parent and how sad Adora feels, and the dreaded *she doesn't like me* comment made earlier around Juliet in private. Micah sat there and tried to hold Angella's hand under the table, but his wife's hand was bawled into a fist as Casta chastised her for every little thing she has done with Adora since the diagnosis.

Casta felt she was in the right to say all this. But, as an advocate for Adora, she let all the private information she coaxed out of Adora be her ammunition to get over Angella. So the new adoptive mother of her autistic daughter had to take it all in a while. Her husband and former best friend her be humiliated by her hot mess of sister-in-law that has done more damage in her presence around Angella than she would ever know.

“You took her fish light away, she’s afraid of the dark, and you took it away from her because you thought it would overstimulate her? It calms her. You did the exact opposite to help her sleep partner; you also bought all those sensory toys. Those aren’t for every minute of play, she’s just like every other little girl, and she wants regular toys too; sensory toys are more to help with her stimulation. On top of that, your constant berating of her stutter has crushed her self-esteem to the point she’s afraid to even talk to you.”

Micah spoke up on Angella’s behalf, “Okay, Casta, thank you, but Angella doesn’t berate Adora. She only reminds her to take her time with speaking and to annunciate.” He looked over to see Angella was not breathing. She wanted to cry and storm off but couldn’t due to the location. Making a scene in front of the soccer moms would kill her reputation and damage Glimmer in the process; she didn’t want her to be known as the girl with the dramatic mother.

Juliet scooted herself out of the booth and reached for Angella’s hand. “Hey, let's get some fresh air.” Angella had her head down as they left the front door. I was feeling ashamed to be handled with such care.

Casta waited for them to be out of earshot, turned to her brother, and gestured to the door. “See? Anytime she’s criticized, she needs to run off and be pampered.”

Micah’s face showed visible anger.

He loved his baby sister, but he could not excuse the disrespect of Casta telling them all this a public place. He knew the butting relationship between them had gone on for years. From the incident to Angella walking in on Juliet and Casta when they were supposed to babysit Glimmer when Casta got drunk and moved on to Angella, the two had never been close. Casta, in the beginning, had always made a lousy impression on Angella from her past immature antics.

Even though Casta had matured and changed from then, it didn't make things any better. Even if Casta specialized in autistic children's therapy, it still wasn't the place Angella wanted to hear criticism from.

Micah spoke in a disappointed tone, "I know you think this was helpful. You think Angella is some out-of-touch terrible mother, and you always want to find reasons to tell her that. My wife is my life, Casta. You can't talk to her like that."

Casta felt the wind being knocked out of her. Micah wasn't on her side at all. Her defenses were up; she did want an excuse to criticize Angella, but she is apprehensive of Adora. She restored. "What about Adora? Her feelings should take priority over Angella's and your ego. Two parents that barely have time for Glimmer and you think raising a child with special needs is going to be something you can plan. She's a high energy, she needs time to play, and she has serious abandonment issues; her not seeing you two or being excluded from things is breaking her little heart."

Micah’s eyes narrowed as he demanded, “What did Adora tell you? Word for word.”

The siblings were entering a heated conversation while Juliet saw the softer side of Angella; by soft, she meant the part of Angella that she wished no one would ever see. The side of her that is an overworked career woman and mother desperately trying to keep everything together despite her anxiety tearing her apart and her inability to connect with her autistic daughter made everything so much more personal to her. She hugged herself as she tried not to cry in front of Juliet. Her friend took her into her arms and apologized, “I’m so sorry, I didn’t know what Casta was going to say. We didn’t want to offend you or Micah, and we just wanted to have a good time with Adora.”

Angella fought back the tears to regain her computer. Then, breaking away from the hug, she assured Juliet she knew that was the truth. “I know, I know, it just hurts so bloody much to know Adora doesn’t feel loved enough by us. We try and try to get her to open up, and whatever we—whatever I keep doing to ruin that is going to make things harder and harder on us as a family.” She wiped the tears from her eyes that were falling from her cheek.

Juliet placed a hand on her shoulder. “This job transfer came at a bad time. You're doing the best you can. If you can have more time with Adora, it would make the world of good.”

Angella nodded, and the two shared a hug before Juliet walked her to her car. “You want me to drive you home?”

While Juliet took it upon herself to support Angella, Micah and Casta had a very long conversation on boundaries and how to help without coming off hurtful. Their discussion had paused and had to be whispered as they still were in a kid's arcade, but the message was clear. Casta's intentions were good but not executed correctly, and as a family, they would all put more focus on Adora.

Thankfully while this all went on, Adora was busy showing off her soccer skills at the kicking game and impressed the coach, who was there with his daughter. Thus, giving Micah a hard offer to refuse. "Adora is a great kicker, and she would be great at soccer."

His blonde daughter hid behind Glimmer as Micah was looked on for an answer. He only stated, "That's great news; it will be up to Adora if she wants to play. Thank you for the offer." He smiled at his daughter. Adora felt tense at his warm smile. If daddy were nice, would he let her play soccer with Glimmer and her friends?"

Adora kept playing with the other girls, running around the arcade to new games and going back to Micah twice for more token money.

Casta felt some guilt in how she handled telling Angella about the situation regarding Adora. However, she knew Angella was sensitive and didn't mean to do anything hurtful to Adora. Her phone buzzed in her jacket pocket.

Juliet sent her a text saying she was taking Angella home and that she was upset.

Feeling even more guilty, she didn't tell Micah right away. Knowing he would give her a hard time again. He sighed when he saw Glimmer and Adora playing. "I'm so proud of Glimmer being so good with Adora. She was so excited about the adoption and has been so good to her."

Casta smiled at that and looked down at her soda.

Micah told her, "I'm glad you got Adora to open up to you. I want her to love and trust you. But, unfortunately, we got a phone call earlier from her school saying she has shown signs of depression, and earlier today, we found out she has been hiding her bedwetting. It might be a symptom of the medication, or she might be under severe trauma that we'll need to go through therapy to help her with." He looked at his sister. "I still want your help with her; just because I'm mad at you for making Angie feel like crap doesn't mean I don't want you around."

She smiled at him, and the two were able to have a normal conversation. As were Angella and Juliet, catching up on so much missed information about each other and enjoying each other's time. When Micah brought the whole family back to the house, she hugged Juliet goodbye as the girls went to their rooms. Micah and Casta grinned at each other when the two parted away. Juliet and Casta were leaving together while Micah smiled at his wife. "How are you feeling, Angie?"

She softly replied, “A bit better now, but I still want to talk to Adora.”

He kissed her on the cheek before she left to go upstairs.

She knocked on Adora’s bedroom door beofre entering and asked, “May I come in?”

She heard Adora’s little feet rush to the door to open it. The blonde had on the cutest pow print pajamas. Angella couldn't help but coo. “Awww, you look so adorable.”

Adora’s face went pink, and she backed away from the door and rushed to her bed. Angella’s compliment surprised Adora, and she didn’t know how to feel about it. Sometimes Angella could come off as nice, and those minor signs of her kindness could lead Adora on. For all her anxiety around Angella—she wanted Angella to like her the most. She missed being the favorite child. In the foster home, she was praised by Sue for her excellent behavior. All she wanted was for Angella to like her more—she wanted Angella to love her and want to be around her.

Angella walked over to the closet and asked Adora, “Would you like your fish light plugged in again?”

Adora jumped at the offer, "Y—yes please, m-mommy!" instantly regretting her stutter.

Angella took the light out from the top shelf of the closet and plugged it in on Adora's nightstand. Adora got under her covers and stared as the bubbles started to make the plastic fish move in the tube.

Angella asked, "Can I tuck you in?"

Adora nodded.

Any mother would love to tuck their child in for bed; for Angella, this was a cautious slope. Sensory and trauma aside, she knew Adora did not favor her and wanted to show Adora how gentle and sweet she could be. Unfortunately, in these past few weeks, she had lost the ability to show her that. Her hands carefully tucked the precious blonde in, feeling the little child tense at her touch. Adora's eyes were closed tightly as Angella hovered over her, grateful to have her being so kind to her but fearful of what these could all be about. False kindness was a feature Sue always showed the most. In delicate situations, Sue easily overpowered and hurt Adora with no time to respond by blocking hits or hiding due to Sue's kind nature being so warm and inviting. Adora kept her body tense, knowing that she could quickly receive a *pow-pow* from past mistakes. To her surprise, she received a soft kiss on the forehead, and it made her jump a little in her bed. Angella kneeled by the bed to be eye level with Adora and said: "I love you."

Adora didn’t know how to respond to that; only Catra told her she loved her, not Sue. Even when she tried to tell Sue she loved her, she was meant with a cold *“Don’t”* response. Her heart wanted to say it back, knowing that it might be what Angella wants to hear, or it could be a trap to hurt Adora’s feelings. But, instead, she closed her eyes tightly again and nodded.

Angella felt her throat go dry and Adora’s lack of response. As personal as this was, Angella had to remember Adora’s past trauma and how badly the effects can be moving forward. All she could do was kiss her forehead again and tell her, “I love you so much, Adora,”

Before getting up to leave the bedroom, her heart was sinking slightly. Changes needed to be made for Adora to feel loved in this home, and Angella was ready to make all the changes necessary for that to happen.

Understanding You.

The gesture was sweet, even if it wasn't executed with the work. However, it still showed dedication on Angella's part. Despite a professional salon ruined job on her blonde highlights, making her head from the back look more like a zebra from the 90's she did her best to be calm with it. Even if the salon felt bad and gave it to her for free, she still had to deal with Micah gawking at her. The whole drive home didn't make things easier. So stressed, she chose to drive while Micah sat in the passenger seat, constantly glancing over and his wife every chance he got.

"Just say it!" Angella demanded. She just wanted to get the jokes and intelligent remarks out of the way.

Micah shook his head and replied, "I'm not going to say anything."

"Well, what do you think about it?" She asked.

He averted his eyes and answered, "Well, truthfully, it's not your best look when your hair is up and looks better, but when it's down, it doesn't look so great."

Angella tapped her right palm against the steering wheel and declared, "Well, for the next few months, my hair is staying up."

"Aww, don't do all that." Micah frowned. "I love your hair."

Angella pointed to the back of her head. "Like this!?" she exclaimed.

He laughed. "Even like that, darling."

She finally cracked a smile, and then Micah's phone went off. In a panic, he answered it in a hushed tone to tell them to call back later. With that, Angella's eyes narrowed, and she asked, "Why didn't you want to take that call?"

"Oh, it was sometimes about the car shop. But, don't worry, love." He replied.

Annoyed by that response, she reminded him, "You know I am a co-owner to that place; shouldn't I be in the know about what goes on."

Micah assured it, "We aren't losing any more money sweetheart, I'm working on a plan."

She didn't want to get into an argument, so she just accepted his response and pulled into the parent's pick-up spot for the school. Adora and Glimmer made their way to the car, and Angella couldn't help but see the huge smile on Adora's face when talking to the crossing guard. She was a lovely woman who was a little younger than Angella, but she had won over Adora simply by

having blue eyes and blonde hair. Micah noticed the last few times he had picked the girls up from school. Adora would talk to the cross walking guard. He took this as Adora being more comfortable with people, and Angella took it as Adora liking everyone else more than her. She had heard Adora talk to Glimmer about how different she looked and how she wished she was *pretty like mommy,* and that statement has bothered Angella ever since she heard it. Getting blonde highlights was something to bring Adora closer to her. The first thing to come out of Glimmer's mouth when she buckled herself into the backseat was, "Mommy, what happened to your hair?"

Micah snorted and covered his mouth and that just made Glimmer smile.

Angella's eyes narrowed as she explained, "I dyed it."

Glimmer innocently replied, "You should have gone to a professional."

Micah couldn't hold in his laughter as he let out a loud, boisterous laugh at Angella's expense.

Adora darted her eyes around nervously, knowing they were being mean by laughing at mom and feared what Angella would do with them laughing. She kept her head down and shut her eyes tightly to avoid getting in any trouble with Angella. Micah saw this through the rearview mirror and gestured for Glimmer to stop. The two looked at Adora and asked, "You okay, Adora?"

Adora nodded and refused to open her eyes in case she caught Angella looking at her angrily. Even if she didn't laugh, she still felt in trouble just by being in the same car as the other two. It was *guilt by association,* as Sue would say. If one kid did something wrong in a room with their kids around and didn't stop it, they would even get punished.

Heading back home, it was time for Glimmer to get ready for soccer practice. Adora became excited as she knew last week was fun. After speech therapy, she spent time with Juliet and played at a pizza arcade with Glimmer and her friends. She was looking forward to after speech therapy so she could go and play with friends—especially Glimmer's *beautiful* friend.

Her happiness was shut down when she went downstairs to see Angella was still home, and it looked like only Micah was going with Glimmer to practice. Adora looked around to see no one was looking at her or telling her to put on her shoes and jacket. Finally, it sunk into her that Angella would be home while her speech therapy went on, which made her stomach hurt. Angella would hear her make mistakes and mess words up. When Micah finally caught a glance of Adora clutching her stomach, he asked her, "Are you okay, pumpkin?"

Angella then drew her focus to Adora and walked over to her.

Frantically, Adora shook her head and went back upstairs.

Her throat felt dry, as if she was going to cry. She didn't want to be alone with her new mom. Angella wasn't friendly to her anymore; she made her eat yucky foods, made her take medicine that made her feel worse, and didn't like playing or talking. She hated Adora so much she made Adora take speech classes so she could talk better. She went into her closet and hid with her stuffed monkey, and curled into a tiny ball. She was feeling a sensory overload, and she was trying to self-soothe. Her anxiety got the better of her, and she needed time away from everyone. Being diagnosed recently, Adora never knew why she did these things; to her, they felt normal. Now with Angella, she felt shame in them. She hid more from her family, fearing what she would do could cause Angella to be unhappy or teased by Glimmer and Micah. She jumped when she saw Angella open the closet door and look down at her "Adora, Sweetie? What's wrong?"

Adora held it behind her back, fearing Angella would throw it like all the other clothes she used to wear. But, instead, the blonde stammered, "I—I'm being good."

Angella kneeled to be at eye level with Adora. In return, this made Adora more anxious as now she was cornered into a small space she felt safe in and was now intruded on by someone she didn't want. Angella could quickly raise her hand and slap Adora endlessly, and there would be nothing the little girl could do. Adora tensed as Angella spoke to her, "I know you're a good girl. Do you want to come downstairs? Your speech therapy teacher is coming soon."

Adora nodded and stepped out of the closet.

Angella frowned and how meek she had gotten and extremely sensitive she was. The only time she ever saw Adora smile was

when she wasn't around. Then, a ping on Angella's phone came on, and it was the speech therapist telling her that she was at the door. Angella took Adora by the hand and informed her, "It's time, sweetie."

Adora whimpered and kept her head down. Finally, Angella asked her, "Adora, please tell me what is wrong?"

Adora shook her head and replied, "I—I'm a good girl! I'll be good!"

Angella turned to her and kneeled and asked her, "Baby, you are a good girl."

Adora whimpered, "C—can I got the park t—today?"

Angella frowned. "Sweetie, today won't be a good day."

Adora's little blue eyes watered as she looked up at Angella. This made Angella feel awful, but she knew Adora needed speech therapy and escorted her to the kitchen dining table for her tutor. After she settled Adora in for her lesson, she left to go upstairs. Upstairs, Angella texted Micah.

Angella: Adora is upset again. She was on the verge of tears right now because she couldn't go to the park.

Micah: She sure does like the park.

Angella: She's full of energy, and I need to sleep before work tonight; when are you two getting back.

Micah: Practice will be over in half an hour. By the way, Hannah and Julia asked about you; they are lovely ladies.

Angella: They are my co-workers. I'm their boss.

Micah: I get that, but even I go out with my co-workers. They seem highly invested in you, and I think you and them should go out one night.

Angella: Forget it. I don't mingle with co-workers outside of the hospital.

Micah signed and didn't respond after that. Angella was just as disappointed with herself as he was with her. This whole Adora problem has been eating her up inside. I'm *a medical professional, a good mother to Glimmer, and a good wife, which keeps me from being a good mother to Adora. So what am I doing wrong?*

Her thoughts were cut short when she heard sobbing coming from downstairs. Her immediate reaction was to rush downstairs to

see what had happened. In the kitchen, Adora had her head down in her arms, sobbing. Angella saw the tutor try to console her. "Adora, honey, it's okay, don't be upset. This takes time."

Adora shook her head from within her arms and cried, "I keep messing up!"

Angella moved the chair close to her and sat next to Adora to comfort her to "Adora, it's okay."

Adora lifted her head to reveal her red cheeks, her nose was running, and her eyes had tears streaming from them. Angella tried to wipe her tears, but the second Adora saw her lift her hand, she thought she was going to get slapped and ran out of the kitchen. Leaving both adults to look stunned, Angella told the tutor that Adora had been having a hard time and that they should end the session. The tutor explained Adora was trying to read a whole book without stuttering, and once she did, she broke down into tears.

The tutor excused herself to leave, and Angella went upstairs to see how Adora was doing. Opening the door, she saw the little blonde pacing and repeatedly punching herself in the head. Angella gasped and tried to grab Adora's arms to make her stop, and that only made Adora jolt her body back so she could slam her head down. Angella stopped her from falling. "Sweetie, I got you! Please stop that."

Adora shook her head frantically and still kicked and tried to hit herself. Angella ignored the fact she was being kicked by Adora to

try and restrain her. "Adora, please stop!"

Adora was now scared, having a full-on meltdown. Her sensory stimulation was entirely out of control, and all she wanted to do was kick and cry. Angella attempted to draw her into a hug, and all that did was let Adora's arms free, and in her tantrum, she swung full force into Angell's right eye. Angella pulled back in pain and covered her eye as Adora still flailed around her bedroom floor. As if the timing couldn't be worse, Micah and Glimmer came home and rushed upstairs when they heard the crying. Glimmer looked from behind her father to see something that haunted her. The sight of Adora rolling on the floor, screaming and crying while flailing around, made her uneasy. She didn't want to go near Adora because she felt scared of her and seeing Angella hold her side in pain scared her even more. Finally, she moved to the doorway and told Micah, "Adora's having a sensory overload tantrum."

The word tantrum struck a chord with Glimmer as she only knew that for being a thing babies and toddlers did, and seeing Adora do this made her angry. She didn't look at Adora with pity but saw her as a brat. To throw herself down and hit mommy was something she couldn't forgive.

Micah looked at Adora, who was now losing steam and showing she was regaining her senses. I just sat on the floor with her and lay next to her as she cried. Adora whimpered and coughed a bit until sitting back up. The tears streamed down her face still when she turned to Micah. He didn't scold or hit her. He was on his knees when he sat up, and his hands were behind his back, making Adora feel slightly safer since he didn't look like he could hit her at any second. Adora rubbed her eyes, and Micah asked, "Can you tell me what happened?"

Adora cried, "I mess up!"

Micah clarified, "You messed up? What happened?"

"I—I—I can't t-talk good, and—and—and I was crying."

Not much of an explanation, but Adora started to cry again so that Micah couldn't get much else out of her. He told her that he would get her some water, and he left her room. Getting Adora bottled water and then leaving her to calm down.

Looking into his bedroom, he saw Angella sitting on her vanity chair while Glimmer had her hands on her mother's lap to look at her face. Micah's face dropped when he saw that Adora had left Angella with a bruise under her eye.

Glimmer remarked, "Adora is a bad girl."

Angella shook her head. "Adora didn't mean to do this."

Glimmer huffed. "She needs to say sorry and get grounded."

Micah came over to Angella and placed his hands on Angella's shoulders. "Baby girl, this is something that happens to Adora. She can't help, and she doesn't mean to do hurt anyone."

Glimmer protested, "She doesn't do it at school."

Angella tried to explain, "Well, she might not be overstimulated at school. But, sometimes at home, she might get overstimulated, or maybe something upsets her, and she can't control herself."

Glimmer frowned. "Well, I'm not playing with her anymore; I don't want her to hit me."

Angella tried to assure "Glimmer it was an accident; she didn't do it on purpose."

Glimmer didn't want to hear it. She was mad at Adora for hitting her mom and didn't like that Adora could get away with having a tantrum. Finally, she left the bedroom to go to her room; leaving the two adults alone, they spoke in a hushed tone. "What are we going to do about this?" Micah asked.

Angella shook her head. "Darling, I'm not sure; Adora has been miserable since her second day here with us; we might need to get more help or to console for her."

Micah agreed and offered, "What about the rest of the night? What are we going to do?"

Angella offered, "We'll give her space and check in on her in a bit beofre dinner."

Micah bit his lip. "Would this be a bad time to say Casta and Juliet are coming over for dinner?"

Angella wanted to shout at him. *Yes, this is a terrible time!* Then realized Casta is a specialist for children with autism and Juliet is a physical therapist. They could help Adora out right now even if Angella hated the fact she couldn't be the end all be all solution for Adora.

Getting up and peeking into Adora's room, she was stunned to see Glimmer in Adora's bedroom. But not to be supportive. Instead, the eight-year-old had the blonde hunched in the corner of the room; her back turned to Glimmer as the brunette decided to relatively hit Adora on the top of the head. Poor Adora did nothing but as Glimmer hit her. Angella gasped and shouted, "Glimmah!"

Glimmer turned back and saw her mother in the doorway. A muffled voice from Micah came downstairs. "What's going on?"

Angella angrily announced, "Glimmer was hitting Adora."

Glimmer then moved away from Adora, and the blonde covered her head, shaking as she tried not to cry.

The thumps of Micah's feet were coming upstairs as he ran to the doorway to see Glimmer in the room. She was scared now. The idea of upsetting her daddy was worse than upsetting her mom. So Micah sternly told her, "Glimmer come here right now."

Glimmer started to cry. "Adora was the bad girl! She hit mommy first!" Micah extended his hand out to her so she could hold on to it. "Glimmer, we need to talk about this." He said. She still cried as he made her go into her bedroom with him.

Angella looked to see Adora still in the corner of her bedroom, softly crying to herself. She walked over, slightly hesitant due to her recent episode, and asked her, "Adora are you hurt."

Adora nodded and rubbed her head. "It hurts."

Angella offered her a hand. "Do you want to come downstairs with me? I'll get you an icepack for your head."

Adora turned to look up and Angella and saw the visible bruise she had given her. Horrified at her actions, she quickly turned away and hugged herself closely; shaking her head, she said, "No! I'm bad, I can't" she then started to cry again, and Angella tried to console her. "Adora, it was an accident."

Adora then banged her head forcefully in the corner of the wall and cried, "I'm a bad girl! You're never going to like me now!" before bursting into another fit of tears.

Later in the night.

Casta had a long talk with Glimmer about understanding autism and Adora's needs, and what she should be doing as a sister. Micah was there for the conversation, too, since he had the most challenging time explaining autism to Glimmer in the first place.

Angella and Juliet were with Adora helping her relax. The nervous child sat down between the two of them, although she leaned more towards Juliet. This bothered Angella, but she couldn't take offense to this now with Adora not crying.

Juliet asked her, "Sweetie, why are you so sad all the time?" she rubbed Adora's back for comfort, and Adora felt less tense from the gentle touch. The blonde was hesitant to explain herself when she looked up at Angella. Her mother promised her, "Adora, you can tell us anything; nothing will get you in trouble or punished; we just want to know so we can make you feel better." Juliet smiled warmly at Angella for being so compassionate, and Adora looked down and explained. The tears are slowly coming

back as she spoke, "I—I m-miss my friends. I miss Catra M-my best friend. I don't feel like I'm good here, and—and I keep making mistakes, and I know you don't like me." The last part made Adora whimper out a cry. Angella desperately wanted to embrace Adora; slowly rubbing her back to replace Juliet's hand, she asked Adora first, "Can I give you a hug?"

Adora nodded and moved her body to reach her arms around Angella; the mother lifted Adora onto her lap and held the child close to her, noticing she was about as heavy as Glimmer was in her arms. She held her close as Adora cried, "If you don't like me, I'll go away to a group home or kid jail." A scary thing to tell a child her age.

Angella assured Adora, "Sweetie, I promise that will never happen. We love, and we will never give you up to anyone. We love you. I don't want you to feel sad, tell me, what would make you feel better?"

Adora buried her face into Angella's chest and whined, "you're going to say no."

Angella looked at Juliet and back to Adora and asked, "Sweetie, please tell us."

Adora looked away and asked, "I want to play; I miss playing outside and going to the park. You—you always say no and—and I only can p-play at recess. It's not fair, Glimmer gets to go and play with friends, and I can't even see my friends. I—I want to go play, and you don't l—let me."

Guilt came over Angella as she didn't realize how much Adora valued going to the park. She should have known better, seeing as Adora had ADHD and Autism. The poor child must want to burst with all her energy. Adora then commented, "Ev—every day is different. I get—get upset because When I come home, your not home or you are home, or we have to go out, or we have—do stuff." Adora must be referring to Angella and Micah's schedules being so demanding. Glimmer was born into this, so it didn't phase her, but for Adora, she needed a solid routine. Angella stroked the side of Adora's face and kissed the top of her head. "We will make a more consistent routine for you, sweetheart."

Adora clung tightly to Angella for a brief moment before saying, "I miss hugs…. I used to get hugs all the time before I got autism….."

Juliet looked away uncomfortably as she knew that hurt Angella. It was knowing well that Angella only became less affectionate with Adora to try and mitigate her sensory issues. Instead, she made Adora feel neglected and hurt Angella deeper due to her being emotionally and physically neglected. She always made sure to make Glimmer feel loved, and she was awful for Adora to think she wasn't.

It was an emotional night for the two of them; Angella kept it together until bedtime. Tucking Adora and Glimmer in and giving them kisses on the forehead. It bothered her how much she had missed all these needed signs for Adora and left her feeling so miserable. It made her feel awful to know all this, but she knew she would do better for her starting forward. She noticed Micah was still in the office and went downstairs to see what was

keeping him. She overheard the end of a conversation he was having on the phone.

"Great, as long as I can get it writing that none of my current employees are losing their jobs or pay, I'll settle with the contract. Good, thank you. Have a good night."

She went back upstairs to ponder what he was doing. If he were selling the car shop, that would be a huge burden lifted off them since it was losing money every month, but it would be a devastating loss for Micah. She couldn't wish for him to do something that extreme. When he came upstairs, he acted like he was too tired to talk and lay on the bed. She chose not to pry tonight and get ready for work.

She hated these overnight shifts.

The commute sucked, the hospital was in the slums, and the people were awful; just because the location wasn't ideal doesn't mean the cleanliness and service had to dive with the locals. Getting in, she was greeted with a *code grey*. Meaning they had a hostile patient that was going into withdrawals and attacked a nurse. After ensuring the nurse was alright, she checked on the patient but moved quickly due to the police coming in and arresting him for stealing. Apparently, the man stole all his girlfriend's meds, got high, went crazy, and somehow ended up here.

Exhausted in only her first hour of work, she started to walk over to her office when she saw a nurse rush over to her side. "Good

evening, Doctor Brighten." She saw the cheery smile of the curly-haired blonde with tan skin next to her and smiled, and it was Julia, Perfuma's mother and one of Glimmer's new friends she couldn't stop talking about.

"Evening Nurse Julia, how are we this evening?" Angella replied politely.

Julia shrugged. "Oh, you know. I cleaned poop, some pee and then got screamed at by a junkie. The usual."

Angella placed her hand on her shoulder. "Your alright, though?"

Julia nodded. "Oh, trust me, I'm fine. I have tough skin. I can handle some harsh words."

Angella nodded. "Well, that's good. I wish more nurses were like you. I was too mean, and my other hospital and they landed me here." Angella has never admitted that to anyone on staff beofre; she wondered how Julia would handle hearing that.

"We all know how you were back at Brightmoon. But, here you gotta be tough, some of these nurses won't work unless you scream at them; I was wondering why you weren't as aggressive as they said you'd be." Julia replied.

Angella looked slightly ashamed. "I wasn't aware you were all aware of my past work."

Julia chuckled. "Trust me, we know, and we were hoping for someone to come in and clean house with all the sucky staffing issues we have."

Angella swallowed then replied, "Well, I suppose I can be harder on some people, but I will warn you and apologize for the upfront; I'm not easy to work with, I tend to snap, and I get frustrated easily. I'm not proud of it but," she stopped to face Julia "I would hope you know I don't mean for it to be personal. I respect and value all nurses."

Julia looked at her and saw the sincerity in her eyes and also sadness. Finally, she asked her, "Are you okay, Dr. Brighten?" referring to her bruise under her eye.

Angella touched the side of her face and replied, "My daughter Adora has been struggling since the adoption and accidentally hit me during an autistic meltdown."

Julia covered her mouth and gasped, "Oh gosh, I'm so sorry I didn't know."

Angella shook her head. "It's okay, and I don't tell many people."

The two heard faint crying come from behind them and turned to rush back to the main desk to see what was happening. First, a

stretcher was brought in a child. Then, a woman Angella recognized instantly as Sue Weaver, looking panicked as a child, rolled into a room was Adora's little best friend, Catra.

Angella dashed into the room with the EMTs settling her in. "What happened here?" Angella asked, with Julia following her in from behind. The EMT began, "According to her foster mother, she choked herself on accident and passed out."

Angella glared at Sue as the foster mother explained, "she's awake and breathing now, so we should leave."

The EMT saw Sue reach for Catra on the bed and put his hand out, and told her, "She needs to be examined before she can be released."

Catra choked out a cry, "My throat hurts."

Angella ordered Julia, "Get her on an NC and check her vitals." The EMTs excused themselves and left Angella and Sue alone for a brief moment. Sue calmly greeted, "Dr. Brighten."

"Miss Weaver." Angella Coldly replied.

The dark-haired woman gestured to under Angella's eye and remarked, "I see Adora had a fit. Shame. She only throws a tantrum when she's under an enormous amount of stress."

Angella scowled at her and saw the shuffle of Catra on the bed as the petite brunette whimpered, "A—Adora? Is she okay, where is she?" trying to get up.

Sue snapped, "You just said your throat hurts, so why are you talking?" then Catra cringed and went to lay back down. Angella questioned Sue, "Explain to me how again she lost consciousness?"

Sue waved off her explanation. "She regained it right before the paramedics arrived; it was a little accident; she's fine now. I need to bring her back home Catra hates the hospital, right Catra?"

Catra replied, "Hospitals killed my real mom."

Angella's face fell at that. What a horrible thing to say to a child and to have her repeat it? Julia walked in with the NC machine and began to set her up. Angella motioned for Sue to be out in the hall with her as they spoke.

Angella's tone shifted from polite and professional to angry and warning, "I know this was no accident, and unless you want me to get child services involved, you will tell me the truth."

Sue crossed her arms. "You think you can threaten me? Catra is a destructive child. She has attention devastate disorder and

opposition defiance disorder; she has a record of running into and falling into things all the time. I mean, the girl left Walmart in an ambulance last spring after she tried to climb up an aisle of toys to get to the next aisle over."

Angella rolled her eyes. "That doesn't explain her right now, how a child suffocates to passing out in the late of the night when she has a school in the morning?"

Sue sighed. "Well, I don't know. She's a highly active child and doesn't sleep well. Anything could have happened to her."

Angella crossed her arms. "Oh? Then how did you know she needed medical care?"

Sue narrowed her eyes. "I'm a foster mother of nine children; you don't think I check on them? Throughout the night and I make sure my teens, children, and toddlers are okay. Despite your judgmental attitude, I am a mother to these kids; I'm far from the monster you assume I am."

Julia poked her head out from the curtains to see where Angella was and made her way over to her "Dr. Brighten; I need to show you the cause of suffocation."

Sue looked visibly uneasy by this and asked, "May I speak with Catra for a moment? She doesn't like to be away from me for too long."

Angella put her arm out to block her. "No, we need to speak with her first."

Sue warned, "She's a child. She doesn't understand what is being explained to her."

Angella dismissed her and went back to where Catra was to see the little girl was still out from her blankets with her right leg sticking out.

Julia remarked, "These are burn marks from cigarettes, and she is bruised around her neck. She might have been strangled."

Catra answered, "I get in trouble a lot, and I get hurt a lot."

Angella softly asked Catra, "Now, sweetie do you hurt yourself, or does someone else hurt you."

Catra looked around and saw the silhouette from behind the curtain. She knew it was Sue and responded the way she was always told to "No, I'm a bad girl, and I get hurt all the time by myself."

Angella knew Sue was right outside the curtain and explained to Catra, "Sweetie, these burns on your legs, how did you get

them?"

Catra shifted her eyes. "I don't know. I forget."

Angella reminded her, "Catra, you can tell me anything; I'm a doctor. I only want to help you."

Catra asked, "Can I get a snack?"

Angella looked to Julia and her at up to leave the room. "I'll get you a snack," Julia replied and left the curtained room. She was a little startled to see Sue right outside but didn't let that stop her from getting the child a pre-wrapped cookie and juice box from the break room pantry.

Angella noted the entire incident, where all Catra's cuts and bruises were, and how Sue acted. After a quick snack, Catra still said all her injuries were from her and claimed not to remember what happened beofre she got to the hospital. But Angella was no fool and could tell by the bruises that Catra was choked. Sue must have angrily choked her until she passed out and panicked and for an ambulance, fearing the worst, but when Catra can back to consciousness, she wanted to flee before an examination.

Sue was livid by the whole ordeal. Know all too well that Angella was writing up reports; in most cases, when she has had incidents

with the foster kids, she knew the hospital was ragingly incompetent and would often dismiss them without ever seeing a doctor for minor injuries, but Angella didn't have it. This British pain in the ass was going to make a huge deal over this. It angered her, especially now that she had to get a taxi home, and Catra was given several packaged cookies from Angella.

Being discharged from the hospital was good for Sue, but Angella had to remain there with the painful facts that Sue was an abusive foster mother, and if she could hurt Catra, she must have hurt Adora. It bothered her all week.

A week later.

Exhausted from one of her overnight shifts, she went home to get some rest, but first, she showered and tried to go downstairs to her office. Micah was home to her surprise and was trying to keep her upstairs for something. She asked, "Darling, I'm tired, but I want to do some work in the office right now."

Micah sputtered, "Well, I wanna cuddle, and maybe we can…." He then whispered something provocative in her ear, and she flushed and sputtered, "W—well, since no one is home, I don't see why not."

Once he had her in the room, he occupied her until she fell asleep and immediately redressed and went downstairs to see George, Lance, and Jeff in the backyard with delivery guys for what his secret project was. "Hey, guys." He greeted. The three looked at him and asked, "Where have you been? We've been out here for almost half an hour trying to get this thing set up." Jeff asked and handed him a beer.

Micah opened it and apologized. "Sorry, Angella got home, and I needed to help her with her vitamins."

Lance questioned, "Vitamins?"

Micah smirked. "Yeah, vitamin *D."*

The guys all chuckled at that and went back to the assembly what Micah had bought. Then, finally, George asked, "Does Adora know you got her this?"

Micah shook his head. "No, and neither does Angella, that's why I want this to be a surprise. Adora always asks to go to the park, but we don't have time to drive out to one. So, we brought the park to her."

The four men finished it in record time. When Angella awoke from her nap, she went downstairs in her lingerie rope and silently down the stairs. She practically purred Micah's name, "Micah darling, before the girls get home shall we—BRAHHAAA" to her embarrassment, all the men were sitting in the kitchen having beers and saw her so sensual. She would never want to do

something in front of Micah's two gay best friends and his one hetero and frankly—*pig-minded one*. She instantly backed up and hid behind the corner wall.

Micah darted over to her with a massive grin on his face. "What was that, dear?"

Her face was redder than her robe as she hissed, "Why didn't you mention we were going to have company?"

He nervously chuckled. "Uh, surprise?"

Angella swatted his right forearm repetitively and growled, "I could fo been in a towel! My robe could have been undone!"

They awkwardly heard George remark, "If you feel any better, Lance has a robe just like that." All four men burst out into laughter, and Angella kept her glare on Micah as he stopped and went back into the kitchen. But not before poking back out of the kitchen entrance and telling her in a hushed tone, "Love you."

She groaned and went back upstairs to change and dreaded that she had to go back downstairs. She was covering the side of her face to avoid the gaze of three. Finally, Micah asked her to come into the backyard to show her something. She wasn't expecting much, but her eyes lit up when she saw the fully assembled children's playset through the screen doors. A yellow plastic slide,

two swings and attached monkey bars, and a climbing wall made Angella rush to see it. "My God! Look at this! It's so large, Micah!"

Micah then chuckled. "You like it?"

"Love it!" She proclaimed. "It's perfect for the children." She turned to him and smiled. "Adora is going to love this."

Micah smiled at his wife and kissed her cheek. "She's going to be so excited when she gets home."

The two heard Juliet's car pull into the driveway, and Micah took a hammer and handed it to Angella. "Hold this." He asked.

Angella looked confused by this and heard the kids come in. They heard Bow talk to his dads about the school, and they heard Glimmer's voice; Juliet's voice was heard as she told Adora to go into the backyard for a surprise. The two parents waited in excitement for Adora to come to the screen door. But, instead, they saw the blonde go into the kitchen and then saw her little eyes light up as she rushed to the screen door to open it.

Adora came into the backyard and gasped; Micah and Angella smiled at each other then opened their arms up. "Surprise!" they both pointed to the playset.

Adora was then followed by Glimmer and Bow, who both gasped.

Adora covered her mouth in shock.

Micah then proclaimed, "Adora! Pumpkin looks what mommy built you."

Angella was shocked about that lie. Looking at the hammer, she was asked to hold made her realize Micah had planned this. Making Adora believe that Angella did that would make Adora closer to Angella; the one thing Angella wanted more than anything was to earn Adora's love. Micah was willing to do that at the expense of him looking like the better parent. He smiled at her, and Angella looked at him and mouthed. I love you.

Adora rushed to her parents and looked at them. "I—is this for me?" she asked.

Micah smiled. "All for you, pumpkin; you and your sister and friends can play on it."

Adora looked to Angella. "It's a park in the backyard!"

Her little blue eyes and face showed how happy Adora was, and it melted Angella's heart. She kneeled to Adora. "Do you like it?"

Adora nodded and began to swivel on her heels a bit, and shyly nodded with a smile.

Angella spoke to her softly, "Daddy, and I wanted you to be happy and have this; we know you love the park, and now you can play every day now."

Adora extended her arms out hesitantly. "I—I like it."

Angella extended her hands out to "I'm glad sweetie, I love you."

Adora then rushed into her arms to embrace her. "I love you too, mommy!"

Angella held her tightly, trying to hold back tears as she looked up to Micah. It was the first time she ever said it to Angella. To say she loved her and call her mom was the most significant achievement Angella could have. This tiny moment was all she cared about; making Adora happy was all that mattered. She wanted to do anything for this little. She loved her, and she knew Adora loved her, and that was all that mattered now.

Forget Helping

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

After a long hot shower, Angella stayed in her room to get dressed. Sitting at her vanity to apply her makeup, she heard the loud thuds of her husband's feet coming up the stairs. He opened the door, and in a hushed tone, he showed Angella a picture on his phone. "Look." He practically squeaked when saying it. Angella looked and squeaked out an "Awwww!" when she saw it. Adora was sleeping on the couch with her doctor's jacket over her.

"Oh, my word! How precious! Did you put that on her?" Angella asked.

Micah shook his head. "No, she likes to wear your jacket when she thinks no one can see. It's so cute. I saw her do this yesterday, too."

Angella sat up and snuck downstairs with Micah to see if Adora was still sleeping. A new adjustment to her meds made her sleepier after dinnertime. Less tossing and turning at night and a new medication made some of her previous problems disappear. However, she was still very thirsty and needed some additional protection at night. Angella kneeled next to her and stroked the side of Adora's face until the little girl's eye fluttered open. "Mommy?" Adora asked. Hearing Adora calls her mommy was something she could never get tired of hearing her. Finally, Angella softly asked, "Do you want me to tuck you in before I go to work?"

Adora nodded and sat up. Angella held her hand out and brought her upstairs to Adora's bedroom. She was opening the room that was now more customized to Adora's interests. A My Little Pony wall banner near her bed was adjacent to a Spiderman and Spider Gwen banner of equal size. Her little fish lamp was on by her bedside. Angella picked out a pair of pajamas for Adora while the little girl undressed. She was placing Angella's jacket carefully on her bed. Angella went into her closet and took out a diaper for her. Although they never called them that. Angella referred to them as bedtime shorts so Adora would feel less embarrassed. Since the medication change, she still had at least two accidents a week. Angella handed it to Adora and saw the blonde frown at it. "I was good last night." Adora protested. Angella assured her, "Your good every night, pumpkin, but we need you to wear bedtime shorts in case you have an accident." Doing her best to be gentle over the whole situation. If Adora had it her way, she would have kept hiding it. If it wasn't for Angella addressing it to Adora in private about her bedwetting, she realized that Angella knew and wanted to help. She still cried when Angella told her she knew, but Angella promised her she wasn't in trouble, and her bedwetting would remain secret, and she didn't want Adora to feel bad over it.

Adora got on her bedtime shorts and pajamas while Angella turned, made sure her window was locked and took her jacket off the bed to tuck Adora in. Placing her toy monkey next to her and then covered it with her jacket. Then, with a soft peck on Adora's forehead, she told Adora she loved and her and went turned off the light to the bedroom.

Glimmer was in her bedroom with her pajamas on and waited for her mother to walk past the bedroom. Angella smirked when she saw how Glimmer was waiting eagerly for her to be tucked in. Angella teased, "Waiting for mommy, Glimmah?"

Glimmer then tried to play it off. "I know you like to tuck us in like we're babies. So, I'm going to let you."

Angella rolled her eyes. "Well, aren't you a sweet daughter, letting your mommy love you." She said, tucking her in and giving her several kisses on the cheek before turning the lights off and closing the door behind her.

Giving Micah several kisses before leaving for work, she drove the loathed forty-minute drive to Horde County Hospital. She was missing her Brightmoon hospital community and seeing as it was only fifteen minutes away from her house. She should be thankful they didn't send her to Etheria. That hospital was almost two hours away.

Settling into her wild night, she knew the city hospital had more issues than what she ever dealt with at Brightmoon. Horde County was a rougher town. Late nights had road rage accidents, assaults, and overdoses at night. In contrast, Brightmoon had the occasional late nightfall from a senior citizen or sick or injured person from one of the late-night warehouses on the shore.

Settling into her shift, she was happy to see Jillian was with her tonight. The peppy curly-haired blonde was always a delight to her. So peppy and cheery, she grew fond of working with her. Angella feared she ruined the kinship, so she tried to talk to her when the two were alone. In the breakroom, Angella made herself some tea while Jillian made coffee. Finally, Angella looked over at her and called, "Jillian, I must tell you something." Her

voice came off sterner than she had mentally planned for it, and Jillian looked at her attentively. "Yes, Dr. Brighton?"

Angella cleared her throat. "I must inform you that I'm not the easiest doctor to work under; I'm not easy to work with at all in some instances, but if I am to ever be rude or sharp with you—please know it isn't personal and It's not out of understanding your skills as a nurse."

Jillian looked a bit confused. "Are you saying sorry for something you haven't even done? Dr. Brighton, I appreciate your sentiments, but I'm a big girl. If I'm offended by something, I will speak with you privately. But trust me, it will take a lot more than a snippy remark to get under my skin. Hell, it will take more than snapping at anyone to break anyone here. Maybe at Brightmoon that happened, but not here."

Angella blinked. "Oh."

Jillian chuckled. "If you worried that you have to be nice to keep in everyone's good graces, forget that. This hospital needs a hardass professional to come in and get these people back into shape. Ever since the former doctor retired, they've all gone soft."

Angella questioned, "What was Dr. Burtch like?"

Jillian took a sip of her coffee. "Well, he was officer Burtch of the South County correctional facility for fifteen years before becoming a doctor. When you get threatened to be stabbed regularly, coming here to Horde Grove sounds so easy."

The two shared a brief smile, and Angella replied, "Thank you."

Jillian shrugged. "Hey, don't mention it. Unless it's to get H.R. for me to get a raise, have fun. Let's go back onto the floor and see whatever craziness has happened in fifteen minutes."

When they returned to the E.R. floor, they heard faint crying coming from a curtain in E.R. The faint whimpers turned to a screech of pain with louder crying when a C.N.A came out and informed the two, "We have a seven-year-old with significant cuts on her upper left forearm."

Angella went in to see her and saw the child sitting on the bed sobbing without any sign of stopping with blood dripping onto a blue hospital towel was Adora's best friend from the foster home.

Catra was right there in front of her, with Sue sitting on a chair next to her. The musty smell of recently lit cigarette was on Sue's breath as she explained, "Catra was playing downstairs when no one was looking and ran into the breakfast hutch and hurt

herself." She turned to Catra, "Isn't that right?" asking the child to agree with her.

Catra nodded and whimpered. "I was being bad again."

Angella wasn't sure what she was looking at. Nothing about this seemed right; she remembered seeing that breakfast hutch when visiting Adora beofre the adoption was finalized and couldn't imagine Catra getting hurt by it. If it fell on her or she was thrown into it, that would make sense, but seeing the injuries to her forearm and how tender it was to the touch made her believe something more sinister was at bay. Looking at Sue through the corner of her eyes made her confident Sue was lying and making Catra lie for her. Jillian was behind Angella, and the doctor asked her, "Get her vitals while I speak with her foster mother."

Sue looked at Catra before getting up to speak with Angella from the other side of the curtain. Jillian had instructed Catra to get into a hospital gown and examine her. Vitals were fine, but the bruises around Catra's legs, torso, arms, and neck are suspicious. Even a hyper child wouldn't have been able to create all these herself with trivial playing and mischief.

Angella asked Sue, "Explain how exactly this happened to her."

Sue narrowed her eyes. "I told you she was running around, and the hutch fell on her."

Angella questioned, "It is such a big hutch; I find it odd how it fell on her."

Sue scoffed, "You don't know Catra; the girl can find anything way imaginable to get hurt."

Jillian signaled for Angella to come back into the room. Angella put her hand out to Sue and told her to remain outside while speaking with her nurse.

Jillian had Catra's clothes in hand showed Angella a shard of brown glass she had found. They were making sure not to startle or alert Catra of anything. Finally, Jillian whispered, "This is beer bottle glass."

Angella's eyes went wide, and she softly replied, "Make a call." A code phrase for calling the police on their floor.

Jillian left with Catra's clothes in hand, and Sue went in and demanded, "What is she doing with her clothes?" A visible sign of panic in her face showed her worry for the truth to come out.

Angella informed, "She's putting her clothes in a bag; we need to run more tests on Catra before we release her."

Sue assured Angella, "She just needs stitches and bandaids; no more tests are needed; Catra hates the doctor's office." Then, Sue

narrowed her eyes to Catra. The little girl looked down to her lap. Angella's eyes narrowed back to her, and she reminded Sue, "She is getting the medical care she needs beofre she is released. She's a child, and these injuries shouldn't be taken with such flippant regards."

She left the room again and thought about how much Adora must have seen and gone through. Angella was no stranger to abuse as a child. Neither was Micah; she knew this wasn't an accident caused by a kid being too hyper.

Sue went out to smoke. The stress Angella was putting her through made her only think of herself and what she needed to do to get the edge off.

When Sue left, she slipped back into Catra's room. Her phone in her pocket recorded the conversation she tried to have with her.

"Catra?" Angella called to her, "Would you like a cookie and some milk?"

Catra instantly perked up. "Can I have chocolate milk?" she asked.

Angella nodded. "Of course, honey, anything."

Jillian heard what Angella had offered, and as Angella left the room to get it, Jillian told her she would get it for her. Angella

kept her eye out for Sue, and when Jillian returned, she gave the snacks to Catra and asked her, "Do you still feel hurt?"

Catra nodded. "A little."

Angella asked, "Do you get hurt easily?"

Catra shrugged and took a bite of her cookie. "Sometimes."

Angella pressed on, "Sue is often around when you get hurt, right?"

Catra didn't know how to answer that question. She froze when Angella asked, unsure whether she would say yes or no. She was always trained on what to say for some questions from a young age. She knew she could never tell a social worker. Sue leaves to go to the store on her own sometimes and leaves the kids in the house alone. She can never say the teenagers are mean unless she wants to be locked in the basement. She knows Sue would want her to do something that made her sound good. She would be rewarded if she said the right things, just like at the temple. If she says the right things in front of people, Sue would be friendly and stay nice for the whole day. For Catra, this was precious and worth lying to keep. After all, if she didn't have Sue, she would be forced to go to a group home and get beaten and starved.

"Sue is a good foster mommy. She takes care of me when I get boo-boos, and I like to play, and sometimes when I play, I make

mistakes and get hurt, and Sue takes care of me."

Catra saw Angella's reaction wasn't a happy one—as if knowingly lying to a doctor would somehow make Angella unhappy. Catra didn't like the feeling; despite being an energetic child, she never really liked it when adults were unhappy with her.

Angella sighed and softly told her, "Catra, I'm a doctor, and I'm here to take care of you and protect you; if anything is going on, you can tell me, and I will make sure you're safe."

Catra looked down, unsure of what to say to this. Sue can be mean sometimes. She didn't like getting hit or yelled at by Sue or other kids; she didn't like that the showers were cold or that the house was sometimes really hot or cold. The smoking smell was gross, and she was usually always hungry. She wondered if she told Angella this, she would take her to live with Adora. She told the doctor that Sue shoved her into the dining hutch, and the glass from the door shattered and fell on her. If she told her, Sue hit her after it happened and didn't stop until she realized the little girl was bleeding. Maybe Angella could tell Sue to stop it? Maybe she could tell Sue to be kinder?

The curtains opened, and in came to nurse Jillian to tell Angella, "Doctor, may I speak with you?"

Angella turned to Jillian and sat up, giving Catra a warm smile beofre leaving. "I'll come back soon, and I'll bring you another snack."

She saw the police officer she asked Jillian to call for behind the curtain. Her demeanor was calm as she spoke to the office. "Thank you for coming……."

One Week Later

Catra liked the extra attention she was getting from Sue after she hurt her. But this time she had with Sue being friendly was rare, and she was taking it for all it was worth. Every time a social worker came over, Catra made it a point to be overly affectionate with Sue. She asked for hugs, sat closely, talking more when other adults were around. Sue hated it for all it was. Ever since Angella accused her of abuse, more social worker visits have been assigned to Sue, and now more kids in foster care were being moved along for adoption. Lonnie just received news that a family in Horde Grove would adopt her, and Kyle's biological father wanted custody of him now. Rogelio was placed in another foster home better suited for his special needs. In only a few more months, Sue was going to be down three kids and almost two-thousand dollars in childcare checks. All thanks to Angella's accusation—she couldn't even deny it to herself that she was always playing a dangerous tight rope with this foster mother routine. It's been tested before with teens claiming abuse and neglect, but the State was too busy and never had enough evidence to have Sue considered an unfit foster parent. Too many children were in foster care, and even more, were wards to the State in various other programs; having one more minor foster parent in the system could be a death wish for these kids, and

Sue knew she was valued in that regard. She knew if she wanted to get Angella off her case, she would need to throw her off by force. She didn't fear the doctor—she could see through her stern intellectual demeanor, and she could see a coward to confrontation behind the white coat and BMW.

For now, Angella was in control, making her presence known by insisting on a playdate between the two children ever since the incident at the hospital. But, unfortunately, her best social worker friend, John Hordak, was not on her side to her dismay. Instead, the two smoked in the backyard while the kids were inside.

Sue took a drag from her cigarette. "What the hell am I going to do with her now? That woman thinks she can stroll on in here now just because Catra had a couple of bruises."

Hordak didn't bother to look at her and explained, "We both know it's more than a few bruises, and we both know that Dr. whatshername and her lawyer husband have much greater pull than us. If your smart, you'll place nice and not try to with them."

Sue glared at him. "I don't want her getting my kids taken away." Her fear was not grounded in the dread of losing them. She didn't care for them, but she did need the money. Without her childcare checks, she would be jobless and without anything.

Hordak calmed her, "You know the foster parent shortage is too large for the State to take all six of them and leave. Once the smaller kids are gone, you'll get more teenagers—the only issue being is Catra. Either she'll have her room, or you'll need to

convert that basement into something because the State won't give you anyone under fourteen, and not even the most careless judge in the county would allow you to room a seven-year-old with teenage girls."

Sue rolled her eyes. "As soon as money falls out of my ass, that won't be an issue."

Hordak then asked a question he has always wanted to ask for years "Why have you kept on to her for so long and not adopted her. You want Carlotta to be yours." He never called the child by her nickname. He had known Sue and Catra since Catra was a baby. Sue's reasoning for keeping Catra was odd but newsworthy. Sue's best friend died in childbirth, and Sue decided to be the legal guardian of Catra until the family came for her. The deceased mother had distant relatives that were deemed unable to care for an infant, and the father was unknown. A suspected deadbeat may live in town, but no other details came about it. Sue knew who the father was and stubbornly refused to tell him about her—not wanting Catra to be taken from her. In truth, her desire to keep her around was entirely selfish. She wanted something to remember her friend and wanted a child to raise in her family home. Before Sue's parents died, they left her the family home due to Sue caring for the baby but the cost of being a foster parent. Her time was taken up all by children thanks to Catra, and it didn't help that Catra was a sickly baby and needy toddler. Her love for the child faded quickly when the work became more complex, and she grew more fond of the well-mannered children she cared for. Sadly every time she grew to love a baby, toddler, child, or teenager—they would be adopted out.

Always leaving her with Catra and made her harsher to the minor child than any other person in her home at any given time. Justfibly it would be better for Catra to go with another person—but Sue did care in some capacity and knew that Catra being sent to a group home would be bad for her. She had made the decision when Catra was only two to keep her until she aged out of the system.

Sue replied, "I'm not heartless, John, I don't want to ruin the kid's life before it even begins, and you know being in a group home would do that."

"Not every group home is run by monsters, Sue." John Hordak corrected, "Some facilities are well cared for."

Sue then replied, "Yes, but as for Horde Grove, there is nothing good here. Ship her off to Brightmoon county, and she'll be in the clear, but throw her in a Horde Grove group home, and she'll have a face tattoo and a felony by age nine."

It was going to be a challenge now. She would either lose monthly income by not taking in more kids or be stuck with a massive bill if she needed to renovate her basement. It's not like she has friends in high places. Then it occurred to her; the only person in any position to get her some help would be the last person in the world she'd want to talk to.

Sue questioned, "You think Angella Brighton would grace us with her savior complex and stir up some donations on our behalf?"

John Hordak grinned. "Rumor has it her husband sold his business, right now, those two have so much money they wouldn't even know what to do with it."

Sue chuckled. "Looks, I need to make a phone call for a playdate."

One Week later

Angella smiled at Adora from the driver's seat of the car. The blonde was practically bouncing as they drove to see Sue and Catra. The older woman had finally agreed to a playdate between the two, which relieved Angella since she was afraid that after the police incident, Sue would avoid her. Instead, Sue called her and insisted Catra was exemplary and showed her how great things were for her and Adora to come over for a playdate.

When the two girls reunited, it was so sweet to see them rush to each other to hug and let out childish squeals of happiness. Then, the two ran to the backyard to play. She was leaving Angella and Sue to talk awkwardly. Sue made it to smoke in front of Angella to show dominance, knowing Angella would be too polite to ask her not to. She was even going to refer to her as Angella and not Dr. Brighton. Watching the two little girls play was nothing special for Sue. But, for Angella, this was special, and Sue knew that Angella's guard was down enough to say this and make an impact on her "I hope they don't make me lose her."

Angella turned to her with confusion. "I'm sorry, I'm not sure what that means."

Sue took another drag and explained, "Three of my youngest have been adopted out, and a fourth is getting adopted out too—they want me to place four teenage girls and two teenage boys now. I have a four-bedroom home. Four girls in one room were bad enough with children—let alone teens. The boys I have now share a room with two teenagers already, and when those boys leave, the other teens will come in their place, but I was advised that Catra shouldn't be in that room with the teenage girls. It wouldn't be fair for her to have her room. Most likely, I will need to split the girls up between rooms, and Catra might need to be rehoused. It would break my heart to let her go."

Angella didn't know how to take this. Just as an adoptive parent, she knew the trouble children in the foster system went under. Adora would have suffered if Angella didn't step in, and that only led Angella to one conclusion "I'll adopt Catra."

Sue's face dropped.

Not wanting to be the natural reaction to her situation, she flipped the script by blurting a blatant lie. "I want to adopt Catra; I've wanted to ever since I took her home from the hospital." A somewhat lie. She had just lost her best friend/long-time girlfriend. Catra's mother and Sue were quietly in a ten-year relationship as two bachelorettes working in the private school sector. One day Camilia came to Sue with the news that she had been unfaithful to her. After a short time apart, Sue accepted her

back and supported her throughout the pregnancy as the child's father couldn't be bothered since he was off trying to make a better life for himself. When Camila died, Sue kept Catra hoping that a child would bring happiness. In the end, it brought her misery as she failed at having maternal instincts and ended being a foster parent for financial reasons over an actual desire for loving kids.

Angella didn't pry and asked the generous and kind question Sue longed for this entire visit.

"How can I help?" Angella asked.

Five months later

Angella fought and stressed along with Micah for this project. She was getting Sue money to convert her basement into two bedrooms to house more kids and adopt Catra. This extensive plan had them phoning in every connection in good faith they had for this. In the end, Angella was more disappointed that long-time friends from the country club had no interest in donating. Instead, Jillian and Hannah stepped in and used friends they made in the hospitals and the public schools to donate. In record time, the project was done, and Sue had her renovations paid for in full, and she had needed space. Now the last order of business was adoption, which led to a significant conflict.

Angella sat across from Sue and slammed her hands down on the table, surprising Micah and the social worker Hordak. "What do you mean you want us to stay away from you now! After all,

we've done? All we ever asked was for you not to keep Catra and Adora apart, and you've now made this into a selfish accusation that I am interfering with your ability to foster?"

This wasn't some tiny meeting. This meeting was Sue taking to Angella to court for harassment.

After all the family's help, she turned around and called child services on Angella, claiming she was taking too much interest in catra and wanted it to stop.

Angella exclaimed, "So now that this is all said and done, you want to keep them apart. These are little girls; how could you be so cruel?"

Sue looked over to the judge; since this wasn't a crime or significant dispute, he was not in his judge robes and was only in a suit like Micah and Hordak, but he looked just as uncomfortable as Micah was. This was no courtroom either, and it was an office in the courthouse. This matter was a negotiation, and the judge did have to rule on this matter in this situation.

"I see no grounds of harassment. Susan Jane Weaver," he looked directly into Sue's eyes "As the legal guardian to Carlotta Flores; you have the right to decide who the child is associated with and visits with. All communication—" he slid a folder to Sue that Micah had brought in "All evidence shows all contact was not unprecedented. Therefore, I will not order a restatement on Dr. Angella Claire Brighton."

Sue's face looked upset, but she held her tongue as Hordak darted her look that screamed for her to keep her mouth shut.

He turned to Angella next to explain. "Your charity work with Sue does not grant you access to the property or her wards; as much as the project offered to her was generous, she is now the legal mother of Carlotta and can deny visitations. So, moving forward, I would suggest neither of you two contacts each other."

The motion was dismissed, and Angella left with her husband in a hurry, leaving Hordak to be with Sue for a long car ride home. "You know you just burned a major bridge; just because the judge didn't make you place nice with Angella doesn't mean you still don't look like an ass for doing this." He reminded her.

Sue shrugged and kept her eyes on the road. "I may not look so innocent and kind for what I did, but I have my reasons."

Hordak asked, "What is your reason for pissing off a doctor—lawyer power couple that just raised 15,000 dollars for you?"

Sue narrowed her eyes. "I won't be under anyone's control. I'm not Angella's savior project, and I'm far from submissive. That woman was ready to put me behind bars with her abuse accusation months ago—I don't need her playing hero and getting my only source of income taken away."

Hordak replied, "Your far from a good foster parent—let's be honest for a moment, Sue, and take in all the times you and I both should have been thrown in jail. But, unfortunately, there aren't enough social workers and foster parents in the State to care for all the kids. So some kids are better off with their dysfunctional families sometimes while others are better off with fosters or group homes; all I know is our dedication isn't without flaws." He glanced at Sue to finish his words "Although I don't understand your methods, I can only somewhat your reason to have Catra as your daughter. After all, this time, might as well, right?"

Sue paused and took that statement for what it meant to her. Angella and Sue were not that far in age. Sue was older, but she was nowhere near Angella's success, beauty, and happiness for her age. Angella was a doctor, and that title alone brought a status Sue couldn't compare to; just the fact that Angella was a mother and wife was more than what Sue had ever had for herself. To see someone like Dr. Brighton become her allies in a time of begging was no more than agony for Sue. Even though she successfully played Angella, she still had to admit that Angella was still a far better person than her. Sue sighed. "Might as well." She replied.

She never truly wanted Catra, but now she had her. She could do the right thing and love and cherish her the way all the other children were being when they got adopted out, instead Sue still hasn't even told Catra why her last name is now Weaver instead of Flores. If Angella had it her way, it would have been Brighton, but why should Catra have this glorious life away from Sue. If it weren't for her being born, she would have still had her soulmate, and they would have been living on easy street. She was not living in her old childhood home with no real job except being a glorified babysitter for others.

Sue then felt the guilt and jealousy of her actions and only responded with an additional "Might as well."

Chapter End Notes

It's a bitter ending.

After Angella was wronged by Sue, she kept her word and didn't bother her. As for Adora, Angella did everything to set Adora up with playdates to make new friends and slowly in time forget about Catra. Sadly Catra grew to feel this was her being forgotten as Sue always made her feel she did something wrong.

End Notes

Art for this series is done by Not-So-Average-Fangirl on Twitter.

Please check out their work at:

https://twitter.com/notsoavgfangirl/status/1315827112696143877?s=20

Illustration for the first chapter is this link:https://twitter.com/notsoavgfangirl/status/1315827112696143877/photo/1

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